



gamechanger

max sebastian

Game Changer

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PUBLISHING

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Excerpt first published as 'High Stakes' within [Best Hotwife Erotica Volume 4: Games of Chance](#), Edited by Ben Boswell

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Contents

[Author's Note](#)

[Part One: High Stakes](#)

[Chapter One](#)

[Chapter Two](#)

[Chapter Three](#)

[Chapter Four](#)

[Chapter Five](#)

[Chapter Six](#)

[Chapter Seven](#)

[Chapter Eight](#)

[Part Two: Dealer's Choice](#)

[Chapter Nine](#)

[Chapter Ten](#)

[Chapter Eleven](#)

[Chapter Twelve](#)

[Chapter Thirteen](#)

[Chapter Fourteen](#)

[Chapter Fifteen](#)

[Chapter Sixteen](#)

[Chapter Seventeen](#)

[Chapter Eighteen](#)

[Chapter Nineteen](#)

[Chapter Twenty](#)

[Chapter Twenty-One](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Two](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Three](#)

[Part Three: All In](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Four](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Five](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Six](#)

[About the Author](#)

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[Also by Max Sebastian](#)

Author's Note

Some readers may have dipped into the first part of this story through an excerpt published at the end of January within the anthology [Best Hotwife Erotica Volume 4: Games of Chance](#) as edited by Ben Boswell. That excerpt was a shortened version of the first eight chapters of this novel, so for those impatient to pick up the rest of the story, you could just skip to chapter nine. In this full version of the novel you get a third extra content in that first part of the story, and then the rest of the twenty-six chapters charting the whole story.

Even if you have a full version of 'Game Changer' in your hands right now, I'd still heartily recommend you grab a copy of Best Hotwife Erotica Volume 4, by the way. In it there are hotwife stories by the fantastic Arnica Butler, Ben Boswell and Kirsten McCurran, as well as subgenre legend Kenny Wright.

'Game Changer' stemmed from Ben's call for BHE Volume 4 to focus on stories about games of chance that lead to the sharing of wives. As ever, as a writer I'm fairly terrible at limiting myself to a few thousand words for the benefit of putting out a short story — I usually want to see what happens after the events contained within a short, which is one hallmark of a good short, and as the writer I don't have to stop if I don't want to.

As you'll see in this story, what happens when a tale of hotwife action is allowed to continue can lead into unexpected directions, very much in the same way that the opening up of a relationship in real life can also take turns unforeseen at the start.

Anyway, I'd like to thank Ben for getting me into this story in the first place, along with Kenny for his thoughts along the way. I'd also like to add my undying gratitude to my circle of invaluable beta-readers for their input—Anjali, Dan, Nick and Robert.

Thanks, also, to you, Dear Reader, without whom none of this would be possible.

Max Sebastian

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Part One: **High Stakes**

Chapter One

You could totally blame it on climate change. Unless you're one of those out-and-out whack jobs that denies what every scientist not on an oil company's payroll says about climate change.

'You're kidding me.'

'Is closed.'

Here we were, the four of us, stuck in the middle of the Slovakian Alps in clunky boots not made for walking, all clutching ski poles and skis optimistically as the rain kept on falling.

'But it's going to open later, right? I mean, when the rain clears up.'

'No. Is closed. No snow.'

'But up there, at the top, there's got to be some, right?'

'No. No snow. Is closed.'

Jake was leading the negotiations with the one guy we'd found in the whole place who seemed to speak a word of English. And he really didn't speak much more than a word. Jake was kind of our host, but also the one of us who had more language skills than just elementary high school Spanish. However, here, Spanish was as alien to them as iced hazelnut macchiato or broadband internet—and German was downright frowned upon.

All he could do was speak slowly and loudly in English, 'You think it might open tomorrow? Thursday? The weekend?'

And the old man, with the even older cigarette hanging off his lip, merely shrugged and repeated his entire English vocabulary back at us:

'No. Is closed. No snow.'

That was the extent of our interaction with the locals our whole week there. After our attempt at communication, we trudged back to the chalet, past bars and restaurants and even grocery stores that were all closed like the ski lift, past houses and chalets that were equally lifeless, windows darkened or even boarded up.

'When you booked this, you did look to see if they ever have snow in these mountains?' Hanna asked Jake, and it wasn't the first time the question had been put to him since we had dismounted the decrepit weekly airport shuttle bus the day before, only to discover green grass and mud all around us instead of dreamy white snow.

But we couldn't spend the whole time blaming Jake. We'd all done our little bit of Internet research on the beautiful Slovakian Alps before

agreeing to Jake's suggestion of a low-low-low-price ski vacation to Europe. The year before, they'd had plenty of snow here.

There was one grocery store in the whole town we'd discovered open, though the three aisles of mostly canned goods hardly offered us the most diverse menu to cook up once we got back to the chalet that was to be our prison cell for a whole week. There were pistachio nuts and some kind of licorice-like substance to snack on. At least we wouldn't starve.

The first couple of days, it proved something of an activity for us to try and come up with some kind of recipes with which to keep ourselves fed all week without getting sick.

There were precious few other activities available to help us pass the time until the goddamn airport shuttle bus returned. Conversation only went so far. Television was all in Slovakian, and mostly seemed to involve either news broadcasts or documentaries about mountain goats. Internet was supposedly available as dial-up, but we all came bearing smart phones and tablets, nothing that could even conceive of needing to connect to anything as Stone Age as dial-up.

Anyway, you get the picture. There wasn't even a pen and paper on which to doodle.

We spent the first day cleaning up the chalet, we were so starved of anything to do. Hayden found a single solitary pack of cards in a tiny drawer in the writing table hidden down in the basement, and that just about took care of Day 2 even though there were no kings in the whole deck.

Day 3: after waking up and spending a leisurely two hours munching on Slovakian corn flakes and milk, while attempting to crack jokes about how terrible the local TV was, that lonely pack of cards really did not appeal any longer.

'We could go for a walk,' my wife, Hanna, suggested with a half-hearted attempt to sound bright and cheery.

We all looked to the windows, and what view there was, which was blurred there was so much rain streaming down the glass.

'We could sing some songs.'

Well, that just prompted laughter, even from Hanna.

Of course in years gone by, we would have simply bought a crate or three of the local plonk and worked our way through it. Even the lethal-looking local Borovička— something not unlike gin except with a much higher alcohol content—seemed enticing while we had strolled

around the grocery store. But Hayden had been to rehab, and we all had to respect that. There would be no drinking the week away.

‘It’s okay for you guys,’ Hayden complained, his big, dark eyes flicking between Hanna and me. ‘It’s not like you’re short of stuff to do.’

‘What are you talking about?’ I asked him, baffled as to what he was referring.

‘Well you’ve got... each other... right?’

Hanna and I looked at one another as though Hayden was talking in some other language and neither of us could untangle a word of what he was saying.

‘What?’ Hanna said.

‘Well... you can... you know... spend the whole day in bed,’ he explained, and I think he was blushing, though it was difficult to discern because of his skin pigmentation.

‘Huh?’

Hanna and I really weren’t stupid, I’d just add. We’d been married seven years, that’s all. Jake watched on from the sidelines, amused at us apparently teasing Hayden with our lack of comprehension of what he was suggesting. The way we forced him to explicitly state exactly what he meant:

‘You two can just spend the whole week fucking.’

Hanna and I looked at each other in silence, somewhat stunned at that idea. I didn’t even feel a flicker of stiffening down below. Oh, it wasn’t that I didn’t find Hanna attractive anymore. Even on this trip—where she’d gone for the bare minimum effort look—simple T-shirt and leggings with her long, dark hair tied up in a high, messy ponytail and her face free of makeup, she was still unquestionably delicious. As I said, we’d been married a while. We had sex whenever one or the other of us needed it, perhaps a once-a-week thing. Ten minutes each time. Not a big deal. We satisfied each other, but we took shortcuts to satisfaction. And to be honest, we probably couldn’t remember the long way anymore.

The thought of spending a whole week—or even five days or whatever we had left—doing nothing but making love... well, it was as inconceivable to us as it probably was to Jake and Hayden.

‘But that wouldn’t be fair to you guys,’ Hanna said after a long, awkward pause.

‘Sure it would,’ Jake shrugged, a mischievous smirk spread across his face. ‘At least somebody here would have something to do.’

Hayden laughed, ‘And at least the rest of us would have something to listen to.’

‘Ohhhh... seriously?’ Hanna and I said as one, while Jake just laughed.

After that the four of us had lounged around the central room of the chalet in virtual silence, the battered, old, only-just-color TV blaring in the corner. With a dejected sigh, Jake had picked up the cards and started playing Solitaire with himself. Hayden sat on the window seat gazing out at the rain splattering over the rooftops stepping down the mountainside in front of us. Hanna and I were sat on either corner of the large couch, attempting to look as though we really were watching TV.

Maybe half an hour after our awkward conversation, I caught Hanna giving me a strange look.

‘What?’ I said silently.

She flicked her big, smoky green eyes over toward the kitchen, and I flashed her a confused look. Did she want to start on lunch? It was hardly even ten o’clock yet. I doubled-down on my confused look. What was she saying? She flicked her whole head over toward the kitchen... and I saw she was looking toward the stairs that went up to the bedrooms.

I raised an eyebrow, and half a smile. Was she thinking about doing exactly what Hayden had suggested half an hour before?

She blushed and flicked her dark hair out of her face as though to distract anyone from the sight of her being a little flustered, maybe a little embarrassed. But then she looked at me directly and shrugged, as though to say: Why not? What else have we got to do?

Along with her blue leggings, she was wearing a yellow t-shirt and no bra, since she hadn’t really been expecting on going out or doing anything much that day, certainly not anything that would cause her nipples to get as hard and obvious as they were right now.

Was she really thinking about standing up and leading me out to the bedroom, to fuck me while our two friends sat around this place, only yards away, bored out of their skulls? Hayden had been absolutely right to say that if we did do anything, they’d be able to sit here and listen—this chalet was not large, and the walls were not thick.

I gave her a nod toward Hayden and another toward Jake as though I needed to remind her that the guys were right here. She looked directly into my eyes, blushing fiercely, but shrugged as though to say ‘Who cares?’ At least we’d have something to do.

I have to say, despite the fact that I often overlooked my wife’s beauty—because of the familiarity of spending so much time together over the years—just then the strange prospect of going upstairs to fuck,

with our two friends knowing exactly what we were doing, and Hanna wanting to go ahead and do it anyway, had me warming up immensely, my manhood thickening up within my jeans.

I was, I'll add, a little nervous, because Hanna and I were used to the ten-minute quickie, and if we knew that Hayden and Jake would be sitting here listening to us do it, we'd probably feel pressure to extend our play time, to try to make it seem as though mammoth sex sessions were the normal state of our relationship these days.

So for a little while I did pretend to be ignorant of what Hanna was suggesting, making her spell it out with nods toward the bedrooms, with glances at my crotch, with cupping of her breasts and even tweaking of her nipples when she thought the other guys weren't looking.

Finally she whispered, 'Come on...'

And as Hayden and Jake looked over to see what was going on in our world, I chuckled as though to play it all down, to get those guys to relax and not wonder what we were doing, so we could somehow sneak upstairs and fuck without them knowing exactly what we were doing.

Hanna huffed and folded her arms in front of her chest, saying my name somewhat testily.

Now Hayden and Jake were looking our way, and no one in the room could be under any pretenses about what Hanna wanted right now, and what I was going to have to do. Hayden laughed quietly, as though he'd been well and truly proven right.

Jake said, 'If you two want us to... get out of here for a while... you know, we can.'

I'm not sure if he felt guilt as our host, the guy who had invited us on this trip, who had sold us on the idea of an affordable European getaway to a very out-of-the-way ski resort where we'd have the space to shoot down mountainsides without worrying about trains of toddlers learning to ski or jagged rocks waiting to slice us up on the way down.

'No,' Hanna said, her blush intensifying, which somehow appealed to me. 'You shouldn't have to go out there in that...'

'We could go down to the store again—see if they've had a fresh shipment of really watery, gray canned peas,' Jake said.

'No,' Hanna said, but now she was standing up, and to my surprise seemed to be stepping over to me as though she really was serious about going through with this. 'You guys just stay here... we'll make sure to keep the noise down.'

I was a little horrified, to be honest, at my friends from college knowing I was about to walk upstairs and just have sex right then and

there. I mean, sure, we'd been roommates at times where we'd probably had sex while the others were around, in apartments that were smaller than even this compact chalet. But we were mature now, sober, the last of our circle who didn't yet have kids. And Hanna wasn't just some dippy college girl who didn't mean anything to anyone, she was my wife.

I looked over at Hayden, and he gave me a big nod, looking at me with envy but also approval. As though if I could get this done, I'd be scoring one for the team. Jake gave me a similar nod of endorsement.

He said, 'Maybe there'll be somebody attractive at the checkout in the store today.'

And Hayden joked in reply, 'Hey, you're welcome to him. I am not going out in that, whatever.'

I don't know. Jake was giving him a fairly assertive look that said we are going to go out and give these guys some private time, no matter what. But Hayden was not a pushover, he was as strong-willed as anyone we knew. Hanna led me out of there as though we were sneaking away from a battlefield, I guess at least it made me feel like we weren't quite so noticeable on the way to the stairs, even though we totally were.

I felt a mixture of mild excitement and trepidation as I followed Hanna up the narrow wooden staircase and along the small hallway to our little bedroom. Inside, she didn't even wait for me to close the door before she was peeling her t-shirt off, and whipping her leggings off to reveal a fairly ordinary pair of no-frills white panties.

Chapter Two

Hanna's quick stripping had become a firm part of our usual abbreviated sex sessions at home, since it was pragmatic and efficient and genuinely cut to the chase. With hindsight, I'd have responded much better to slowly pulling her clothes off myself, prolonging the tease, but I didn't really know that at the time, and this was what we were used to.

Efficient. Quick.

Honestly, I was turned on by her hunger, her need, her drive. The pink flush in her cheeks, the slight sheen of perspiration on her forehead, her deep breathing, the large size of her pupils. But somehow, the pressure to perform with friends listening and a highly expectant wife... it didn't bode well.

'Come on,' Hanna said, laying down on the bed, pulling the covers over her naked body. Such was the extent of her dirty talk.

I pulled off my clothes as sullen as though I was being punished for something I hadn't done. I knew what was coming.

'Seriously?' she said as I lay next to her, and her fingers curled around a soft cock.

'They're listening,' I pointed out, as though she needed to be reminded of that fact, and as though this was a perfectly valid reason to fail to get hard when called upon.

'So now is the moment you think it's a good time for... this?' she said, as though I had any choice in the matter of erectile problems. Oh, it had happened before, when I was particularly tired, or stressed, or when I had Hanna brandishing plastic swabs or digital instruments declaring that she was at the peak of her fertility. I wouldn't say it was a frequent thing, but it certainly had happened over the years in difficult times.

'Is this going to happen all week?' she scowled, making me feel I'd betrayed her, ruining her carefully-drawn plans for the rest of the week.

'No, not at all,' I insisted. 'You know... maybe... at night...'

She sighed. 'So what are we going to do all day, every day, for the rest of the week?'

We just lay there side by side, naked, and I'll say to any single guys out there, she did look good. She was just too familiar for me, and maybe I was no longer quite the twenty-something, immune to the effects of performance stress, as when she and I had met.

‘It’s hardly fair to the guys, anyway,’ I said. ‘Keeping to ourselves, shutting ourselves in our bedroom all week.’

She said, ‘Perks of marriage, right? Maybe they should have done more to hold down a relationship for longer.’

Hardly fair, but then she wasn’t in the mood to be fair.

She started touching herself, almost spitefully, but it was probably the most foreplay we’d shared in years. A little counseling may have helped, pointing out our need to slow things down, reduce the pressure, take time to just enjoy each other without the furious need to reach climax as quickly as possible.

I did start responding mildly to the sight of her laying there stroking her pussy as though this was all she could expect this week. I felt the warm, blissful arousal kick up a notch between my legs, though it wasn’t quite enough to stir my terrified cock. For a while I just watched her, trying to think hot thoughts, hoping my mild thrill at her masturbation might eventually explode into a firm erection once I was sufficiently relaxed and in the right mindset. It wasn’t happening, though.

And then she let fly with a very casual, flippant remark—more of a joke, really.

‘Maybe I should go see if Hayden or Jake could come finish the job?’

And suddenly, as if a switch had flipped, there I was, lying there, hard as a rock, my swollen manhood bobbing and swaying slightly in time to my heart rate.

Hanna gasped.

‘Holy f—’ she said, grasping it in her nearest hand as though to test whether she was imagining things. ‘Where did that come from?’

I protested, ‘You’re lying there, right in front of me, touching yourself.’

But she shook her head. ‘Uh-uh. I was doing that for a while... and no joy. Then suddenly... blam!’

She rolled onto her front, and then pushed herself up to kneel beside me, her hand closing around my thick rod once again as she resumed pumping it, apparently amazed at what she held in her hands.

‘There wasn’t some sudden drop in your stress levels,’ she said, almost cooed. Suddenly happy now, ecstatic. Thinking to herself that this was how the rest of the week would be. Husband with a hard-on. Her mental predictions were really based on very little data. Extrapolated from whatever was going on right now, in the moment.

‘No, there wasn’t...’ I agreed.

‘You didn’t pop a pill while I wasn’t looking.’

‘Nope.’

‘Mmmm....’ She beamed, from ear to ear, as she used both hands on me, pumping me and pulling on me as though a little rough play would test just how stable my erection was. ‘Were you thinking of something hot?’ she asked. ‘Something you’ve watched some time...’

‘I don’t... think so...’

‘God... look at that thing...’ she said, awestruck. ‘Big... fucking... hard... cock...’

She straddled me, still pumping on my manhood with two hands, still cooing over it, amazed.

‘I was just lying there,’ she said, still apparently trying to figure this all out, because she’d been married to me so long there was no way I had anything left that was unexpected for her, that she couldn’t predict. ‘I was lying there... stroking myself... my *pussy*...’

She didn’t use words like that usually. It was hot. Unexpected. But not quite the same impact as when she’d said what she’d said.

And then she said it again: ‘I was just warning you that if you didn’t... get hard for me... I’d have to go... get Hayden... or Jake...’

And that was when she squealed, and I knew she was feeling my cock throbbing in her hands, maybe even bucking a little. I felt a little heat, a surge of something wet rise through my shaft, and was almost certain that she’d made me come, just with her hands. That she’d be disappointed with me, that it was all over already and I hadn’t even been inside her.

But she squealed again with delight, and my hardness was not evaporating, and when she held up a hand to show me, it wasn’t streaked with white come. It was pre-come, which she now used as a lubricant as she continued stroking my cock.

‘You *liked* that...’ she breathed. ‘Didn’t you?’

I just lay there, taking it.

She went on, ‘You liked the thought of me going down there... maybe asking Hayden... or Jake... to fuck me instead...’

I couldn’t help it. I was just so hard for her. Thinking about her going downstairs to fetch Hayden. The thought of his powerful African-American frame laying between her thighs, taking her. Even the thought of Jake, a fairly average white guy like myself, joining my wife naked on the bed made my pulse race and my cock stiffen up like a two-by-four.

‘You know you’d have to sit outside while I fucked them,’ she said, casually as though she was planning the arrangements, ‘and of course in

this chalet you'd probably be able to hear everything...'

'Stop... stop...' I pleaded, feeling myself beginning to go, my come so very close to being triggered—and we weren't trying for a baby here, the whole point was to pass the time, and for me personally it was to keep Hanna satisfied.

'Stop?' she teased.

Then she did stop, and she gasped, as though suddenly everything had clicked and she had figured me out. She looked up at me, shocked, and said: 'This is a thing, isn't it? For you, I mean. A fantasy. A fetish.'

I breathed, trying to keep calm, to avoid spurting my cream all over her before we were done. 'I... I don't know...'

'God! Seriously?' she was really surprised. I guess we hadn't actually talked about each other's sexual fantasies. At least, when the subject had come up in the early days of dating, we'd both said we didn't really have one. That had been true for me then. Not so much now. 'So your secret fantasy...' she went on, her eyes sharpening with interest, '...is it... the thought of me fucking other guys, or Hayden... or Jake... specifically that turns you on?'

It was all a little strange to me because I'd never really had thoughts about other guys sleeping with my wife before. As a teenager and in college I'd harbored fantasies of threesomes with two girls, but as I got older and the reality emerged about what a challenge it could be to keep two women satisfied, that fantasy had evaporated. I hadn't had much more than passing crushes for various celebrities since then.

Now I was faintly embarrassed at being so turned on by the idea of my friends banging Hanna—and yet I couldn't avoid the fact that it did turn me on. I felt like I was blushing as I lay there, being interrogated, and yet I was still so aroused there was a very real danger of me coming, even now that she'd stopped pumping my cock in her hands.

I tried thinking about how it might be to watch someone else fucking my wife. Maybe a celebrity. James Bond, or that guy from Game of Thrones. I thought of other guys we'd known in college, guys at my office. All of it seemed just as hot to me.

'I don't think it's them...' I said, not quite knowing how to put it into words.

'You mean... any guy would do?'

I shrugged. She looked down, running her fingers all over my big, hard cock. She seemed to be taking that as my answer rather than what I was saying, or my facial expression. And she giggled.

‘Is it just the sex?’ she asked me. ‘I mean... would you get this hard thinking about... some other girl fucking your friends... or other guys?’ She looked up at me. ‘Is it just... you know... watching sex that turns you on so much?’

I pursed my lips as though I wasn’t sure, but as I thought about Hayden or Jake—or that guy from *Game of Thrones*—fucking some other women, it certainly didn’t have the same effect on me. I thought of the celebrity crushes I’d had over the years—Sandra Bullock, Charlize Theron, Halle Berry... but though I still thought of them as attractive, fantasizing about them sleeping with other men wasn’t much of a thing for me.

‘Jesus!’ she gasped again, feeling my cock softening slightly in her hands. ‘So... it’s really all about me being with someone else?’

I shrugged again, and gave her a sheepish nod. The simple fact was that when I thought about it, there wasn’t any drama in the fantasy of watching another woman fucking someone right in front of me. However, the thought of watching *Hanna* fucking someone else—or even just knowing that it was happening, somewhere where I couldn’t watch—was just so powerful an idea, so full of drama, so steeped in terror and excitement and confusion and outright lust.

‘Wow,’ she said, smiling ear-to-ear. ‘This is so huge.’

I shivered a little, and it wasn’t cold in there. I guess I was starting to feel a little nervous that she was discovering all this about me—that I was discovering all this about me. Did I really want some other guy to sleep with my sweet wife?

But I couldn’t avoid the fact that my cock seemed to want it. Thinking about some other guy having Hanna just made me want her more.

‘You’re so... kinky...’ she said, still stunned by this revelation. ‘And I didn’t even know it.’

‘I... I don’t think I knew it, either,’ I admitted.

‘I think I just... kinda assumed your fantasy would be a threesome with two girls,’ she said, and I actually felt strangely good about myself that that wasn’t my fantasy, not anymore. That I wasn’t so predictable.

‘You never... told me anything.’

‘You never told me any of your fantasies,’ I fired back at her.

‘I really didn’t have much to tell,’ she insisted.

‘Try me.’

‘I don’t know...’ now it was her turn to blush profusely. But I stood my ground, waiting for her to open up. ‘I mean... you know... sometimes

I think about... you know... times you've fucked me and it was really amazing...'

'I think... that's called a memory, not a fantasy,' I chuckled.

Her blush deepened. 'Sometimes... I think about... you know... a little crush I might have...'

'A little crush? Who?'

She shrugged. 'Iron Man... Batman...'

'Which one?'

'Any of them. You know... in the suit...'

'You know he couldn't fuck you in the suit.'

'You don't think he'd have an attachment for that utility belt of his?'

'What about real guys? Guys without superpowers.'

'I don't know... that guy from Game of Thrones?'

I laughed. Thinking silently, *I knew it!* And hey presto, my full erection was back, as hard as ever, as I thought about her riding that guy from her favorite TV show. She felt it, of course, and it made her giggle.

'I can't believe you never told me about this before,' she chided me, as though we'd wasted years of marriage by not opening up about this stuff sooner. I suppose it would have made trying for a baby easier if I'd countered the pressure and anxiety with the fantasy of watching Hanna fucking some other man.

'I swear,' I said in response to her semi-accusatory statement, 'I never really thought about it before.'

'Seriously?'

I guess it was a little odd that something would turn me on so much, and yet I'd never really considered it before. I paused. She needed some explanation. I needed some explanation. I mulled it over in my head for a moment.

'When we started dating,' she said, 'you really didn't want to know about guys who'd dated me before.'

I thought back. I did remember feeling a few nerves on once being introduced to one of her ex-boyfriends, but there hadn't been a moment where I'd banned her from talking about her dating history. 'No,' I said, remembering, 'you were the one who got all upset every time I accidentally hinted that I'd been with another woman before you.'

She smirked. 'I guess... maybe that's true. I kind of... still hate thinking about anyone else having you except me.' Then she had a thought, and looked suddenly horrified. 'Is that what this is about? You

fantasize about me being with some other guy because it would mean I'd have to let you get with another girl?"

I shook my head, but funnily enough the most telling fact was the slight softening of my manhood in her fingers. 'No, that's not it at all,' I said, though I hardly needed to.

She laughed, 'It's really just that you want to watch me... getting nasty with someone else?'

And, lo and behold, my manhood thickened right back up. 'I don't think I'd even have to watch,' I admitted. 'You know... just knowing that you were...'

'That would be enough?'

The erection never lied, apparently. It was most amusing for Hanna.

'It's like a magic 8-ball,' she giggled, pumping on my hardness as though rewarding me for not wanting to sleep with other women.

'Except I know it's the truth. So... you're really not jealous thinking about me with other guys?'

I thought about it. Oh, I'd been jealous enough in my time. At high school, whenever I'd had any interest in a girl. In college when guys at parties had occasionally hit on Hanna, or girlfriends before Hanna. I had been nervous about Hanna's ex at some stage, sure. But these days... no, I wasn't jealous thinking about her fooling around with someone else.

'I don't think so,' I said. 'I think... you know... I trust you.'

'Trust me?'

'You know—to come back to me after you've... you know...'

'Fucked someone else?' she giggled.

'I mean—we're married. I think that just makes me feel confident enough that if you wanted a little fun with some other guy, it would be just that—nothing serious—and it wouldn't make you stop wanting to be married to me.'

'Of course it wouldn't,' she said, adamantly. And the way she said it somehow seemed to suggest that this wasn't just my newly-discovered fantasy anymore, she was really considering trying it for real. It frightened me that she might be—but at the same time, it turned me on like nothing else.

'Jesus!' she squealed again, as my hard cock jumped in her hands. 'I think your bad boy down here is trying to tell me something!'

'I think it is!' I laughed with her.

'I think if it was up to him, it wouldn't just be a fantasy. We'd probably be talking about me actually seeing what it would be like—you know, sleeping with someone else.'

‘I think we would,’ I nodded, and my cock was certainly giving both of us the impression that as far as it was concerned, Hanna already had full permission to sleep with whoever she wanted.

Hanna ducked her head and kissed it on the tip. ‘Maybe we should try it someday,’ she said, and it seemed to me just about the hottest thing she’d ever said.

‘Uh-huh,’ I nodded, still trying to hold myself back, to avoid coming until I was at least penetrating her.

She looked at me for a moment, trying to figure me out, her eyes latching onto mine. I smiled. She smiled back. I wondered what she was thinking about. Maybe she was thinking we could go home after this god-awful trip and start trying for a baby this time—and this time, she’d know exactly how to get me going in the bedroom when needed.

‘Come on,’ she said, pulling away from me, climbing out of bed. Leaving me totally confused.

‘What?’

She gave me a mischievous grin. ‘Don’t you think we’ve been in here long enough? You said it yourself how unfair it is for us to shut ourselves away from Hayden and Jake all day because we get to fuck.’

‘Yeah... but...’ I said, flustered. By now, I needed release.

‘Come on, we can talk about all this later,’ she said. ‘I’m going to take a quick shower and then we can see what Hayden and Jake want to do, right?’

I watched her wrap a towel around her body and scamper out of the room toward the bathroom. No en-suites in this tiny chalet. Ah well, I tried to console myself that I’d be able to resume all this with her later, at bedtime if not before when serious boredom returned.

Chapter Three

I showered after Hanna, and since she took an age to get ready, I was dressed before her, so that we could head back downstairs to our friends together. Hanna was now dressed a bit nicer in a short black skirt with a red fairly tight blouse. When they greeted our return, and afterward, it seemed that Hayden and Jake were trying their very best not to mention the fact that Hanna and I had just walked upstairs to fuck, and they knew exactly what had happened, or at least they thought they did. It was kind of amusing, but what surprised me was that I didn't feel embarrassed that they 'knew' Hanna and I had just slept together. I felt kind of proud that they thought we had. That I had such a hot wife who I could just whisk away and fuck any time I wanted. The way they looked at me, especially Hayden, reinforced that sense of pride. They seemed impressed by me.

I'd take it.

Outside, it was still raining. The television was still full of incomprehensible game shows and news broadcasts we couldn't understand. Hayden and Jake seemed to be watching one particular game show, and from the piles of little pistachio nut shells on the coffee table in front of the TV, seemed to have invented a betting game based on certain outcomes in the show. With nothing better to do, they shared the rules of their game with us: they were betting on things like which female contestant the host would grope next, or who would get kicked off the show first, or who would win any of the baffling array of mini-games during the show.

Hanna and I tried playing along with them for a while, but it wasn't as fun as it had initially seemed.

'Maybe we should just go for a walk,' Hanna suggested.

'In the rain?' Hayden reminded her, as if she needed reminding.

'We have coats,' she said. 'And anyway, none of us are made of sugar.'

We all looked toward the windows. It was really pouring.

'It can't be that bad,' my wife insisted.

We all went to the front door, and looked outside. The streets were unpaved, and the rain had turned everything to mud. And a huge gulley had been dug right down the middle of the street, by a torrent of muddy rainwater tearing down the mountainside. It looked dangerous.

'Okay. Let's not go out there,' Jake said.

Hayden said, 'It's nearly lunch time anyway.'

Eleven o'clock. For us, bored out of our skulls, it was near enough to lunch time. We ate, as slowly as humanly possible. We chatted. Time passed slowly as ever. Hayden and Jake started playing their TV game show betting game again. Hanna sat at the table and resumed Hayden's game of solitaire with the cards. I lay stretched out on the window seat, gazing out the window, occasionally glancing across at my wife.

To be honest, I wasn't really bored at all. I had to pretend to be bored in order to fit in. I could sit there and think about the brand new sexual fantasy that had been revealed to me earlier, reveling in the idea that Hanna might just suddenly stand up, grab Hayden or Jake, and walk off upstairs to go sleep with him.

I could spend the time trying to figure out why I was drawn to such a bizarre fantasy, as well as thinking about the fantasy itself.

I felt that the idea of Hayden, or Jake, or any other guy wanting to sleep with my wife somehow vindicated my choice in marrying her. And that although they got to sleep with her, I was more fortunate still because I got to live with her, and sleep with her every night. It was a pride thing.

I also found that I liked the thought of Hanna having a good time with some other guy—that for her, it would have all that excitement of a new relationship, without the pressure of wanting that relationship to go beyond a no-strings-attached fuck. I enjoyed the thought of Hanna enjoying herself, of doing something wicked, something corrupt, something oh-so-very dirty.

The early afternoon rolled on, and both Hanna and Jake went off to see if they could have a mid-day siesta. While I relaxed on the window seat, I found myself fantasizing that the two of them weren't really trying to have a nap, that instead they had crept away for a little bedroom action.

Hayden said to me at one point, 'You are one lucky son of a bitch, you know that?' Flicking his head to indicate that he was referring to the fact that I was married to Hanna.

'You should have brought someone with you,' I smiled.

Hayden laughed, 'You remember the invite said 'guys only', right?'

'Well, you know how Hanna feels about that kind of thing. Why should guys get all the fun?'

'Fun, huh,' Hayden chuckled.

'And she probably imagines if it was just us guys, we'd be out visiting strip joints when we weren't skiing.'

‘Strip joints? Around here?’ We were both laughing. He added, ‘I bet she’s regretting coming along now, huh?’

I thought for a moment. The way Hanna had been looking at me ever since the revelation about my new sexual fantasy, it struck me that perhaps Hanna was grateful she’d come on this trip. When we got home, perhaps it would all re-energize our relationship, at least the sexual part of it.

‘If only there was some kind of bar—’ I realized I was talking to Hayden, who was a confirmed alcoholic, and course-corrected, ‘—restaurant... whatever...you know...’

Hayden laughed, ‘A bar would be okay. You know, the way this trip is going, I’m thinking about maybe going back to the drink. I can always go back into rehab again... probably be less painful than this...’

‘No, Hayden—’ I said, horrified, but then saw that he was joking.

The way he shrugged, though, made me think that if tomorrow was as bad as today, he really might start thinking that a return to his addiction might be preferable to the insanity drawn on by such complete boredom.

Jake came back downstairs not long after he’d disappeared, and announced that he had been unable to sleep. ‘I’m just so lethargic,’ he said, ‘I’m about as well-rested as you can get right now, there’s no way I can sleep.’

Hanna came back downstairs not long after, and reported that she had also failed to have her siesta, for very similar reasons. That strange, dark part of me where my new fantasy seemed to have come from was now filling my head with the suggestion that Hanna and Jake really had sneaked away for an illicit quickie. The idea horrified me, because the way Hanna and I had talked, it was all still a fantasy for me, I hadn’t got my head around the thought of doing it for real. And yet as well as being horrified, I was brutally turned on by the idea, and found it difficult to conceal my full erection as I sat there on the window seat.

I watched the rain. Hayden and Jake watched the TV. Hanna seemed to be trying to invent some new kind of solitaire.

Early evening approached. We had another ridiculously early meal. Discussed more ideas for what to do in this rain-drenched ghost town.

‘Maybe we could break into some of the other houses, see if there’s anything to do in there,’ came Hayden’s best suggestion. ‘Come on—maybe next door has a PlayStation!’

But despite our strong feeling that there weren’t any police around this lifeless place with the ski season being a complete washout, we

weren't really law-breakers. We probably couldn't even pick a lock between us.

'If we're going to break into people's houses,' Hanna pointed out, 'we might as well just break into someone's car and hotwire it... you know, get back to the airport.'

'Anyone know how to hotwire a car?' Jake asked.

We all shrugged at that one.

'Can't be that hard. The cars round here—they're all about 20 years old.'

'And liable to break down halfway through the mountains,' I pointed out. 'Might be safer staying here until the shuttle bus comes back.'

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Seven o'clock. We were all watching the clock in the kitchen, and any time a new hour arrived seemed like a minor victory in our attempt to remain sane while getting through this god awful trip.

Jake and Hayden had started talking about risking the rain and the mud and the landslip that the streets were turning into, and going down to the grocery store to fetch alcohol—with Hayden resurrecting his idea that he would be okay to get drunk this week if he went back to rehab when we returned home.

'The store's going to be shut by now anyway, right?' I said. 'Town like this?'

A little while longer, there was a big sigh from Hanna's direction. Then she said, 'This is insane. This is just insane.'

I feared that she'd snapped, she'd finally lost it. She was going to do something stupid or reckless or both. Walk out the door and start hammering on doors for help, before catching pneumonia or being attacked in the street or something.

But then she said, 'Any of you guys know how to play poker?'

It was a funny question, because we'd tried playing poker the previous day for a while. Hanna looked over at me, and I couldn't quite read her expression. I raised an eyebrow to suggest I was intrigued but didn't understand where she was going with this.

'Sure,' Jake said, ignoring the fact that we had been playing poker the previous day.

Hanna turned around and perched on the edge of the table. After her attempt at an afternoon siesta, she'd put on her old college hooded top, a short skirt with another pair of leggings underneath, even though it was perfectly warm in the chalet.

'We're all grown-ups, right?' she said.

'Well, I can't speak for Hayden...' Jake wise-cracked.

Hanna said seriously, 'We're going to go completely insane here for another four days, right?'

'Right,' Jake agreed, serious now himself.

'But... you know... we're all friends here. We trust each other, right?' she said.

'Right,' Hayden nodded. Like Jake, he was intrigued as to what Hanna was getting at. From her tone of voice, it seemed she had a killer idea. Would we all be sneaking out of here to become cat burglars? Had she thought of some clever way to go skiing on grass and mud and rain?

'If we did something... bad... you know... just to pass the time, so we can avoid going insane... we could all agree to keep it all an absolute secret for the rest of time, right?'

Hanna glanced at me again, and I saw her tremble slightly. Jake and Hayden glanced at me, and each other, and I think they were wondering if Hanna was thinking about murdering someone—perhaps one of us—simply to pass the time.

'We can all keep a secret,' Jake said cautiously.

I honestly had no idea what Hanna was going to propose, but the way she was looking at me, seeming hopeful that I wasn't going to be angry with her, and everything she and I had talked about in the bedroom earlier, my cock started thickening inside my pants, and the butterflies started fluttering inside my stomach, and I started suspecting that perhaps, considering the absolute dire circumstances we found ourselves in, Hanna was thinking about toying with my brand new sexual fantasy a little.

'Yes,' Hayden agreed. 'What happens in this chalet stays in this chalet, right?'

Hanna looked at me again, and I gave a nod of agreement.

'Not a word,' she said to everyone, 'passes any of your lips beyond these four walls. Not about anything that happens in here, right?'

'Right,' we all said solemnly, and I could feel the tension in the other guys, who just wanted to find out what idea Hanna had come up with.

‘Okay,’ Hanna said. ‘And we’re all... you know... fairly broad-minded here, aren’t we?’

Jake nodded. Hayden said, ‘Sure.’ I nodded. I was tingling all over. Was she really going to do it? Was she really going to suggest something so wrong, so naughty, so completely against the rules for friendship, especially among friends I’d had for so long?

Hanna seemed nervous, and had to force herself to get the words out. And she couldn’t just come right out and say it, either. She came at it from a roundabout angle. ‘We’re all adults... you know... a girl... a few guys... nothing else to do at all... we’re going to go crazy if we don’t do something, right? I mean like *The Shining* crazy...’

‘Sure,’ Jake nodded. Everybody nodded. We all just wanted to hear her out.

‘Okay,’ she said, drawing a deep breath—and blushing fiercely. ‘So I think we should play poker... we can use your pistachio nuts as chips, right?’

‘Okay...’ Hayden said, glancing at us all warily as though to ask why we were all so tense if all Hanna was going to suggest was yet more poker.

‘And whoever wins... gets to spend the night with me,’ Hanna said.

Chapter Four

I felt my heart suddenly pounding inside my chest, threatening to burst out through my chest cavity like one of those creatures in the Aliens movies. A burst of searing-hot energy exploded in my stomach—as both intense fear and intense excitement were triggered within me. And of course, I was hard as a rock.

‘Spend the night... with you?’ Hayden said, seeking clarification.

‘Uh-huh,’ she said.

‘And... what does that mean?’ Jake said, and the way they were looking at her—profoundly hopeful, I’d call it—only intensified the arousal I felt at the idea of one of these guys getting to sleep with my wife that night. They really wanted her. In fact, I’d almost say that this offer from Hanna had exposed secret crushes they both had on her.

‘It means whatever you want it to mean, if you win,’ she smiled.

‘You get to stay with me in my bed... and do whatever you want to do... with me. All night.’

‘Jesus,’ Hayden said in an awe-struck whisper.

The guys looked at me, and I merely shrugged and smiled, blushing myself, as though to say that it really wasn’t up to me. Hanna was her own woman, she decided who she slept with, she decided what she did with her own body. It wasn’t up to me.

‘And if he wins?’ Hayden pointed at me.

‘The offer stands,’ she said, ‘my husband wins, he gets to spend the night with me.’

‘And if you win?’ Jake asked her.

‘Then nobody gets to spend the night with me.’

‘Hey!’ I objected. ‘So where do I...’

‘You get to sleep on the couch, honey,’ she flashed me a mischievous grin.

Jake was up on his feet, nervous, quietly excited, and hopeful not only of winning the chance to spend some time with Hanna, but also that this whole idea might somehow get us through the evening, and contribute toward getting us through the rest of the week.

‘Are you sure about this?’ he asked Hanna, and looked over to include me in his question.

Hanna said, ‘I’m sure. We’ve got nothing to do here all week. We’re all so bored out of our skulls... I don’t dare think what would happen if

we don't find some diversion.'

'It's true,' I said, acting cool and casual, as though none of this was a big deal for me.

Hayden asked Hanna and I, 'Have you guys... ever done anything like this before?'

Hanna laughed. 'Are you asking if we're swingers? No, we're not, by the way.'

'No,' I shook my head. 'Nothing like this.'

'And it's... going to be okay?' Jake said to me, now. Worried that if he won—or if Hayden won—it would affect our friendship.

'It's going to be okay,' I insisted, trying not to blush so much, trying to sound as though it really wasn't a big deal—and that I really wasn't sexually aroused by the possibility of my wife sleeping with one of them that night. 'It's just the week, right? We've got to get through it. Somehow.'

'But she's... I mean, she's your wife.'

I sighed, as though it was really weighing on my mind, and said, 'Look, it's just... you know... sex. It doesn't have to mean anything. And as long as we're all absolutely clear that none of this leaves the chalet, we don't ever talk to anybody about what happened here... I think it'll be okay.'

'Right,' Jake nodded.

'Come on,' Hanna said, picking up the pack of cards to begin shuffling it. 'We'll play at the table.'

We all grabbed our lemon cordials—which was what we were drinking in place of alcohol—and got comfortable around the table, which was actually pretty good for poker since it had a central light you could pull down closer to the table, so we could pretend it was some kind of casino we were in, rather than a cramped vacation apartment.

I was sitting opposite Hanna, which allowed me to look into her smoky jade eyes and see just how excited she was. And she was able to look across at me and reassure herself that I really was all right with this—shocked, surprised, but okay with it, and excited at the bizarre prospect of my brand new sexual fantasy coming to pass.

'Of course, if you win,' Hayden said to Hanna as she started dealing out cards, 'or if hubby wins, it'll really be just another night like any other.'

Hanna grinned. 'But we'll have had an entertaining game of high-stakes poker, right? And maybe if you don't win tonight, you'll get a chance to play tomorrow night.'

Now in amongst all the butterflies and the heart-strain and the giddy nerves, my hardness returned with a vengeance. The way Hanna talked—and the logical way for us to get through this week—was, indeed, to play this poker game each night. And with four nights to go, that meant fairly high probability that Hanna would get to sleep with at least one of them, Hayden or Jake.

It would happen. My wife would sleep with someone else that week, I was sure of it. And I was, among many things, thrilled about it.

Of course, poker is not all about pure chance.

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I don't think, to start with, we realized quite how bad at poker we all were. Or how reckless.

As we shared out the pistachio nuts and pushed in our first chips for the ante, I think I was expecting the game to last a few hours at least. Maybe even until Midnight. It was in everybody's interest to let it run as long as possible, so that we could eat up the time. A late night would mean a long lie-in for everybody, which would help us get through the interminable days in this chalet.

But with each hand we were all merrily bluffing away and raising the stakes here, there and everywhere—and in no time, you had Hayden and I going all in on ridiculous hands, and losing it all. And inside twenty minutes, the game was over.

Hanna, by the way, had won the day.

The rest of us just groaned, and looked up at the clock to see, to our absolute horror, that it wasn't even eight o'clock yet. Our optimism at having an entertaining evening—with an explosive night-time for somebody—had been dashed before we'd even had time to really settle and start enjoying it.

But then Hanna said, 'Have you guys ever played poker before? Come on—everyone ready for the next round?'

Us guys all looked at each other with questioning expressions, until it hit us that the game wasn't over for the night after all. Huge relief at that, and then the pistachio shells were being divided up again.

Hanna said, 'Hayden—you were out first that round. So you have to lose a piece of clothing.'

'What?' Hayden said, a touch surprised.

‘Come on,’ my wife smiled wickedly. ‘We’re all having fun here, right?’

I looked at Jake, who shrugged as though to say, why not?

‘And if you lose, you’ll take something off, too, right?’ Hayden asked Hanna, and started peeling off his t-shirt to reveal his ripped chest, toned by the regular gym sessions he’d kept up since his college football days.

‘Of course.’

‘And what happens when one of us loses all our clothes?’ Jake asked.

‘He—or she—is out of the game,’ Hanna said.

‘Hey—you have more clothes on than me,’ Hayden protested. ‘I could have put on a sweatshirt too.’

‘But you didn’t,’ Hanna grinned smugly. Had she been planning this all afternoon? Ever since she’d come out from her siesta dressed as though there was a leak in the window, or the boiler in the basement wasn’t heating up the place nicely.

My guess was that she’d been thinking about my surprising new sexual fantasy ever since our morning’s conversation about it, and had come to the conclusion that if I had an open mind on the matter, some kind of sexual game between all of us might just be the easiest way to pass the time this week.

Well, she was the only woman here. Hayden griped about the unfair advantage, but we didn’t let Hanna’s apparent clothing bonus worry us too much. We played on, and were a little more clever, and a little less reckless. And would you believe it, Hanna was the first one that round to lose all her chips.

‘It’s okay,’ she said, pulling her hooded top off over her head. ‘Plenty of time yet.’

I felt my heart rate pick up a little as we watched her pulling off her hooded top. My wife, taking off her clothes in front of my friends. Wow. It was just so unexpected. She’d always been very demure, respectful in front of my friends before. Early on, she’d wanted to impress them, and not embarrass me. Later, she just rarely socialized with my friends, and when we did both go out she was on her best behavior because she just didn’t know them all that well.

Underneath her hooded top, Hanna was wearing a dark blue tank top that gave a nice idea of the shape of her chest, although it was also fairly obvious she was wearing a bra—a black one—beneath. Jake and shirtless Hayden were watching her closely as she removed her hoody,

and it seemed that for once it really wasn't impolite of them to stare—or to check out another guy's woman. Tonight one of them might be sleeping with her.

I have to admit a strange sense of arousal at the way they looked at her. It wasn't just pride. It was a sense of taboos being broken, expectations being shaken, of my pretty, confident, yet usually fairly conservative wife being naughty, wicked, dirty. After dropping her hooded top by her side, she looked over at Jake, and then at Hayden, before glancing at me, and there was real fire in her eyes. Wow. This was going to be some night.

'You're going to force us to strip naked, and then at the end of the night you won't sleep with anybody,' Jake said as the cards were dealt for the next round.

'Nobody's forcing anybody to do anything,' Hanna said dryly, finishing up handing out the cards. 'You don't have to play—you could go for a walk instead if you like. Or go upstairs to sleep.'

'Uh-huh,' Jake grinned. 'This is the only game in town, right? I'm just saying... you're keen on an eyeful of us, right? But that's as far as it'll go.'

Everybody pushed in their ante.

Hanna laughed. 'You think it's in my interest to sleep alone tonight?'

Jake nodded as though her answer had been totally predictable. Gazing at his hand as though he was trying to silently calculate exactly how good it was, he said, 'So you're saying you're likely to blow the game? If you're winning at the end, you'll take a dive?'

'I'm not saying anything,' she said.

We went around, and Hanna folded. Hayden groaned at her caution, and pushed half of his pistachio shells into the middle. 'You're going to hand victory to hubby here, aren't you?' he accused her, picking up on Jake's conspiracy theorizing.

Hanna laughed again, 'Jesus, would you look at you guys? Just wait and see, huh? Open your minds.'

Jake called, and I raised the bet, with Hayden matching my stake but Jake subsequently folding. At the end, I had the stronger hand with two aces, Hayden had been almost bluffing.

'I'm just saying,' Hayden told her, 'You have an interest in helping Thad to win.'

'An interest?' Hanna raised an eyebrow.

‘You said it yourself, you don’t want to sleep alone tonight,’ Jake concurred with our friend.

‘And that,’ Hayden said, his argument energized, ‘means there’s half the people at this table trying to get Thad a win.’

Hanna looked over at me and rolled her eyes playfully. Then she gave me a naughty little wink, which was just about as hot as anything she’d done all night in my view, as it seemed to suggest that she was joking with me about how Jake and Hayden had totally the wrong idea here. And that seemed to suggest that in her view—as in mine—the real victory tonight would be if she slept with Hayden or Jake, rather than any other option.

‘Okay,’ Hanna nodded, ‘So let’s change the rules. If I win, I get to choose who I sleep with tonight. Does that sound better?’

Jake and Hayden shrugged, seemingly defeated. In their minds Hanna would automatically choose to sleep with me that night if she won, which wouldn’t increase their chances of pulling off the marital upset. I looked over at Hanna, and the fire in her eyes that sent excited-terrified shivers down my spine, and I got the feeling that if she had the choice of sleeping partner that night, considering what we’d talked about that morning, she most likely wouldn’t be sleeping with me after the game.

Jesus. Could this really happen?

I felt my manhood thickening up again at the thought that it might—that at some point I would be sitting there at the table with one of my friends, watching the other one escorting my own wife upstairs.

Chapter Five

Anyway. I won the hand, I won the round. Hayden ended up taking off his shoes, arguing with a flirtatious Hanna along the way as to whether he ought to remove one or both of his shoes, before it was decided that items like shoes and socks would count as one item.

‘You just can’t wait to see my dick,’ Hayden told Hanna, as though he was gently insulting her for forcing him to lose both his shoes at once.

However, Hanna just giggled and said, ‘That is true enough.’

Her answer made Hayden catch his breath at her audacity. Jake glanced over at me with an inquiring expression that seemed to be asking me whether my wife was really for real, whether I’d slipped her some mind-altering drug, or whether she’d simply snapped because of the sheer tedium of this trip.

I simply smiled back at him and shrugged.

The next round, I lost my shoes. Jake was complaining because he wasn’t wearing any shoes, and from his calculations he hadn’t lost yet and was still level-pegging with me for number of clothes being worn, with Hanna up on all of us.

‘I’ll let you go put your shoes on if you kiss Hayden for thirty seconds,’ Hanna giggled, and both Jake and Hayden made retching sounds at that suggestion.

Hanna lost two rounds in a row, taking off her own white tennis shoes and her leggings, and Jake started feeling better about his chances. That left Hanna wearing her tank top and skirt, along with white socks and underwear.

Then I lost another round, so off came my shirt.

‘You know, it’s not so bad for you,’ Hayden pointed out to me. ‘You strip naked, you’re only sitting there in front of a bunch of guys—your friends—and your wife. Not exactly terrifying.’

I chuckled. He was right in a sense—my own stripping did not concern me at all. I was more interested in how much clothing my wife would lose in front of my lust-fueled friends. And, of course, what would happen after the game. I said to Hayden, ‘But I’m the one who might have to see his wife go spend the night with another guy tonight.’

My point couldn’t be beaten in this particular debate.

Hanna said to Hayden, ‘You’re always complaining, you know that?’

‘I’m just pointing out the way it is,’ Hayden protested, and as though distracted, lost the hand of cards right then and there.

‘Look at the clock,’ Hanna said. We all did. It was nine o’clock already. Where had the time gone? ‘Nine o’clock. You guys might all have an inferiority complex, but you see how much time this little game of ours is eating away?’

Hayden moped, ‘I do not have an inferiority complex.’

But our little glance at the clock did seem to clear up any lingering complaints about this game. Jake and Hayden might have had doubts as to whether Hanna would really sleep with one of them—and whether I’d really let her—but there could be no doubt that she was removing her own clothing item by item as the game progressed.

After Jake finally lost a round—and his socks—we saw Hanna drop another two rounds, so that we saw her lose her socks and her tank top. Surprisingly she had yet another tank top on underneath, but nevertheless the feeling was that she was really playing this game, she was really stripping when she lost. If things proceeded accordingly, Hanna was going to be exposing herself at the very least tonight.

She certainly didn’t seem all that great at poker.

‘Don’t tell me, you want a rule change,’ Jake said dryly as Hanna dropped her tank top beside her. ‘You only have to lose clothing every other round you lose, right? Because you’re the only girl at the table.’

Hanna grinned, and shook her head, ‘I don’t need a rule change. What makes you think I’m not just hustling you?’

Jake laughed, ‘Because you wouldn’t be asking me that if you were. And hustling doesn’t work in strip poker.’

As though to prove himself wrong, Jake went ahead and lost the next three rounds in fairly quick succession, to his increasing consternation. It left him in his boxer shorts, and he only escaped nudity because he happened to have a white t-shirt on under his checked button-down shirt.

When Hayden then lost, and his pants came off to leave him also in just his boxer shorts, the feelings of resentment seemed to start returning, since I was sitting there having merely lost my shoes.

‘You’re gonna ruin tonight, dude,’ Jake shook his head at me, though his smile was one of amusement. ‘We’re counting on you to take a dive, here.’

‘He’s defending my honor,’ Hanna said.

‘I thought none of us were worrying about honor here,’ Hayden pointed out. ‘Because... you know... we really do have to find a way to

get through this week.'

'And because what happens within these four walls stays within these four walls,' Jake added.

'You're just both losers,' I threw back at them with a broad grin. 'You can't handle being beaten like a useless donkey.'

I wasn't particularly good at poker. The cards just seemed to fall my way that night. I wasn't bravely bluffing my way through to picking up all the pistachio shells each round, and keeping my clothing to myself. It's funny because the longer we played, the more comfortable I felt with the idea of Hanna actually doing something wicked that night—that the secret would truly stay among us four, that Hanna wouldn't suddenly find herself wanting to divorce me to run off with whichever guy she slept with that night, that it would just be a huge turn on for me, even if I was sleeping on the couch that night, or in the bedroom of the winner. I started groaning internally whenever I won a hand, or a round. It seemed to me that I wanted to lose, I wanted Hanna to be with someone else, to see what that was like.

The cards just kept going my way and others had to strip, while I was closer to the 'reward' of getting to sleep with my wife. But isn't that the way? You only win if you're not really trying to win. You're less likely to win if you're really desperate to win.

With Hayden and Jake both sitting there in their underwear, I realized what I really didn't want was to lose them from the game, and have it come down to me versus Hanna.

I enjoyed watching Hanna lose the next round, and have to decide whether to lose her tank top or her skirt. She chose the tank top, peeling it off to reveal her flat stomach, her shapely breasts contained only by her black bra. My friends also enjoyed watching her lose her tank top, and the sense I got—especially from Jake—was that seeing her lose her clothes might be the only real treat they received after their long night of hopefulness.

It was about that point that I kind of figured that I really wasn't going to shake the good fortune at cards that night. When the next couple of hands went my way, it seemed almost proven in my mind. I felt an odd sense of disappointment.

And Jake looked across at me groaning as I held a hand of Aces and Jacks, and he said: 'Could it be that the master has finally been dealt a lousy hand of cards?'

I looked at him, and despite what I held, I nodded sheepishly and folded right there on the spot.

It was a eureka moment for me. I know, it sounds stupid—all night, I could have folded any time I liked, and taken my fair share of losses. I just don't really think like that, I guess. Or, perhaps I thought I'd be found out if I faked some losses. Somehow, I could handle my friends thinking that I was being somewhat forced to accept my wife sleeping with someone else that night, for everyone's sanity. It seemed humiliating to me if they started to realize I actively wanted her to sleep with another guy.

But here I was, in a strong position, almost controlling the game. I realized if I was actually in control, I needed to start using that control to start throwing the win toward one of my friends.

And so I started to fold when I had strong hands—and when, on occasion, I had vaguely lousy cards, I started to bluff ineffectively.

'You know, I think I know your tell,' Jake said to me when I was caught out for the third time bluffing with nothing much in my hand.

We all looked at him.

'When you're bluffing, you have this... I wouldn't call it a tic... but it's like you can't stop scratching under your ear,' he said.

In truth, I had a little bug bite there. But I was willing to deny his observation and then make use of my supposed 'tell' to try to signal to everyone when I was bluffing. It was a good route to failure for me.

I lost my socks. Then I lost my shirt. I could have lost three rounds in a row and really drawn level with Hayden and Jake, except that Hanna managed to lose a round. Now we were all focused on her, because she had the choice of skirt, bra or panties to remove. She stood up, blushing faintly but apparently enjoying the feeling of three men being so attentive toward her.

She stooped slightly, and to our collective surprise, reached under her skirt to remove her panties.

'I still say you're hustling us,' Jake grinned, and I saw he was sitting a little awkwardly, and realized he had to be finding it increasingly difficult to hide his physical response to my wife's slow stripping since he was sitting there in only a pair of boxer shorts.

'I'm guessing Thad's going to win,' Hanna replied to Jake with a flirtatious smirk. 'So I don't really have to hustle you or anyone.'

Hanna put her panties right there on top of her pile of clothing on the bench next to her, and even though they were fairly ordinary black panties—she hadn't thought to bring sexy underwear on this trip, since she'd assumed we would be skiing all week, rather than playing strip poker—it seemed like a bold, sexy move. Flaunting it in my face, or

perhaps the guys' faces, that she was available that night to whomever won the game.

Well, Hayden and Jake were starting to win the game. I lost my pants next, leaving me in just my underpants, the same as the other guys. Yes, I purposefully folded, but that was what I was going for.

I had to make it look real, though. Like I was trying to win. I took another round with two pairs, and Hanna lost the round with some reckless all-in bets.

'Now she's trying to lose,' Hayden joked, but Hanna gave a reasonable impression of someone a little nervous and upset at losing and facing the prospect of having to cheat on her husband.

She looked over to me, though, silently asking whether I was still all right with all this, whether I was still enjoying the evening, enjoying this sudden plunge into my fantasy. I nodded and smiled, as reassuring as I could. Then she removed her bra, doing her best to bashfully conceal her bare breasts with her hands once she'd done so, although her hard little nipples bore witness to her enjoyment at exposing herself in front of three lust-filled guys.

Then Hayden was out. It felt like a loss to me, it felt like my fault even though Hanna won the round. Now there was a lot less of a chance that Hanna would have to sleep with someone else. I was, by that point, increasingly certain that if Hanna won she would choose to have me sleep with her. It felt like a stretch to suddenly decide to sleep with another guy so soon after first discovering my little kink.

Hayden stood up and said, 'Well that's it, huh? I guess I should say good night to you folks.'

And Hanna had to demand, 'No, no, get them off—you know the rules. And you have to sit here with us until the game is over.'

Hayden was about to complain, but he looked at Jake and I, and the two of us nodded our support for Hanna. 'Rules are rules, dude,' Jake said.

Hayden smirked, and hooked his fingertips into the waistband of his boxer shorts. He said to Hanna, 'Are you sure about this? Because once you've seen it... you're gonna regret not being able to choose this for tonight.'

Hanna giggled, 'Take them off. Go on!'

Hayden wasn't all that bashful. He looked as though after all these years, he kind of liked the idea of Hanna getting to see what he was packing. And he was packing something significant. Hanna's eyes

widened as his big beast was exposed. Maybe she did look a little regretful as Hayden took his seat again.

Jake and I looked at each other, not really knowing what to say.

Hanna spent most of the next round trying to order Hayden not to cover himself with his hands, or sit so close into the table that he was exposed only from the waist upward. But then she lost that round, and it was time for her to remove her skirt—and bare herself completely. And Hayden was adamant in saying she couldn't cover herself with her hands or anything, either.

I think both Hanna and Hayden quietly enjoyed their exposure. Their flirting made me feel slightly nervous, even though I still felt a strong desire for them to sleep together, if she wasn't going to sleep with Jake. I guess I hadn't expected this kind of easy chemistry between Hanna and my friends when the possibility of sex between them was presented.

But here she was, naked in front of them, and the chemistry was obvious. They wanted her badly. And why not? She was so exposed, and so available. Her full breasts heaved with desire, her nipples were stiff as nails, her pussy right there for the taking.

Now it was between Jake and I for the win. Head to head, both of us sitting there in our boxer shorts.

Suddenly, it was real for me. The fantasy, the thought of another man spending the night with my wife. I had cold feet. I started wondering if I was crazy, if I'd regret everything as soon as it had happened. If Hanna went upstairs and fucked Jake, there was no way she could take it back. You couldn't un-fuck somebody. You couldn't un-cheat. Or de-cheat. Or whatever the word would be.

Half of me desperately wanted to find out what it was like for Hanna to be unfaithful. And yet now my other half started thinking maybe life would just be more simple if she didn't. We wouldn't have to risk anything, there wouldn't be any chance that our marriage would unravel.

I started thinking perhaps I needed another night to sleep on it. Perhaps everyone would want to play the game again the next night?

I started trying to win the game.

'Oh, here it is,' Jake said after I took the first couple of hands—and half of his pistachio shells. 'The hustler starts coming back from the brink to seize the day...'

'You're just a sore loser,' I snapped back.

'Not losing yet,' he insisted.

He came back and won a couple of hands, and for a while we were going back and forth, nobody really coming ahead.

Hayden was cheering on Jake, even though it would mean someone else than him sleeping with Hanna. I wondered if he thought that Jake getting to do it would mean she would be open to him doing so another time in the future, considering. Well, we did have three more days to kill.

Hanna was cheering me on, as though she felt obligated to at least seem as though she was fighting for her honor. But the way she did it, I started wondering if she was having second thoughts, too. It made me resolve to win the game, at least this time. It had been a wild ride all evening—and now it was getting close to midnight—but maybe we weren't ready for this big step in our relationship.

At least I'd discovered the fantasy. At least I'd discussed it with Hanna. We had that going for ourselves. We'd be able to role play the whole thing when we got home, have some fun with it. Maybe we'd decide to try for a child again, and this time we would have more luck.

I started pushing to try and win the game, and felt confident, too, based on my evening's good fortune.

Only, you remember what I said about what happens when you really try to win?

Jake made a really big bet, and he was doing something with the bottom of his cards as he did it, and I started thinking—hey, that's his tell. He's bluffing. I went for the bet, and I lost a lot of shells. I had maybe 20 left.

Suddenly, Hanna was saying to me, 'Maybe we should call it a night, right? I mean, we're all tired... we're not thinking straight, are we?'

I saw the shock in her face. Maybe she saw the horror in mine. This was actually happening. Jake was winning.

It was our fault, we'd been so gung-ho with it. Maybe we had assumed from the outset that the two of us had good odds of winning—we were half of the poker table, after all.

I tried to keep calm, tried to relax, tried to get myself in the same mindset I'd been in most of the evening, when winning had seemed to come so very easy. I sighed, and said to myself that with 20 pistachio nut shells compared to Jake's 200 hundred or so, it would be a slow way back, but I'd get there.

Then I was dealt a two and a three, and it seemed all over. Jake had two Queens.

'Read 'em and weep!' he said, laying them down in front of us.

I think he was almost as shocked at winning as we were.

Chapter Six

‘I won!’ Jake yelled.

Hanna gasped.

I drew in a deep breath and felt a strange coldness inside my chest, squeezing my heart. Suddenly, my erection was gone.

‘I won!’ Jake yelled again, then, it seemed more like a question. ‘I won?’

He couldn’t believe it. Nobody could believe it. Somehow, everybody had just kind of assumed Hanna or I would win at cards tonight. The established order wouldn’t be shaken up. We wouldn’t have to go through on the promise of Hanna sleeping with somebody else.

And yet here was Jake, the winner.

It was a joke to him. I don’t think he thought Hanna would go through with it, either. He turned to me and was like, ‘Come on, dude—get them off. You know the rules.’ Kidding, because what was the point of me stripping naked? The guys weren’t interested. Hanna had seen it all before.

I think maybe Jake was just relieved that he would be able to keep his boxer shorts on in front of everyone, in front of Hanna.

I did as I was told, removing my underwear. Feeling more than a little embarrassed by my soft dick, hardly much compared to Hayden’s monster. But nobody was checking out what I was stowing between my legs. Jake was laughing merrily, most amused, telling Hanna he was ready when she was. Hanna was looking to me, somewhat anxious—scared, maybe—and waiting for me to tell her what to do, now.

I felt scared, maybe even a touch annoyed. It hadn’t been me, after all, who had decided on this game. It hadn’t been me who had put her out there on offer for the winner to sleep with. She’d done that on her own, with no discussion, no agreement from me beforehand. And Jake had won.

I was embarrassed.

Hanna stood up, and I felt as though I’d forgotten she was completely naked. ‘Okay then,’ she said to Jake. ‘Let’s head upstairs.’

Was she testing me? Was she expecting me to leap in front of Jake and physically fight for her honor?

It seemed to me that that most embarrassing thing of all was to have my wife offer herself as a prize, and when one of those guys won it,

reneging on the promise and not giving up the offered prize.

I shrugged at Hanna as though to say, you were the one who suggested this. You have to go through with it.

My abdication of responsibility seemed to make her bolder in inviting Jake to join her on the way up to the bedrooms. Jake's smile was suddenly wiped from his face.

'Wait—seriously?' he said, as though he suddenly wasn't sure what was going on. Was the joke on him?

'You won the game, didn't you?' Hanna asked him.

'Yeah...' he said, looking at Hayden and me, and then switching between Hanna and me as though he was watching a game of tennis. 'But you guys... you're married... I mean... aren't you? You're not supposed to... you know...'

Stunning in her nudity, Hanna went over to link her arm in Jake's, as though to escort him forcibly upstairs. She was looking at me as though challenging me to stop her. I was trying to keep calm, not to panic. And seeing her like that with him, so naked, apparently giving herself to him—I started to warm up again. That dark side of my mental makeup started to come to life again. I started to feel the dangerous arousal that went with the fear and the insecurity.

'It's just sex,' I said, completely downplaying what I was feeling. 'And... you know... as long as we're all resolved to keep everything that happens in this chalet... you know... between us...'

Hayden had grabbed his clothes to hold in front of his manhood, but he seemed keen to support what I was saying. 'You know I won't tell anybody,' he declared.

'Me neither,' said Jake, somewhat stunned by what was going on.

Hanna looked at me, a funny expression on her face, asking me silently, 'Seriously? You really, honestly, want this to happen?'

I shrugged, doing my best to conceal an involuntary shiver that passed through my whole body. I nodded. 'A Lannister always pays his debts,' I said.

For me, it felt as though I'd just lit my insides on fire. My stomach dropped into my shoes. My heart just about stopped beating. Hayden and I watched Hanna and Jake walk slowly to the base of the stairs, and then climb step by step up to the upper floor.

Wow. I was so frightened, and so turned on. I felt a little nauseous, if I was honest.

Hayden took a huge breath and slapped me on the back. 'You sure about this, dude?'

I shrugged. 'We've been married a while. It's only sex, right? She'll have a little fun...'

'He will.'

'He will. And then in the morning... we can kind of forget it all happened.'

'Maybe,' he nodded. 'Then we have to find something else to do for three more days, right?'

I nodded.

'Well... I guess that was fun tonight,' he said, and his tone acknowledged that now Hanna and Jake had gone, things felt a little awkward between the two of us. We were both naked, for one. 'I mean... you know... it really helped pass the time.'

'It did, didn't it?'

'I better... you know... try to get some sleep,' he said.

'Yeah,' I nodded, my tone effectively giving him permission to get the hell out of there, back to the safety of his own bedroom to leave the train wreck that was me alone.

And so there it was, just me on my lonesome.

I felt my legs almost give way. I had to sit down on the couch, I flicked on the television to one totally baffling late-night game show. I was in shock, perhaps. Scared. Not jealous, though. My heart was pounding, I was sweating like crazy—but my cock was harder than ever.

It was, when I tried to push away the feelings of fear, focusing on the logic that there was no way Jake would try to steal my wife even if he got all the way past third base with her. And she wouldn't leave me. I'd have her back. I'd have her back, and she'd be sullied from a night with another man. She'd be dirty from sex with someone else. Jesus. She'd be so unbelievably sexy.

I concentrated on breathing—in, out, in, out. Deep breaths. Relaxing. Meditating, almost. And I was calming down. As I was calming down, the positives of the experience started beating out the negatives.

Jesus, my wife was going to spend the night with another man. What a rush!

I did start putting my clothes back on, but was also considering whether it would be comfortable enough to sleep on the couch all night. It wasn't the widest couch there was, and the cushions weren't exactly the fullest. My mind soon started drifting back to the thought of Hanna being with Jake, however. Sleeping with another man.

It was just so wicked, so against the rules. So hot.

And knowing he was going to get to have her only made me want her more. Knowing that Hayden wanted her, too, but that she would return to me—that was hot. Just knowing that Hanna was going to get the rush of a new bedmate, sex with a man she'd never known that way. Strange cock. She'd get an unbelievable buzz—and it meant I had one, too.

Then, as I was settling down on the couch, lengthways, imagining that this game show was going to put me to sleep soon enough, I looked up to see Jake slink down stairs.

'Hey,' I said. 'Everything okay?'

He looked troubled. He said, 'Look, I don't need to do this, dude. I can... you know... it was fun, imagining that this might be—'

I said, 'You won, Jake. She's your prize tonight.'

He nodded, accepting that I was being true to my word, or at least true to Hanna's word, but said, 'We could just... you know... pretend it happened... you know, Hayden wouldn't need to know it didn't—'

It would have been so easy to do it this way, as well. Jake was being so gracious, I could see how weird he thought all this was, but I could also kind of see that he was a little disappointed at not getting to have Hanna for the night. Maybe I was reading too much into his face.

I said, 'Jake, really. It's no big deal. It's just sex, right? If you get to do this... you'll have a good time tonight. A really good time... and you'll be able to sleep late tomorrow... and then you and Hanna... you're one day closer to the trip being over.'

Jake said, 'But—'

And I said, 'Hanna and I have been married so long... we trust each other. I know I'm not going to lose her, just because she's had a single night of fun with someone else.'

'Yeah, but—'

'Trust me,' I said earnestly, feeling odd trying to persuade him to bed my wife, but that is what I was doing now. He'd won the game. It felt like bad luck to go against the will of the cards. 'It's okay. You go... have fun. As long as no one talks about any of this outside of the four of us...'

'No, buddy. You know I'd never—'

I just nodded. Jake looked as though he couldn't believe his luck. I gave him a final reassuring smile, and he was away again, looking as though he was walking on clouds as he drifted back to the staircase, and headed on back up to Hanna.

I was on my own again. I went around the room switching out lights and making sure the windows were locked, as though I needed to. Keeping as silent as I could—not for fear of waking Hayden, but because I wanted to find out if, indeed, it was possible to hear Hanna and Jake from down here. The chalet was hardly palatial.

I was disappointed not to hear anything, however. Were they purposefully trying to be quiet? That hardly seemed fair, but then I wasn't expecting Hanna to tell Jake that it was my secret sexual fantasy to have her sleep with someone else.

I lay back on the couch, almost resolved to try to sleep knowing that I wasn't going to get to hear my wife being unfaithful, my wife being naughty and sexy. Cheating on me—except that it wasn't really 'cheating', was it? Not when I was basically consenting to it.

Then I looked up one more time toward the staircase, and there was Hanna, in the flesh, standing just a few paces away from the back of the couch. She made me jump.

'Hey, are you okay?' she asked me.

'Of course.'

She seemed genuinely concerned. Anxious. She'd put on a bathrobe, and as she clutched it to her body, I could see through the gap that she'd also apparently put on a clean set of white underwear.

'Nothing's going to happen,' she said, and I could see she was a little frightened.

'What do you mean?'

She clarified, 'Jake and I are just... you know... going to talk a bit... get some sleep. The bed's large enough.'

I chuckled. 'What are you talking about? I thought the whole point was... you know... you get to do whatever you like with each other.'

'But—'

I said, honestly, 'Look — I know it was your idea, and we didn't talk about it, but it was a good one. We've basically got nothing to keep us sane the rest of this week except who we are. Sex is the obvious answer—we have a beautiful woman and three guys here. That's like a resource, a toolkit for getting us through this unbelievably bad vacation.'

She said, 'I don't know what I was... I'm not sure...'

I said, 'Look, you don't have to do it if you don't want to. But as far as I'm concerned... well, you know how I feel about it.'

'You still... feel that way?'

I smiled, trying to make it my warmest, my most reassuring. 'It's my fantasy, isn't it? And tonight we get to make it true. And the two guys

here with us are our friends, and have pledged never to breathe a word to anybody.'

'Yeah, but... are you *sure* sure?'

She let her bathrobe hang open, and I was given a delicious view of her body. Her bra and panties were simple, plain white—and yet so very sexy, because I knew another man was going to peel them off her. And I wanted another man to peel them off her.

'I'm sure sure. Are you sure sure?' I asked her.

'I... I think it would be fun...'

I gave her a prompting look. Silently telling her: we need you to be sure sure. If I'm sure sure, you have to be sure sure, too.

She sighed, and gave me a meek little, sweet little smile. 'I'm sure sure,' she said, almost whispered.

I nodded, and reached up to kiss her, now she'd drifted forward toward me. Her lips were warm, sweet. Trembling a little. 'It'll be okay,' I said. 'You'll have fun. And if it's not amazing... well, we'll say no more about it. We'll forget it ever happened.'

'And if it is amazing?' she asked me.

'Yes?'

'You'd want to... you know... know what happens?'

I nodded. 'I'd want to know.'

She nodded.

'Jake says you can sleep on his bed if you like,' she said, and it seemed to remind me that the reward for winning the poker game was to spend a whole night with Hanna. Wow.

'Great,' I smiled. 'Got to be more comfortable than this couch.'

Thinking, Jake's bedroom was directly opposite mine and Hanna's. No way I'd avoid hearing them.

'I'll try... we'll try... to keep the noise down,' she said, stepping back, away from me. My heart felt drawn to her as she moved away, as though there was some kind of magnetic force pulling me to her.

Wrenching at my heart, in fact.

'Don't,' I smiled. 'You don't need to. At all.'

She flashed her sparkly green eyes at me, telling me in no uncertain terms that I really was kinky, that she was kind of fired up about it. That I'd want to hear, and everything.

'I'll tell him you'd prefer to stay down here,' she said. The implication just made my cock throb.

She held up her hand and gave me a little wave, and blew me a kiss. Mouthed, 'I love you.'

I mouthed it back at her.

She turned, and disappeared upstairs again.

Chapter Seven

I waited ten minutes, and then turned off the television. As though Jake would be listening for it, to tell if I was still down here, maybe that I intended to get to sleep on the couch. I stood, my heart pounding. Was it happening now? What were they doing? Kissing? Cuddling? Touching?

I pictured her lying beside him in that plain white underwear, maybe reaching for him, stroking his hardness through his boxer shorts. The two of them gazing into each other's eyes, saying silently: are you sure about this? Isn't this crazy? Are we really doing this?

I was so hard. It was terrifying, but I was so hard. It really was a rollercoaster thing. Scaring myself excited.

I drifted over past the table. The scene of my defeat. Hanna's clothes were still heaped on the bench. Her panties sitting on top. I picked them up. They were still damp. She must have been so turned on. This was huge for her. The whole game had been about three men wanting to sleep with her. She'd been flirting all night. When she'd taken off her bra, her nipples had been hard as diamonds. She'd clearly loved being the center of our attention, our desires.

I pressed her underwear to my nose, breathed in the dark scent of her arousal. Wow. He was going to have this. He was going to have *her*. Another man, with my wife.

I clutched her clothes to me as I crept toward the stairs, and then slowly up to the next floor, at pains to keep the floorboards from creaking. I just about managed it. Outside the chalet, the wind had picked up, flinging the rain about, even shaking the walls slightly. It was enough to cover the occasional creak as I went up.

I walked past the bathroom, and Hayden's room. Past the airing cupboard. Then, I stepped into place outside Jake's room, outside mine and Hanna's room. She'd left the door open—only a crack, but open. I wonder if Jake would even notice. But I would. The sound came through in full stereo, practically.

I could hear them murmuring quietly. Then... the wet noise of kissing. A little quiet laughter—the two of them probably still not quite believing they were being allowed to do this.

I left the door open, and sat nervously on Jake's bed. It felt so weird, I was a little dizzy, my vision swam. I was tired, and it also seemed as

though too much of my blood was currently located in my erection, leaving the rest of my body a little starved of oxygen. I was still so hard.

Five, ten minutes passed. I was perched on the very edge of the bed, waiting for the real stuff to get going—certain that it couldn't be long before I'd be hearing more than just kissing. And yet they were really taking their time. Talking in low voices, kissing. I supposed I was so used to marital sex—where everything usually happened so quickly and efficiently, with so many corners cut—I could hardly conceive that this was simply the elongated foreplay of new lovers, who hadn't even dated.

After a long while, I started wondering if they'd even go as far as oral sex tonight, even though they were allowed to go all the way. Perhaps for the two of them, this really was a first date, and they weren't the types to fuck on the first date.

There was a sustained burst of giggling from Hanna, and some laughter from Jake, and I found myself getting a little annoyed at them—at Jake in particular. Why was he holding back? Why were they just talking? And I have to admit, there was the distinct burn of jealousy in my stomach as I listened intently to what was going on over there.

I tried to keep calm, but the fear was starting to build, too.

The simple fact was that my sexual fantasy seemed built around the prospect of some other guy taking my wife to bed and fucking the hell out of her. Then they'd be finished. I hadn't considered the finer art of seduction as my fantasy had rapidly taken shape. You know, like how two strangers might want to get to know each other a little before they start rubbing up against each other, and joining body parts together.

In spending time getting to know each other better, were Jake and Hanna developing a thing for each other? The thought was terrifying. Why would my wife need to develop something for another man? Why would she need to let feelings into the deal? I could understand her wanting the excitement of a new man, but what was the need for all this talking, all this slow, cautious kissing? An icy jolt ran through me: *what if she actually wanted more than 'just sex'?*

I wanted to go in there, demand to know what was happening. At the same time, I wasn't really supposed to be listening—at least as far as Jake was concerned—and I didn't want to make a fool out of myself. Pride was a big deal, even if I had given up my wife for the night. Plus, despite the jealousy and the fear, I couldn't get away from the fact that I was still massively turned on by the whole thing. Even if they weren't fucking yet, it felt like a strong probability.

Twenty minutes, thirty minutes passed. My hardness was ebbing away a little, particularly as fatigue hit. I had lain down on Jake's bed, not exactly comfortable since I felt it was another guy's bed, but unable to continue sitting up, I was so tired. It was a little odd—I could smell him, in the bed, in the room. His cologne. Ordinarily it would have put me off, I hated catching whiffs of cologne while out and about, in malls or supermarkets or offices or wherever. Guys who wore too much fragrance made me want to hurl. And yet somehow this made me feel closer to what was going on with Hanna. This guy was seducing my wife.

An hour passed. I was close to sleep, I have to admit, though my insides were still churning, and my loins still tingling. There had been a few more bursts of laughter from across the hall, and some more kissing. But I was beginning to think that Hanna and Jake were preparing to sleep—really just sleep—together. To lay politely next to each other and slip off into a deep slumber.

Now, increasingly, I was feeling disappointed. It seemed the way things were turning out was incompatible with the kind of fear and jealousy I had experienced earlier, and yet none of the feelings I had regarding this bizarre new fantasy could be entirely described as logical.

Then the door opened, making me jump and scramble for my shirt in case it was Jake demanding his room back. It was Hanna.

'Hey,' she whispered, offering me a smile. She was wearing her bathrobe, clutching it closed. Her cheeks were gently flushed, her eyes almost black, her pupils were so wide.

'Hey, you all right?'

'I'm supposed to be going to the bathroom,' she said, folding her arms, almost defensively, as though she couldn't risk me seeing too much of her. She wasn't my woman right now, tonight. I'd lost her in a damn game of cards. 'I just wanted to... check on you.'

'I'm okay,' I said, nodding, spreading my lips in a cool and casual smile.

'Seriously?' she said, gravely.

'I'm fine.'

'Because you know you can stop this any time you want.'

I nodded, accepting what she said, even though it didn't entirely feel true. Her eyes told me she was desperately keen not to bring the night's strange excitement to a halt. That maybe if I were to be so selfish as to pull it away from her, it might even affect our relationship. And yet there was pity in her eyes, too.

‘I want it to happen,’ I insisted, meeting her gaze. ‘You know I do.’

She nodded, and now sat on the edge of the bed, some of the tension between us dissolved. ‘It’s just... you know, difficult to know if you’re just doing this to be nice, because you want to help everybody get through this damn week... or if you’re really telling the truth and you... well... like all this.’

‘I am telling the truth,’ I insisted.

She gave another little nod.

As though to prove myself, I asked her, ‘So anything happen between you two yet?’ With a dark little grin that told her I really did think this was hot.

She giggled, and returned a flirty, dark look. ‘Not... yet. I mean... you know, we’ve talked a lot... we’ve been... well, you know... making out.’

‘Seriously?’

She nodded. The pinkness in her cheeks deepened. She looked irresistible.

I sat up, reached for her. Nervously, she allowed me to kiss her. It was nice—warm, sweet, tender. So soft. And I swear, I could detect Jake’s cologne on her, subtly. I know it wasn’t just the smell from this room, since I’d become accustomed to that. This was new. It made my heart rate pick up considerably.

Hanna’s hand slid down over my shoulders as we kissed, glided down my back, and then she was subtly stroking my thigh. I brushed my hands through her dark, silky hair, and down to caress her breasts through her satin bathrobe. Her nipples were hard, I could feel them through the thin material.

As I cupped her breasts, her hand moved up to find my hard cock, her fingers spreading over its full length. It felt good, though I was wearing boxer shorts now. And she moaned in delight, gaining the confirmation she sought that I really was turned on by everything that was happening.

‘So... you guys going to do more than just make out?’ I asked her.

She gave my cock one last little squeeze through my underwear, and her eyes found mine. ‘I think so,’ she said softly, scouring my face for any hint that I wasn’t totally up for this. I think she was a little surprised at me, that I really had been telling the truth all night, that this was what I wanted.

‘You’re sure about this?’ she asked me.

I nodded, my gaze not straying from hers. I had to project confidence, reassurance.

She leaned into me, and I opened myself for a final kiss with her before she went off to cross that boundary at last. To become unfaithful.

That final kiss was the sweetest thus far. She whispered, 'I love you.'

Then she was gone.

Chapter Eight

Now I was wide awake.

I went to the door on my hands and knees, moving incredibly slowly, listening for the tiniest of sounds. I could hear them—and as I poked my head out of the door, I saw the door to the bedroom opposite was still open, and in fact Hanna had left it open a little wider than before.

There had been a little talking when I put my head out of the door, but only the tail-end, and I wasn't in time to catch what was being said. Now, I heard only kissing. Lips sucking on lips, wet mouths pressed against each other. The talking did not resume. There was no laughing, no giggling. Just kissing, maybe a little quiet moaning.

I heard deep breathing, but then there were two loud gasps from Hanna, and the breathing I heard deepened still. My cock stiffened to full hardness again, and I felt the adrenaline racing around my blood vessels—he was going down on her, I could tell.

I don't know if it was something to do with being a third party here, and not part of the action itself, but the sounds she was making were just breathtakingly erotic. Something I perhaps didn't notice when I was with her. But then, also, I was fairly sure Jake was taking his time with her, it was not the rushed series of short cuts that marital sex had become for Hanna and me. I made a mental note that that was something we'd need to correct, in the future. She was panting and crying out and whimpering from the intensity of her experience, and I felt fairly sure I'd never made her sound that way.

Perhaps she was acting up a little, trying to make sure I could hear everything. It sounded real, though. She was reacting to the way he was making her feel.

Moaning, 'Oh God... oh God...'

I glanced down the hallway. Would Hayden be hearing this? It was fairly loud.

After a while—a long while, I thought, considering he was just going down on her—Hanna calmed down, her crying ceased, and there were more kissing sounds. Jake said something to her, though I couldn't hear what. There was a little laughter. And I heard Hanna saying, 'Oh my God...' as though she was laying eyes on his cock for the first time, and she was impressed.

‘Go ahead,’ I heard him say.

‘I don’t know...’

Then, deep breathing, and more wet sounds—different from the kissing. My heart skipped a beat or two as I recognized the noises as Hanna giving him a very wet blow job. Wow. This was getting uber serious. Hanna had said I’d be able to stop things at any moment if I didn’t want her to go through with it. That had been all very well when we’d just been thinking about her being unfaithful.

Now, it was happening. I felt almost paralyzed, pinned to the spot. My wife had her hands—and her lips—wrapped around another man’s hard cock, I knew it. I could hardly believe it.

From the sound of things, she was enjoying it as much as he was—no doubt because it was so unexpected, so against everything she was expecting from marriage. Her first prick that was not mine for years. Jake sounded as though he was in heaven. I felt a strange sense of pride—that she was my wife, and whilst she was taking him to the peaks of pleasure right now, I would get to have her at the end of this one little adventure for Jake.

He sounded as though he very nearly came—but then the noises of her sucking on him ceased.

The two of them were silent for a few moments, and then I started hearing her breathing again, her sighs and quiet moans. He was touching her. Was he fucking her yet? There was that friction sound of skin moving against skin, and then from just outside that bedroom door, I heard packaging being ripped open.

A condom.

For a moment I felt a surge of wild paranoia nearly overwhelm me, as I questioned why Jake would have brought condoms when he knew it would only be me, Hanna and Hayden here at the chalet with him on this trip. My tired, over-stimulated brain suddenly made all kinds of connections that weren’t there—that Hanna and Jake had been having an affair before this trip, that the whole thing had been stage-managed to allow us to play that poker game so that Jake could take Hanna from me.

My paranoia lasted only for a few moments. I crawled across the hallway and slumped down against the wall beside Hanna and Jake’s door, and realized that Jake had been planning on a fairly normal ski vacation where there would be actual skiing, and this resort would be full of people and bars and restaurants that would be teeming with single girls looking for a bit of après-ski fun.

I calmed down, although my heart continued to race along. Jake was using a condom. That was a good thing, health wise. But it was also confirmation that they were about to go all the way. Oh God.

I glanced down the hallway, making sure Hayden was safely closed away in his room. I heard the snap of latex as Jake sheathed his manhood in the condom, and now I knew what was just about to happen.

I had my own hard cock in my hands as I heard a little more kissing, and then Hanna moaning. I knew another man was sliding his big, hard dick into my wife. I heard her little sighs, her little gasps as he filled her, and as he moved within her. I heard her breathing quicken, until she was starting to pant again.

I heard the wet sound of his cock squeezing into her, the noise of his flesh rubbing against hers as he thrust into and out of her body. I heard them moving together on the bed.

And as it progressed, I heard him panting, the bedsprings creaking, and then I could hear his body slamming into hers as he pounded her pussy.

God.

Hanna was moaning as he penetrated her, in genuine and seemingly shocked pleasure, but somehow it seemed different than before. It took me a moment to figure out what the difference was. She wasn't playing it up anymore, she wasn't trying to make sounds so that I might hear through the door—it seemed like now she was actually trying to keep quiet, that she was trying to stifle her full response to Jake's cock entering her. As though I might be offended that she was getting off on it, that she was actually enjoying it.

That she was enjoying his cock more than she usually enjoyed mine.

The jealousy flared again inside me, but it wasn't from the thought she was enjoying another man's cock more than mine—no, that was strangely hot, for some reason—but more from the idea that she might be holding back, trying to keep something from me, hiding her true enjoyment.

After a while, I heard them moving over each other, skin sliding against skin, as the two of them changed positions. Then the rocking of the bed resumed, and Hanna's moaning resumed, though there was no longer any sound of him slamming into her body. I supposed that she was on top now, riding him cowgirl-style. She was still trying to keep quiet. Somehow that fact seemed almost deceitful to me. But they had been

going quite a while—an astounding amount of time, actually, when I finally consulted my watch.

They weren't stopping. This wasn't a ten-minute marital quickie. I heard them change positions another three times, and each time Hanna sounded as though she was nearing orgasm, from her panting, the little catches of her breath, the rising pitch of her moans, even if she was trying to muffle them.

As I listened, my cock was getting a little chafed from my touching it—but I was at the point where I needed only minimal contact to keep it going, any significant squeezes or strokes would set me off spurting everywhere. Wow. A truly marathon session. I guess they were making the most of the prize, and that Jake would spend a whole night with Hanna.

I heard them stop, and thought it must have finally finished. They were talking, though I couldn't hear the conversation over the heavy breathing as they fought to recover their breaths. Something about a water bottle at one point. And a little after that, I'm pretty sure he was directing her to lay a certain way.

Then they started up again. I was staggered. They weren't stopping, not by any stretch of the imagination. He was pounding her again, there was that sound of his body slamming against hers with every thrust. Her cries were more like yelps.

It was three in the morning. Would they ever sleep?

I thought the original plan had been mildly humorous, that if Hanna spent the night with one of the other guys, that they'd end up needing a long lie-in in the morning, and therefore would end up plowing nicely through another boring day in the chalet. But the way this was shaping up, they were going to end up needing to sleep through the entire day.

I was a little horrified, though it didn't reduce the level of arousal I felt.

Then she was gasping and crying out his name:

'Oh... fuck... oh yes... Oh Jake... yes... Jake...'

That was the final straw for me, there was no way back from that. The sound of my wife's voice. My wife calling out another man's name as he slammed his big, hard cock into her eager pussy.

I felt myself beginning to go, and what somewhat spoiled the full effect was the panic that shot through me, that it was happening, that I was coming, sitting here on the hallway floor. I was up on my feet, rushing to the bathroom as quickly and silently as I could, grabbing at the toilet roll only just in time.

As I came into a wad of soft toilet tissue— feeling all sweaty and a little embarrassed, praying Hayden didn't pick this moment to visit the bathroom himself—I swear, I heard Hanna coming in the other room. With another guy. Though she was trying to muffle it with pillows or bedsheets or something, that was definitely what it was.

I felt like I hadn't heard her making those sounds in a while.

I was jealous, I even felt a little lonely, strangely. I still felt a little aroused, even after my own orgasm.

I don't know what I was expecting as I came out of the bathroom. Maybe the sight of Hanna, hovering in my doorway, trying to make sure I was all right. Sweaty from her bout of infidelity. Sexy and dangerous in the dull light of the bare bulb hanging from the hallway ceiling. Ready to join me.

She wasn't there. As I came out of the bathroom, I saw instantly that the door to Hanna and Jake's room—and I did now think of it as their room, not mine and my wife's—was now closed. Who had closed it? I felt cold, excluded. I was nervous that Hanna really was going to spend the night with Jake. Wrapped up in his arms.

Then, despite the fact that the sound was now blocked considerably by the door, I heard them starting up again. Fucking. Still. And though things were muffled now, it seemed from what I could hear that they were letting go a lot more, that they were no longer worried about being heard. They felt free to completely let go.

I seethed with jealousy. Hanna was keeping me out. It felt strangely like actual cheating.

And yet I was hard as a rock again, mere moments after coming.

It was the most intensely erotic experience I'd ever had.

Part Two: **Dealer's Choice**

Chapter Nine

She really did spend the whole night with him. There was no dashing out at 3am, 4am, whatever, to see if I was okay, to give me a quick fuck to show me she was still mine in heart and soul. When I woke at 4am, I hauled myself out of bed and went to lurk in the doorway again, and there was absolutely no sound other than the wind and the rain outside.

I think I might even have felt better if I'd woken up at that hour to hear that they were still at it, still fucking. Instead, I stood there with the full horror that they were merely asleep in there together, perhaps cuddled up like affectionate lovers.

I know, that was the deal we'd made. She would spend the night with the winner of the damn card game. Somehow I'd kind of assumed she'd sneak out of there to join me once Jake was asleep. Or that she'd boot him out once they were finished screwing. But this was the deal. Together, all night.

I wondered if Jake's initial expectation, when he and Hanna went upstairs together like that after the game, was that she would simply sleep next to him all night. That they'd get to chat, socialize a little. He might see her naked for a few moments until she put on her PJs. That kind of thing. Instead, she'd gone through with the full interpretation of the deal: he could do whatever he liked with her. Spending the night with her meant sleeping with her, in the full, lust-filled and sweaty physical sense of the phrase.

Now, in the early hours of the morning, I stood across the hall from them, and the clean, innocent meaning of the phrase 'spending the night' seemed more dangerous. Although, I suppose they had already fucked. Clean and innocent was long gone.

My jealousy was at its peak, my sense of horror and despair hitting me hard. And yet, I was still mightily turned on. I wanted Hanna more than ever before. I waited a long while before finally trudging back to bed, finding it difficult to get back to sleep with an erection like that.

*

Daylight came at six, and I was up with it. Tired, but full of too much nervous adrenaline to sleep in. It felt as though I had SATs to pass that

day, tests that would have more impact on my future than even my college degree.

I guess my subconscious felt that when Hanna emerged from her night with Jake, I would have to win her back. My heart was thumping, I felt vaguely nauseous, my skin was all clammy, my palms sweaty.

I made myself some breakfast—some of the local cereal, which was just about close enough to corn flakes to be edible, but not all that far removed from animal feed—and sat on the window seat, gazing out at the continuing rain and the miserable muddy street outside.

There was no sound from upstairs. I supposed that the whole aim of making last night a big one was that we should all try to sleep in as long as possible today, to get through the tedium unconscious. It felt slightly unfair that I couldn't sleep. My body was so energized by anxiety and—still—arousal that I was never going to be able to fully relax.

An hour later, I was even contemplating putting on waterproof coats and pants and going for a walk or hike in the misery outside.

Then Hayden came downstairs, looking fresh and well rested.

'Hey, how's it going?' he said, his broad smile warm and friendly.

'Oh, you know,' I grinned in return, trying to seem calm, like nothing unusual had happened at all.

He nodded. 'They still—?'

'Sleeping in,' I said casually as a shiver sauntered down my spine.

He hesitated just a fraction of a second, but it seemed like an age to me—his eyes flickering over my face, taking me in, working out whether I was devastated by what Hanna had done with Jake the previous night, or whether I really didn't care. The truth was neither, but I felt the preferable demeanor was the latter, acting as though it wasn't a big deal my wife going off to fool around with another guy.

Then he was heading into the kitchen area, to fetch himself the same kind of breakfast I'd finished off an hour before.

'So... you slept okay last night?' he asked me, keeping up his air of friendliness and positivity, as though he was secretly concerned for my mental wellbeing.

'Oh, so-so,' I said, feeling about as awkward as I could get.

'You were... on the couch, right?'

He put his cereal bowl down on the island and looked at me as though he suddenly needed confirmation that he hadn't dreamt the whole strip poker thing, and the fact that my wife had slept with our friend.

'I was... up in Jake's room,' I said.

He nodded, and went on fixing his breakfast.

God it was so awkward. But that week, in that chalet, the rain still pouring down outside, what else was there to talk about? Everything either of us said was like trying to break the ice in the conversation.

‘So... are you okay, buddy?’ he asked me.

I shrugged. ‘I’m fine.’

He wandered over to the table carrying his over-filled cereal bowl carefully to avoid spillage.

‘Seriously?’

‘Really, I’m okay.’

With the cereal bowl safely on the table, he pulled out a chair and sat facing me.

‘Cause, you know, you can talk to me about it.’

‘I know, thanks,’ I gave him a smile that appreciated his concern, his friendship. ‘But really, I’m fine.’

He nodded, but gave the impression he didn’t entirely believe me.

‘You guys... ever done anything like this before?’ he asked.

‘Nope,’ I confirmed.

‘Pretty crazy,’ he smiled again, still striding that knife-edge of awkwardness.

I nodded, ‘Pretty crazy.’

Then, in almost an unguarded outburst, as though he spoke before thinking, he said, ‘I don’t think I could do it.’

I laughed, I couldn’t help it. It was the awkwardness of everything that amused me as much as what the big, strong, alpha-male Hayden had said. I didn’t even mean to laugh—it just erupted from me, no thought required. It seemed to defuse the tension between us, though.

I said, ‘You’ve never been married.’

‘No.’

‘You’ve never even dated someone for longer than... what... three months?’

He tilted his head left then right, considering his long, illustrious dating history, before refuting my claim. ‘I was with Hilary Fowler for close on six months.’

‘But from my recollection... you also dated that girl from your accounts department... and the barista... while you were with Hilary Fowler. Right?’

He hung his head slightly. ‘Guilty as charged. So... so what you’re saying is, if you’re with someone for longer than six months...’

‘Probably a fair bit longer than six months.’

‘... You don’t care if she goes off... you know... with another guy?’ Hayden was somewhat stunned by the thought.

I pulled myself up from the window seat, intending to get a drink from the kitchen, more as a distraction than actually because I was thirsty. I thought a glass of water might hide my blushing face.

‘It’s not such a big deal,’ I insisted, sticking to a tactic of downplaying everything. I didn’t want to fess up to finding it sexually stimulating that Hanna was with someone else, although now I started wondering if Hanna had mentioned my secret to Jake while they’d been sleeping together all night. ‘It’s just sex.’

‘But sex with *your* woman.’

Standing in front of the sink, I chuckled. ‘My woman? It’s not as though I own her.’

‘But she is your wife. You’ve chosen her. You’re... sleeping with her. Usually.’

‘You know, she’ll come back from being with Jake... and she’ll still be my wife,’ I pointed out. ‘She’s not going to leave me for Jake after one night with him.’

‘You hope.’

I turned to him, glass of water in hand, and smiled. ‘I trust her. You can’t understand it because you’ve never had that level of connection with someone.’

I thought he might deny it, that somewhere deep in his past there had been someone who had some kind of connection with him. But he didn’t. He just shrugged acceptance of what I said.

‘So you just... let her sleep with him... and then, what? You get to sleep with another woman when we get home?’

I shook my head. ‘I don’t think it works that way. This is... you know... a one-time deal. Because we’re having such an awful time here until the damn shuttle bus comes back.’

‘You don’t think there’d be some kind of leverage?’ he laughed. ‘I mean... if it was me, I’d push it. You know: “Hanna, you slept with someone else on vacation... I say I get to sleep with someone else now.” ’

‘It’s not like that for us...’ I felt the awkwardness creeping back in—I knew it sounded illogical, saying I didn’t think I would want to sleep with another woman after this incident between Hanna and Jake. But I couldn’t tell him what made it seem logical to me: that I only wanted Hanna, that what she was doing turned me on, and rendered other women... well, pointless to me just then.

He shrugged. I really didn't expect him to understand. We were different kinds of people, even though we were good friends. He dated someone until the sex began to seem stale, or until someone else turned his head. And then he simply moved on, no big deal.

'When you date someone,' I said to him, returning to my seat at the window, 'does it freak you out that she's had sex with other guys before you?'

He paused to think about it. 'Uh-uh... I guess not.'

'You don't only date virgins.'

'God, no.'

'And when you start dating someone, do you make it clear to her that you're exclusive as soon as you start sleeping with her?'

'Uh-uh,' he shook his head. 'I don't...'

He didn't seem to understand the concept of exclusivity.

'So a girl you're dating... could be dating someone else at the same time?' I asked him.

'Maybe,' he shrugged.

'So you see... it's not really a big deal.'

He furrowed his brow, as though he really hadn't thought too much about it. He said, 'I guess so. I guess... when I'm dating someone... I don't think too much about who she's dated before me.'

'So, there you go,' I smiled, as though my whole case was proven. As though I wasn't in the least bit unusual, accepting my wife sleeping with another man.

'So you're not... you know... angry... at Jake?' he asked.

'Why should I be?'

'Well... I mean, if I'm dating someone... and a friend starts dating her as well...'

'You'd be angry at him?'

Hayden shrugged. 'I guess... it doesn't matter.'

I felt secure in myself just then, the awkwardness dispelled. Only, then we started to hear something from upstairs—the bang-bang-bang sound of a headboard knocking rhythmically against a bedroom wall, starting quietly, but getting louder and louder.

I felt my insides churn. Jake was fucking Hanna again.

'They're at it again,' Hayden nodded, tilting his head slightly to listen.

'Yeah,' I shrugged, and tried looking out of the window as though I really didn't give a damn.

After a while, we heard her moaning.

That awkwardness was back between Hayden and me. I had to hide my erection from him, which made me sit weirdly. I was considering the fact that Hanna didn't have to keep fucking him—the night was over, as soon as you woke up. Technically, this was outside of the deal. Along with the butterflies in my stomach, I felt a strange twinge that almost seemed as though I considered Hanna to be verging on cheating now. Bizarrely, it didn't lessen my sexual excitement over what was going on.

'Well... they're passing the time, huh?' I said, as though that was the priority for us in that chalet. All other considerations were secondary.

'Yeah,' Hayden nodded. Then he added, 'Hey, you want to see if we can walk down to the grocery store before getting completely soaked to the skin?'

I laughed. 'Sure.'

Well, as arousing as I found the strange sound of my wife being fucked by somebody else just upstairs, the thought of getting out of there did feel safer, less complicated. Wrapped up in our waterproof coats and pants, the rain battering down all over us, there was no room for conversation. We could just about communicate by turning to each other and pointing. There could be no awkward pauses, no embarrassment.

We went down to the grocery to see if there had been a fresh delivery of edible foods. Or to try to find something among the aisles that we'd missed before.

And I guess I was thinking that if we still had a few days to go, and Hanna had used up her star idea of sleeping with the winner of our poker game, what were we all going to do to fill up the rest of our time at the chalet?

*

When Hayden and I returned to the chalet, having found precious little of anything to even vaguely entertain ourselves at the grocery store, Jake and Hanna were out of the bedroom, freshly showered and dressed, eating a late breakfast as though nothing untoward had happened whatsoever.

I found myself wondering if they'd showered together, if they'd had one last fuck under the flow of the water.

Both of them were eating the regulation breakfast cereal, with Hanna sat on the window seat and Jake over at the table—the two of

them separate, as though attempting to disassociate from each other following their night of complete togetherness. Hanna was wearing a small—deliberately small, it seemed—denim skirt and dark hose covering her long legs, along with a white button-down shirt that opened just far enough to reveal a hint of her purple bra.

‘Find anything good at the store?’ Hanna asked us, looking over at me as though to check I wasn’t insane with jealousy or otherwise crazy angry with her. I smiled at her, and saw distinct relief in her features as she reflected it back at me.

‘Are you kidding?’ Hayden laughed. ‘It’s probably against the law to sell anything ‘good’ there.’

‘You found something,’ Jake pointed out.

I was unpacking various items clutched in two large plastic carrier bags. ‘We thought we might try making a cake,’ I said, holding up a large box of eggs and a bag of very basic-looking flour.

Hanna giggled, and it seemed to me she was energized by the belief I wasn’t upset with her. ‘You never made a cake in your life!’

‘Can’t be that difficult,’ I shrugged.

‘They have a recipe down at the store? Because you know we don’t even have Slovakian Google up here.’

Slumped down on the couch, Hayden cackled. ‘He’s got some genius plan to just work it out.’

I shrugged, ‘We’ve got plenty of time, right? And plenty of ingredients for testing batches...’

Hayden pointed out, ‘It was, like, nine cents for a truck load of flour.’

Jake was laughing at us, and in his laughter I also sensed some kind of relief, that I clearly didn’t hate him for what had happened overnight, that I was talking as though we were still all friends, as though nothing much had happened between himself and my wife.

As Hanna wandered over to the kitchen area to check on the quality of our ingredients, I could see my old college buddy scrutinizing me carefully, though subtly, to see how I responded to her. I tried to act naturally, casually, nonchalant. I’m not entirely sure I pulled it off.

‘Wow, you really did buy a lot,’ she said, eyeing the bags I’d dumped on the counter.

Then she turned to me, and stretched up on her tiptoes to kiss my lips. I welcomed her sweet lips, though it struck me immediately as significant that they were waxy with lipstick. Her big, green eyes were

also highlighted by mascara and eyeliner, and as I breathed her in, my chest was filled with her perfume.

She was very definitely on show, courting male attention. I was thrilled.

I was so thrilled, I was trembling a little. Where had those lips been before touching lightly against mine?

‘Still love me?’ she said, raising an eyebrow. Knowing the answer immediately from my stunned expression, my adoring eyes.

‘Uh-huh,’ I said.

She leaned back, pressing her butt up against the edge of the island counter, and with her back to the other guys, she pulled me in for a longer, deeper kiss. I sucked on her sweet lips, doing my best to get my head around the fact that she’d been kissing another guy with these lips all night, and no doubt had stretched them around another man’s cock. She’d showered since then, but it didn’t stop the fact that these lips had been unfaithful.

When we came up for air, Hanna smiled a wicked, self-satisfied smile. She placed her hand over my crotch, pressing it against my hard cock through my pants, feeling for herself what I thought of her.

‘You still want me?’ she said, quietly so the others couldn’t hear.

‘More than ever,’ I said. ‘Can’t you tell?’

She smirked.

Then she said— shouted, it seemed, though I realized she was only talking a little above her normal volume— ‘But you know, sweetie, that if you want to sleep with me this week, you have to win at poker.’

Jake and Hayden’s ears pricked up at that.

‘I thought we’d all agreed on the rules already?’ she said.

‘Everything that happens in this chalet is our solemn secret. And we have nothing really else to do the rest of this week...’

I felt a strange confluence of dread and pure delight.

Chapter Ten

I turned to find Jake and Hayden gazing at us with surprise and lust and doubt plastered all over their faces, as though the government had just declared a second Christmas would take place, and they really couldn't quite believe whether it would really happen despite the official announcement.

'Please tell me this new arrangement ends when we get home,' I said, playing the disappointed cuckold, still painfully aware that this open-to-all sexual contest was the only game in a very dull town. 'I am terrible at poker.'

She covered her mouth with a coy hand as she giggled, though her other hand was checking out my throbbing hard-on, hidden from the others' view. 'As soon as we leave this chalet, everything is forgotten,' she said. 'Nothing ever happened.'

She had a twinkle in her eye as she said this to me, as though she was silently confirming to me that, actually, nothing would be forgotten if it made me as hard as this, although as far as Jake and Hayden were involved, the adventure would end.

'So when does the next game start?' I asked her.

'I thought you guys were going to try baking a cake?' she grinned. I shrugged. Jake piped up, 'Who needs cake?'

Hanna laughed again. 'I do. As soon as you have something edible to share, we can start the next game.'

The cake came, of course, although it nearly didn't. Three guys all jostling to get something good enough to start the game as early as possible, and we were proving the maxim about too many cooks.

It took until the late afternoon, but eventually we had something to tantalize the taste buds. And then we convened around the table with a deck of cards, tantalized for a whole other reason.

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This time, the game seemed much more serious.

Oh, we still had fun. We still played the strip version of poker. But this time everyone played with a whole lot more gravity and caution, we agreed to certain rules—like an equal number of clothing items that

everyone was allowed to wear at the beginning—and we abided by them carefully.

It was like the difference between a casual kick about with a ball in a park, and a proper game with a referee and teams playing for a trophy. Because we knew what our trophy was now. Hanna had proven herself—we knew that the winner of this game would get to spend the night with her, and we knew what that actually meant. She had spent the night with Jake after he had won the first game. And she had fucked him, through the night and into the morning.

And Jake certainly wasn't out of the running just because he'd already tasted the spoils of victory. He was gunning for a win just as much as anyone, desperate for a second night with my wife, as much as Hayden was for a first, and I was for a night of reconnection and reclamation.

In fact, things seemed much more even. None of us had particularly rotten luck, none of us were running away with a victory. Jake lost his football jersey, and then his shoes. I lost my baseball hat. Hanna lost her hooded top. Hayden lost his shoes and his socks.

We were all muted, we were all sharply focused on the cards, or at least the guys were. You could tell that Hanna loved how serious we all were about winning, even if she was trying to fit in with our new serious attitude her wry grin kept on breaking through.

During the game, Hanna's confidence was running supreme, and it was just plain hot to watch. She was a little flirty here and there with Hayden, though perhaps a little more cautious than the previous day. What I could hardly fail to notice, though, even if she was trying to conceal it, was a special connection between Hanna and Jake.

Out of all of us, she seemed to tease Jake the most, she taunted him with the possibility of her sleeping with one of us instead, as though he was her default sleeping partner, rather than me, her husband. She seemed particularly amused and delighted each time Jake had to remove an item of clothing, compared to when Hayden or I had to do so. Well, she had spent all night with Jake, and from what I heard, and the length of their lie-in in the morning, there hadn't been much sleeping going on during the night hours. There was clearly a connection there, and he was the last person to sleep with her. The way they were together, their obvious chemistry, tugged at my heartstrings and stoked the embers of my jealousy all night—though it also seemed to help spice up my simmering arousal.

Hayden lost his shirt, then I lost my shoes and then shortly afterward my sweater. Hanna lost her shoes. Jake lost his socks and then a t-shirt, only to reveal an identical t-shirt underneath.

‘Hey, I still started with as many things as you did,’ he insisted over the suspicions that he was trying to pull a fast one on us, somehow. We counted. He was right enough.

He lost his second identical t-shirt soon enough.

Hayden lost his pants, and revealed that underneath he had a pair of long basketball shorts on over his underwear, which also caused mirth and a recount of his clothing items. He, too, complied with our overall seven item quota, however.

It was no big deal when one of us guys removed clothing, of course, at least from my point of view. Hanna squealed in delight, naturally, and tried to act as though every new piece of flesh one of us guys revealed made her feel just a little hornier. It might have been true. She was so sexy anyway, what did it matter? I liked to think it was turning her on, three guys battling for her like this.

It was more of a big deal when Hanna lost an item of clothing—for her, because she acted all coy, even if we had all seen her naked by now and two of us had slept with her; and for us, because she was our trophy, and we all wanted her so badly. She lost her long-sleeve t-shirt to leave her in a blue tank top, bra and black sheer pantyhose, and her outfit was form-fitting enough to tantalize our gazes even before her stripping became explicit. Her nipples were poking hard through her bra and tank top to show us that she was just as hot for this as we were.

I was watching her closely, as both a guy hoping desperately to sleep with her that night, and a husband who was just fascinated that this beautiful woman was both his wife and a confirmed adulteress. She was both familiar to me and a complete stranger all in one, it seemed. I’d seen her naked before so many times, I’d fucked her so many times. And yet now she had lain with another man—and several times, at that, having fucked him all night long, and through into the morning..

She lost her tank top to reveal a fairly plain black bra, and I could see in her eyes she wished she’d brought some sexy lingerie on this trip of ours. Before the trip, though, she hadn’t been of the mentality that she would need to dress sexy. She didn’t usually make an effort to seduce me these days, it was largely assumed she didn’t have to.

Watching her, I realized that if she was wearing panties beneath her hose, she would have had eight items along with the bra and the skirt she

still wore, and the things she'd removed. Was she wearing nothing beneath her pantyhose?

I was winning for a short period, but although I deeply desired the chance to reclaim my pretty wife after her night with Jake, that strange part of me that had so relished her being with someone else the night before felt oddly hopeful that this night might, perhaps, belong to Hayden.

By then, of course, I knew how it felt to have my wife sleep with someone else. I knew it wasn't so bad on the jealousy score. The excitement for me, if Hayden won my wife, would far surpass my feelings of insecurity and jealousy, even if those negative aspects were not gone entirely.

However, at the same time I was increasingly nervous about Hanna spending a second night with Jake. If she did—and if the cards fell right, she would have to—it felt to me that her repeat exposure might stir something in her that went beyond the mere physical. If she slept with Jake again, I worried she would be increasingly at risk of falling for him. I was flooded with fear and paranoia.

As the game wore on, Hayden lost his shorts to reveal black-and-white Raiders boxers, then I lost my socks followed quickly by my t-shirt—leaving me in pants and boxers only—it felt as though Jake's run of luck might be shifting.

With Hanna apparently one item better off than the rest of us at that point, a new concern presented itself to me. What if Hanna won the game, and got to choose who she spent the night with? Would she choose her husband? It felt to me as though that was her natural choice—and yet she might decide that the opportunity to sleep with someone else was too rare to pass up on this failure of a ski vacation. Okay, so she might choose a night with Hayden since she hadn't been with him already.

My real fear was that she would choose Jake.

Choosing Jake might signal that she felt she had unfinished business with him, that she had so enjoyed spending the night with him she was craving more. That a romantic connection might be forming between them, and she might want to pursue it.

She might be less intimidated by a night with Jake because she'd already been with him, of course. She might feel that even if we'd all pledged solemnly never to reveal what went on in this ski chalet, that choosing to sleep with Jake would make her less of a 'slut', and therefore less open to social shaming, if the secret ever came out, compared to the prospect of her sleeping with every guy in the chalet this week.

The prospect of her choosing Jake became more and more likely, it seemed to me, because I feared it, and because she appeared more positive toward Jake's wins than anyone else's. A few times that evening I had noticed her trying to check herself, trying to appear more impartial between us. Later on, her flirting with Jake increased, and her delight at his victories alongside it.

So that all brought me round to be much more supportive of Hayden than I'd been before that evening. Suddenly, if I was up against him during a round, the others having folded perhaps, I would find a subtle way to hand the win to him. I bluffed to the point where we could both knock Jake, and Hanna if possible, out of the round, and then I'd reveal my bluff as though I wasn't good enough to keep up the presence against Hayden. I would fold strategically against him even if I did actually have good cards.

Nevertheless, there was little I could do if Jake or Hanna had genuinely good cards. I lost my pants, leaving me only in boxer shorts. Hayden lost his boxers, only to reveal he had a pair of briefs underneath, much to our amusement.

'Count them, bitches,' Hayden crowed, and true enough those briefs were his seventh item out of seven.

Hanna lost her skirt, which was great, but then while I was peering between her legs trying to ascertain whether she had, indeed, foregone panties that evening, I lost my final item, my boxers.

'I think someone's a little too happy he just lost,' Jake said as I fought to hide my erection now that I had to sit there naked as two other guys attempted to win my wife for the night.

I blushed deeply, and held my clothes over my lap, insisting: 'She's sitting there in her underwear.' As though Hanna's semi-exposed body was enough to explain my hard-on.

'She's your wife!' Jake chuckled. 'You guys have been married, what, three or four years...'

'Seven,' Hanna corrected him.

'Seven? Geez... you're not supposed to be that hot for your wife by now, dude,' Jake joked.

'Just because you can't get it up, man,' Hayden said, coming to my aid just as I felt humiliation set in. He moved his hands away from his lap to show us the sizable bulge in his briefs—it was almost as though he was making a pitch for Hanna to choose him if she won.

'Hey, I don't need to get a boner while I play cards,' Jake insisted. 'And hey, I didn't get any complaints last night, my friends.'

Now Hanna was blushing, as we all looked at her and it seemed suddenly so out there that she had slept with Jake last night, instead of her husband.

Hanna attempted to distract all the attention by ordering me to give up the pile of clothes I was using as a shield for my lap. ‘You know the rules,’ she declared. Jake reached over to grab the clothes from my clutches. My consolation prize was that Hanna craned her neck to look over the table at my hard cock, and she seemed quietly content at how turned on I clearly was.

Next up, Jake lost his jeans after getting too cocky and going all in on a pair of Kings and a pair of eights, which Hayden beat out with three sixes. Hanna seemed to particularly enjoy watching Jake peel off his jeans, and the way she teased him that he only had one item left... well, she hadn’t teased me quite like that. It was as though she was dangling herself in front of him, hinting that she was his for the taking again that night, unless he messed it up.

She leaned over, staring at him as he sat down in just his boxers, and said to him dryly, ‘What, you’re not even a little bit stiff down there?’

‘You just wait, Missy,’ he replied. ‘I’m just saving it for later.’

‘A girl could feel kind of unwanted,’ she pouted.

Jake had chuckled, ‘Why waste it until I can give it to you? And anyway, you know there’s not gonna be a problem once I win this damn game.’

‘Mmm...’ she’d given him a seductive, sideways glance at that, and licked her lips as though she couldn’t wait.

My jealousy flared. But I liked it.

Can you like being jealous? It was kind of a perverse thought. Jealousy is defined as insecurity, fear, concern, envy over someone or something you might lose to a rival—how could I enjoy insecurity, fear, concern or envy?

The thing was, my jealousy was all bundled in with my desire for Hanna to be naughty, for someone else to defile her, for her to enjoy it all and then come running back to me to prove her love for me still reigned supreme. Only, at the same time, the possibility that she might harbor love for Jake as well—and that her love for me might not therefore reign supreme—did threaten to tip the balance of my emotions toward fear of losing her.

The dark, depraved side of me started wondering what it might be like after all, if Jake won and she did develop stronger feelings for him.

Would it mean she'd stop loving me? Stop wanting me? Maybe it wouldn't. I had to believe it wouldn't. She'd married me. I'd never done anything wrong, I'd never done anything to make her actively dislike me.

But, I was still hoping for a Hayden win, now that I was out of the running.

However, Hanna was winning at that point, sitting there in her bra, her skirt and her pantyhose. Possibly with some panties underneath, though not if she'd started with the regulation seven items. Hayden and Jake had only underwear and would crash out with a single loss. I think most of all, I didn't want Hanna to win, as I feared that she would choose Jake.

Relief, then, when she lost the next round, and chose to lose her bra, rather than her skirt. That kind of confirmed to me that she wasn't wearing panties. Kind of hot, partly because it said to me she felt sexier in sheer pantyhose than in the plain underwear she'd brought for the trip.

I'd been quietly trying to keep calm and not think of the possibility of Hanna fucking one of my friends, in order to help my erection subside, and yet now here was Hanna unveiling her small but perky breasts to all, and the sight of how stiff her nipples were just took me right back to full hardness. She glanced over at me, and the faint blush in her cheeks only made it worse. She was so unbelievably hot just then, I could hardly cope. Anyway, what did an erection matter now? Everyone had seen it by now. And I didn't have to be embarrassed about my size or anything like that.

We were still treading on a knife-edge: Hayden had only one item to lose, and if he was out Hanna would be free to spend the night with Jake either way.

I was thankful, then, that Hanna lost again, and this time had to remove her skirt. She managed to unfasten the thing and whip it out from under her with just a slight lifting of her butt from the seat—allowing her to avoid standing up to strip. It meant she was able to largely conceal herself, and what lay between her thighs beneath her dark but sheer pantyhose. None of us were bold enough to challenge her on it, even considering the fact that she had earlier refused to allow me to conceal my hard-on when I had stripped to full nudity. I think none of us wanted to anger her in case the night came down to Hanna choosing with whom to spend the night.

Anyway. So, here it was: Sudden death. Anyone who lost a round would be out of the game instantly. My heart was thumping ferociously as I watched. I trusted Hanna, and I felt confident that all this really was just a game, a diversion to help us all through the abominable tedium of the vacation. I knew it was paranoia that made me worry about her falling for Jake. In this final round, when I caught sight of Hanna checking out the impressive bulge in Hayden's briefs for a moment or two, I even started to wonder if she might form romantic attachments to him instead, if Hayden won over Jake.

Hanna lost the round, though only just. We had to debate whether a flush beat a straight, and Hayden's flush came out on top so that he claimed her remaining pistachio nut shell chips. I felt some relief that I would not have to face Hanna choosing who she slept with that night, and choosing Jake over her husband.

Again, she tried to strip without standing up. And yet to remove her pantyhose, to peel the thin black nylon down her legs, she had to push the chair back from the table—and this afforded us a stunning view of her full nudity anyway.

I stifled a gasp as I laid eyes on her newly hairless pussy.

I saw Hayden's jaw drop as he laid eyes on it, too. Only Jake seemed to take the development calmly, merely smiling lustfully at the sight of her sweet, freshly shaven sex. Jesus. It was completely free of any hair, not even a narrow landing strip left behind. Had she shaven her pussy especially for him? I'd never seen anything like it—she'd never done anything like that for me. As much as I enjoyed the eroticism of a little fuzz down there, the sight of her like that was just so different—and so unlike the Hanna I thought I knew so well—it really hit me hard.

It almost made me forget the fact that Hanna losing out now confirmed that I definitely would not get to spend the night with her that night.

'You okay, buddy?' Hayden asked me, apparently sensing that I might be upset that my wife would definitely be in someone else's bed again for a night.

I shrugged, 'It's the game, isn't it?'

I got pity from him, and a little mischievous smirk from Jake, but after a few moments I was back to feeling excited for the night. I felt a strange kind of pressure inside me that I now knew my Hanna would be sleeping with—and fucking—someone else that night, and yet it also felt to me as though the tension inside me would merely make it extra special when I did finally get to sleep with her myself. By that point she would

have been extra wicked, she would have been twice as unfaithful, she would be even sexier to me than ever.

The final round saw Jake versus Hayden. It was seriously tense. I looked across at Hanna, and though she was trying to conceal it, I strongly suspected that she was hoping for a Jake win. It made me feel a little sick to my stomach, but I told myself that she was only hoping for more time with him because she felt more comfortable going with a guy she'd already been with. I was quietly pushing for Hayden, of course, though I couldn't show my support in any obvious way because of how it might be taken by the other guys. Jake might think I had a grudge against him after his night in Hanna's bed. Hayden might think I harbored some kind of bisexual feelings for him or something.

It seemed like the longest round of all. Like an epic Wimbledon final, the points went this way and then that, with Hayden grabbing a load of pistachio shells from Jake before Jake then won them back and then some, and vice versa.

Then, finally, here it was. Hayden was betting strongly, and yet Jake was keeping up. They both went all in, and then they both laid their cards on the table.

And I gasped.

Chapter Eleven

Yeah, you probably guessed it.

Jake had won a second night with my wife. I was kind of hurt, kind of horrified—and yet still, that dark side of me was somehow ecstatic. My hard-on was back in force. Now that the game was over, I felt confident about hiding it with my pile of clothes again—and across the table I saw Hanna pulling on her bra again, shortly followed by her skirt as she became a little modest again, particularly compared to the previous evening's nude march upstairs with Jake.

Jake stood in his boxer shorts and roared, victorious. I didn't hate him for winning—of course he would try for another night with Hanna, if he could. And he had been perfectly allowed to do so. I did try to assess how Hanna responded to Jake's victory without looking as though I was scrutinizing her too closely. She was, plainly, delighted that Jake had won. She let out a squeal before remembering to contain her excitement in case it offended Hayden or myself.

She was happy. But was she already in love with him?

My heart strings were being tugged all over the place. My stomach was being squeezed and shoved and prodded all over the place, while a cloud of butterflies seemed to be attacking from within. I had never, ever been so nervous in my life. Even before my driving test.

Hayden threw his hands up and gave a loud, exasperated sigh, as though he'd kind of expected to lose, and that he'd been wrong to hold out hope of any other outcome from tonight's game. Did that mean he sensed Hanna's affinity for Jake, too? I wondered.

He said simply, 'I'm out. Good night.'

And then he was on his feet, grabbing his clothes under one arm, sullenly shuffling toward the stairs and away. He hadn't even removed his briefs, that final forfeit for the losing man, and it seemed that unlike the previous night, no one was going to bother enforcing the rule. I didn't care if Hayden got naked or not. It was only Hanna who would be interested in the guy getting his big dick out for her to see for a few moments, anyway, and she was clearly too absorbed in the fact that Jake had just won a second night with her.

Hayden was a forlorn figure as he went upstairs, seemingly totally excluded from the party. I found myself watching him go, feeling sorry for him to the point where I was almost distracted from the way Hanna

and Jake now came together, like lovers reunited after an enforced break, Hanna completely naked and Jake in only his boxer shorts.

‘I can’t believe it,’ Hanna said, beaming brightly from ear to ear as she pressed her forehead against his, a move that seemed so totally romantic and affectionate that it felt like my heart was being shredded to watch.

‘Didn’t I tell you I was good at poker?’ he said, his smile as broad as hers as their hands clasped together, and then their bodies came together, and then their lips came together.

I stifled another gasp.

They were kissing, passionately, right in front of me. Had they forgotten I was there? When I’d first discussed the strange fantasy I had with Hanna, the idea had been to watch her with someone else. Was she testing that idea now? Was she seeing if I wanted to watch this?

‘Well you’re hard now,’ I heard Hanna saying quietly before sniggering, and then Jake was chuckling too.

Wow. I could see her almost bare breasts crushed against his chest, her stiff nipples would be pressing against him and making her libido crazy. I saw them slipping each other the tongue as they kissed, and the way she grabbed his ass as she held him, I knew she was clamping herself against his hard cock, feeling how hot he was for her.

Their chemistry was so obvious, so powerful to watch. It was absolutely terrifying to me—and yet the most arousing thing I’d ever seen.

I sat still, feeling incredibly awkward to be there, and yet so turned on. At least I could hold my clothes in front of my erection by now. I thought they had to know I was there, that any moment they’d excuse themselves and head upstairs for another night behind closed doors. But they didn’t seem to notice me. They continued making out passionately for what seemed like ages.

Then, at last, I cleared my throat, thinking that if they weren’t going to excuse themselves, then I would excuse myself. It wasn’t that I didn’t want to watch—oh, I did. I suspected that perhaps I wouldn’t be able to handle what I saw—based on how I felt about them simply kissing—but I did want to watch nevertheless. Even so, Jake was one of my best friends. I feared that it would be forever awkward between us if I watched him fuck my wife and he knew I was there watching.

I cleared my throat, and the two of them broke apart, surprised to find me still there.

Jake said, ‘Oh... uh... sorry, man. I didn’t realize—’

He was blushing. Hanna was blushing. Yet they still held each other close, as though they needed to use each other to conceal their most personal naked parts from my sight.

‘Hey, Sweetie,’ Hanna said, her face full of pity for me, and yet at the same unapologetic because I’d known what losing the game would mean. ‘Are you okay?’

‘Uh... yeah,’ I said, attempting to sound bright and breezy and not at all downhearted about what was going on in front of my very own eyes. ‘I was just going to... you know... say good night... get out of your way...’

For a moment, I wondered if Hanna might make even a half-hearted offer to call off her anticipated night of adultery. She didn’t. She did say, ‘I love you,’ which was something, and the more I thought about it later, the more significant it felt to me. She turned to me slightly, and I could just about see between her legs—enough to remind me that she’d shaved her pussy for him. God.

Had the evening’s poker game been a complete set-up? I supposed it would be hard to do, but the two of them did have a 50% chance of Hanna getting to be with Jake, assuming she would have chosen him if she’d won the game.

I tried to shake off my feeling of paranoia, of a conspiracy developing behind my back.

Jake just said, ‘Thanks, man,’ as though I’d just done him a solid.

I gave a slight nod to him, which might have been interpreted as me confirming this was all right, that I would be able to walk out of here and just forget about it all, and at the end of the vacation forget that anything had happened at all between my wife and another man. I guess part of me was all right with it all—that devilish side, the kinky side, the side that wanted her to cheat on me, that wanted her to be naughty and sexy and completely liberated—but the part of me that had remained quiet, shocked, flustered by the reality of my wife eagerly cheating on me under the same roof, that part of me was reeling right now.

Because as I walked out, toward the stairs—moving to claim my bedroom as my own for the night even if my wife wouldn’t be coming with me—I felt certain that Hanna was developing, or had already developed, some feelings for Jake.

It was both agonizing and, I couldn’t deny it, deeply sexually exhilarating.

Upstairs, I turned into my room—our room. Whatever. I'd been shut out of my own bedroom the night before, unable to access anything from my own suitcase, unable even to brush my teeth since my stuff was in here. Not tonight. Hanna could sleep in Jake's room tonight.

I felt downhearted for a little while. The fear of losing Hanna to Jake simmered into a nervous refrain, but at the same time I was tired. It felt as though adrenaline had kept me going through the card game, and now that it was over my body was going through some kind of withdrawal. It reminded me just how little sleep I'd gotten the night before.

I waited, wondering if Hanna and Jake were going to come upstairs. I wanted to go to the bathroom to get ready for bed, but I didn't want to finish up using the facilities only to come back and find myself shut out of my bedroom again. But Hanna and Jake didn't seem to be coming upstairs.

I took a risk, used the bathroom. Maybe I'd turf them out of my room if they slipped in while I was away. I didn't need to, as it happened. They didn't come upstairs.

On my way back to my room, I passed Hayden's room, his door open a crack. I could hear him snoring away, sound asleep.

Back in my own room, I closed the door behind me, shutting out the world. The wooden walls of the chalet and the way the double bed was wedged into a fairly small room, surrounded by what looked like IKEA furniture, made it feel like I was in a burrow, maybe hunkering down for hibernation.

I perched down on the bed, feeling the tightness in my chest strengthen, my heart beating a little more forcefully as though my blood had thickened. My body was reminding me that my wife was downstairs, fooling around with another man. Perhaps even falling for him. I tried to ignore the anxiety, though I could feel the nervous energy eating away at my sleepiness, even if it couldn't dispel my fatigue. The angel on my shoulder told me that I'd wanted to see what it would be like for Hanna to be unfaithful—and that even if it made me nervous, it was a huge turn-on. The devil on my other shoulder said I was losing my woman, that if I didn't go right down there and take her away from Jake, that I'd soon find her wanting a divorce, demanding the freedom to move in with him.

Maybe the angel on my one shoulder was a devil, maybe the devil wasn't an angel. I couldn't tell which was the more morally correct

approach by then.

I lay down in the bed, and I really wasn't sleepy anymore. Tired, but not sleepy. I looked up at the ceiling and breathed deeply, trying to calm down. I could smell Hanna's perfume. There was also an odd mustiness that hadn't been there when Hanna and I had been sleeping here together. It took me a moment or two to figure out that the room reeked of sex. The bed reeked of sex.

Jesus. If I hadn't been thinking about it before, I was now: Hanna had spent all night the previous night fucking Jake in here. The sheets, the pillows had to be saturated in their sweat, their come. It was dry by now, but as I put my nose to the sheet beneath me, my senses were nearly overwhelmed with the confirmation of my theory.

I could even detect the faint essence of Jake's cologne in the sheets.

Well, now I was rock hard once again, with no hope of ever getting close to sleep for a few more hours. I stroked myself a while, breathing in their smell even as I imagined them fucking downstairs—perhaps on the couch, perhaps on the kitchen counter, perhaps up against a wall. Maybe I'd sleep if I came.

But the more heated I became, the more I dwelled on the thoughts about what exactly Hanna and Jake were getting up to downstairs. My brain was not going to let go, and neither, probably, was my erection.

Were they just fucking down there? Or were they professing their love for each other, plotting a quickie divorce so that I might be put out of the picture altogether? My whole body was quivering with apprehension and fear.

I had to know.

Quietly, I slipped on a pair of gray sweatpants and an old white t-shirt with a faded Coca-Cola logo on the front, and then went back to the door, opening it a crack. I stopped still. Outside, I could hear Hayden snoring, and the wind howling outside the chalet—but nothing else. No sounds of fucking from downstairs. I tried to tell myself that it meant Jake and Hanna were probably just watching TV together, making a late-night snack.

I even wondered, half-heartedly, if they might have broken up. Maybe they'd decided that after one night of rampant sex it was best that they refrain from repeating it, for fear that they might start having feelings for each other. Maybe something about Jake annoyed Hanna to the point where she didn't want to sleep with him again, even if she was permitted to by the rules of our ridiculous game.

The trouble was, I couldn't believe anything like that. Not the way Hanna and Jake had been looking at each other during the card game, when they thought they were unseen by others.

No. As I slipped out into the hallway, which suddenly seemed so cold compared to the small, snug hideaway that was my bedroom, I felt certain that Hanna and Jake were downstairs in each other's arms, discussing how they might engineer to end my marriage. I was half right, as it happened.

Chapter Twelve

I crept down the hallway toward the stairs, doing my utmost to avoid any places where I knew there were particularly creaky floorboards, poised and ready to stand up and act as though I was simply heading downstairs to get a drink from the kitchen, if anyone came up the stairs, or if Hayden's snoring stopped.

Painfully slowly, I descended the steps, holding tight to the walls where the creaks were less likely.

The first thing I heard was the television. To hear it made the chill in my chest thaw a little. Could it be true, that they were simply watching TV together after all? Perhaps they'd found a movie being shown in English with Slovakian subtitles. However, I soon recognized the serious gravelly tones of the older male TV presenter even if I didn't understand a word of what he was saying, and I knew for a fact that neither Jake nor Hanna could be paying any attention to that particular news broadcast. A few more steps down the stairs and I could hear Jake's and Hanna's voices. At the bottom of the steps, I could hear the characteristic wet sounds of two people making out.

I peered around the corner of the hallway at the bottom of the steps. If they were on the couch, then they were lying down, where I couldn't see them since the couch was facing away from me. Across from me, not too far away, was the island that divided the kitchen area from the rest of the open-plan living area. I felt certain I could probably crawl over there super-quietly, and if I was lucky I would not be detected. Then I might be able to sneak a few looks around the far corner of the island to see what Jake and Hanna were doing.

I eased forward half a foot, my head moving out of the cover of the hallway wall—and was very nearly discovered.

Jake and Hanna were not on the couch at all. They were over on the window seat, Jake leaning up against the wall on one end, Hanna sitting in front of him, between his legs. He had his arms around her, and she was able to turn her head to him so that they could make out.

I managed to get back behind the wall without being seen, and now lying flat on the floor, edged out so that I might see them with little chance of being seen myself in the darkness.

My heart felt crushed, my stomach buzzing with butterflies, as I saw them kissing. I couldn't deny, however, that it wasn't sweet to watch.

Their chemistry, their affection. Their adultery. While Hanna had left the game naked, and Jake had been wearing only underwear, they were both now wearing clothes. Jake had his t-shirt on, Hanna had her tank top and skirt. I supposed that it was a little cold to be hanging around completely naked. And there was a risk of being disrupted by Hayden or me needing to get to the kitchen in the middle of the night.

Watching them sucking slowly and tenderly on each others' lips, however, I did feel a strange hurt that the two of them hadn't progressed beyond making out since the night's poker had come to a close. Why were they still kissing? He should have had her bent over the table by now, he should have been jamming his hard cock in her over and over and over. This was too romantic, this was too much like bonding, and it sent ice through my veins.

I saw Jake's hand cupping one of Hanna's breasts through her tank top, a finger slipping under the thin material to graze against her nipple, but otherwise things seemed almost as wholesome as Sunday School.

'We should go upstairs,' I heard Jake telling her.

'Here's fine,' she replied.

'You're not... at all worried...?'

She smiled. 'You can hear him snoring, can't you?' Hanna had always chided me for my snoring, and the last few years had taken to prodding me awake before ordering me to turn over onto my front, which usually caused the snoring to subside.

'That could be Hayden,' Jake said. His theory was spot on, of course. But neither he, nor Hanna, would know it.

'Trust me, I know my husband's snoring.'

Jake continued kissing her, and now his hands worked on her tank top, stretching the neckline down so that much of her breasts slipped out, particularly her stiff, pink nipples. She moaned loudly as he touched her there, but his hand was restless, sweeping down her body, to lodge itself between her legs. I watched him pull her skirt up, and now his hand was cupping her bare pussy, his middle finger running along her moistened groove, then circling, waggling, flickering over her pussy lips and against her clit, making her moans turn high-pitch while he kissed her mouth.

It was strange, watching her with him. She was so familiar, and yet I'd never seen her like this, from this angle, from a distance, while she was kissed and fingered by another man.

I watched her sit up, and urge him up onto his feet. Were they moving to the couch? I prepared myself to move across the floor to

behind the kitchen island if they did. They did not. Standing in front of her, while she perched on the edge of the window seat, Jake slipped down his boxer shorts to unveil his large, fully erect cock. He stooped, and they continued kissing, but one of Hanna's hands curled around his manhood, gently stroking it once, twice, three times.

He held her long, dark hair back out of her face as she leaned forward to take the tip of his cock in her mouth. I caught my breath as I watched my wife stretching her lips around that thing, then start to slowly bob her head over it.

After a while, she took it out of her mouth and licked the head, over and over, glancing up at him to register how he liked it. She used to do the same thing for me, back when we were dating, I thought. Jake merely groaned, and the hand holding her hair back urged her back down onto his cock. She was happy to oblige. She looked as though she was worshipping the damn thing. My jealousy seethed, but my own hard cock throbbed as I lay flat, crushing it against the floor.

Jake groaned and stroked her hair as she sucked on him. Hanna moaned as she sank down on his length, enjoying every moment. Was she this jubilant when she went down on me? It had been a while since she had. I suppose it had been a long while since either of us had engaged in this kind of unhurried foreplay.

Hanna really took her time, as with their making out. I supposed that they had all night, there was hardly a need for haste. At the same time it seemed so intimate, so affectionate, so romantic, it ate away at my soul.

I'm guessing Jake was getting close to finishing when he stopped her, said, 'We should go upstairs.'

Hanna had looked up at him and grinned, wiping her mouth on the back of her forearm. 'I wanna stay,' she said. 'Don't you think it would be... kinda hot?'

Jake said, 'I'm not sure... I mean... what if one of them walks in?'

Hanna seemed to hesitate, and then it became clear she was listening for sounds of danger. There was only the wind, and Hayden upstairs snoring away.

Licking the tip of his cock, she said, 'He's still snoring, can't you hear it?'

Jake shook his head, 'That's Hayden. I swear. I'd recognize it a mile off.'

Hanna said, 'It's probably both of them. They're totally asleep. Come on—you wanna fuck me?' She wasn't talking like the Hanna I

knew. I don't think she'd ever asked me to fuck her. She didn't use dirty words when *we* had sex.

He urged her up, kissing her as she slung her arms around his neck. Then he was lifting her tank top, exposing those pert little breasts, those impossibly hard nipples, taking one and then the other in his mouth to suck on them slowly while he helped her pull her top up over her head and off.

She moaned as he sucked on her tits, and then she was moving to help him slide her skirt down over her hips, her thighs, leaving her so very naked before him. My wife, her pink nipples jutting out, her pussy so very smooth and hairless.

I saw his hard cock brush against her as they kissed. The arousal and the fear bubbled away inside me. She smiled seductively at him, her hands curling around his shaft, pulling on it as though not quite believing it was there, this cock that was not her husband's.

'You think the neighbors can see?' Jake said quietly.

Hanna smirked, 'Let them. If there are any.'

She perched down on the window seat again, but Jake wasn't entirely giving in to her demands quite yet. He sank slowly to his knees while kissing his way down over her breasts, down her stomach, and then he was parting her legs and guiding her to rest them over his shoulders.

Hanna brushed her hair out of her face, leaned back and moaned again, and though I couldn't see everything, I watched as Jake began to slowly fuck her with his mouth, his head lodged between her thighs.

My wife looked astonished as he set to, gazing down on him with eyes wide and mouth open.

'Oh God...' she moaned, almost purring like a contented cat.

She stroked his head, and his hand where he was gripping her hip, and it seemed so tender and loving. It was downright terrifying for me to watch, even if my hard-on strained and bucked, demanding attention. I watched my wife's chest rising and falling as she breathed so deeply, and her moans turned to little whimpers, as though she was finding it difficult to cope with the powerful feelings he was inspiring in her.

I felt so crushed by it. Jake was spending absolutely ages between her thighs, as though he was a connoisseur who had discovered perfection, an addict given the purest of hits. It seemed as though I needed to re-learn how to make love to my wife. Years of marriage and taking her for granted had taken their toll. But as I watched her with Jake, and remembered her forbidding me from reclaiming her, unless I

won her through the poker game, I started feeling little flickers of real insecurity. Would she take me back after this incredible show from Jake?

He made her come. Her breathing deepened, her whole body rocking and writhing under him as she clamped her hands around his head, pulling him forcefully against her, wrapping her whole body around his head it seemed, as though she was trying to asphyxiate him. Her breathing turned to shaking, and she was letting out little yelps, apparently trying to muffle them so that she wouldn't wake the rest of us.

I saw my wife come, and it made me certain I hadn't made her come myself, not in years. Certainly not like that, if at all. I couldn't even remember enough about our dating to tell if it had been something that happened back then. Surely it had to have, or else there was no way she'd have stayed with me, married me, would she?

At last, Jake pulled away, and the two of them were smiling at each other like besotted lovers.

How was I supposed to cope with this? I couldn't march over there and pull them apart. I'd feel humiliated, they'd know I'd been watching them. I picked myself up from the kitchen floor—but only to shift so that I didn't get pins and needles. I maintained my concealment behind the island. While I was getting more and more nervous about Hanna developing feelings for Jake, it seemed to go hand-in-hand with an ever stronger excitement, an ever stronger sexual response to what I was seeing.

And now Jake was standing in front of her again, kissing her mouth, sucking on her tongue, and his manhood was right up there beside her open and very willing pussy. I watched my wife gently take hold of another man's cock, and guide the tip to her glistening flower. He sank slowly into her, holding her legs up, her calves rubbing against his shoulders.

He was fucking her. My friend Jake was fucking my wife.

I seethed with anger and arousal.

Moving round to the other side of the kitchen island, peering around the corner, I found that I could see his cock entering her. His shaft glistened with her juices as it disappeared into her, and then reappeared. I could hear the wet sounds of him penetrating her over and over. Hanna closed her eyes and panted as he thrust into her, and though I'd say Jake's cock was no larger than mine, it looked as though she'd never experienced such bliss.

They kissed. God, they weren't meant to kiss while they fucked. They weren't really meant to kiss all that much. It was just sex, or at least it was supposed to be just sex. They kissed each other, they smiled at each other, they gently caressed each other. The anxiety grew inside me, as I realized that I was watching a couple that wasn't 'just having sex', they were making love.

I was watching Romeo giving Juliet a right royal seeing to.

I couldn't stop watching. Despite the overwhelming feeling of fear, I couldn't tear my eyes away from them. For a while I just kind of rode the wave, surfed the fear. I tried to cling on to the belief that Hanna loved me, that she would not give up on marriage after just a couple of days banging someone else.

After another age and a day, I watched as they pulled apart, only for Hanna to turn around and present her rear for him. She propped herself up, with her hands planted on the window seat and Jake entered her from behind. He held her hips and fucked her, and yet it wasn't hard and fast like you'd expect. It was slow and sensual. His hands moved up to caress her body, to cup her small breasts, to squeeze her nipples. She even twisted upward and was able to kiss his mouth while he continued to stir his cock inside her.

She was standing up, for God's sake, arching her back as he kept on fucking her.

Hanna made them move after that, over to the table. She was leading him, telling him what she wanted. It was very sexy, but again something she never did with me. She wanted him to fuck her on the table where we all played poker, where we had all competed for her attention. She lay back across the table, her butt at the edge, and Jake lined up in front of her, lifting her feet up to rest his shoulders, then easing himself back inside her.

I couldn't move. I was just yards away from them now, and there was nowhere else for me to go without exposing myself. I carefully peered around the corner at his big, hard cock sinking into her time after time, and any moment one of them might glance to the side and catch me. I had to be ready to duck out of sight at a fraction of a second's notice.

Hanna started panting again, her body writhing over the table as he fucked her. Jesus. I could smell her arousal, I could smell their sex. She had her hands over her breasts, playing with them while he took her. She didn't do that with me. He was still fucking her quite tenderly, not rough

or hard. Her hands swept down to coax her clit while he took her, but her moans were just intense.

It was only as he grunted loudly, and she matched it with a long cry, that I realized the two of them were not using condoms.

He had come inside my wife, without any protection.

*

I watched Jake collapse over Hanna on that kitchen table, and both of them were laughing. I'm not entirely sure what had them in such fits of giggles, but the fact that Jake had just unloaded in her, on the table in which we had been eating meals all week, and playing our all-important poker games, had to register.

I used their distraction to escape from the kitchen—I was suddenly aware that after sex one or other of them might want a drink, and they'd go into the kitchen to fetch one.

I waited until I was certain they weren't looking, but then I just barreled out of there, launching myself out of my hiding place in something of a risky move. Slipping into the stairway, I paused, waiting for any signs that I'd been seen.

'You're crazy, you know that?' I heard Jake saying to her.

'You make me crazy. It's your fault.'

They were in love, it sounded so obvious. It kind of made my blood boil, and yet strangely at the same time I felt oddly happy. I had opened the door to this, I had told her of my fantasy and I had allowed the poker games to go ahead—and had left her dalliances with Jake go unchallenged. She was so plainly happy, excited, enchanted by it all, and I have given that to her.

I just hoped I hadn't given everything away.

Chapter Thirteen

I needed to get out of there while they indulged in their post-coital flirtation. I had to be in my bedroom—the room that had once been mine and Hanna's, anyway—with the door shut by the time they came upstairs. Otherwise they would wonder where I was.

Back in the room, fatigue hit me hard—and yet laying down on that bed, I was immediately enveloped in the smells of Hanna and Jake and their previous night's sex. It meant I was awake, even if I was tired.

I heard Hanna and Jake coming upstairs, with all the whispering and giggling and one or other of them telling the other to 'shhh!!!'

They turned into Jake's room and closed the door.

My stomach felt as though it was all twisted and folded up, the nerves making me feel sick. I was even shaking a little. Was I really going to lose my wife? I thought about the whole life we'd forged together—the apartment we'd bought together in the city, the timeshare we had in Antigua, the joint bank account. All the friends we shared. It would all unravel if she decided to leave me. My whole life—everything would change. The biggest change, though, would be the absence of Hanna herself. It hadn't even happened, and I started feeling a gaping hole in my world opening up, the throbbing pain in my chest of such a life-altering loss.

I had to sleep, or at least try to. Yet after waiting a few moments for Hanna and Jake to settle in Jake's room, I scampered out and along the hallway to the bathroom.

I undressed, figuring that I might feel better after a shower. But then as I was reaching over the bath to turn on the shower unit, I was somewhat surprised by the bathroom door opening.

'Hey,' Hanna said, stepping inside.

I switched on the flow of the water.

'Hey,' I said, turning back to her, not bothering with any attempt to cover myself. She was wearing a white terrycloth bathrobe, one of the ones we had once swiped from a luxury hotel in Paris on one of our previous mini-breaks.

'I told Jake I needed a shower,' she said.

'Okay,' I nodded, not entirely sure what she wanted, since the previous day she'd forbidden me from sex until I won one of our poker

games. Was she suggesting I vacate the bathroom so she could have a quick shower and get back to Jake?

‘I just...’ she said, glancing sideways awkwardly. I guess she didn’t really know what to say, either. ‘I guess I just wanted to see if you were all right.’

‘Doesn’t it look as though I’m all right?’ I asked her, offering her an attempt at a smile to go along with my erection. Well, I couldn’t help that—here she was, wearing nothing but a bathrobe, fresh after fucking another guy. Just because I was fearful of losing her, didn’t mean I stopped fantasizing about her fucking other guys.

She smiled, perhaps a hint grateful that I was still, apparently, into this. Perhaps pitying me a little.

‘I’m sorry...’ she tried to say.

I jumped in, ‘For what? You can’t help who won the game.’

‘I know it sucks... you know... for you... and Hayden...’

Even with the shower running, and beginning to fill the bathroom with steam, I detected a hint of her arousal in the air, a hint of the musty, earthy sex smell. Jesus. And she looked so good—glowing with the contentment of post-coital satisfaction—even with a slight sheen of perspiration over her brow.

I admit to feeling a touch of annoyance at her, at her apologizing for holding out on me, when she really didn’t have to.

Something inside me snapped.

I said, ‘Take it off.’

My eyes flicked over her bathrobe.

She sighed, and her eyes dropped for a moment. ‘Honey... I’m sorry... I said...’ she said, starting to refuse me.

‘I don’t care,’ I interrupted her, barking: ‘Take it off.’

I’m not sure what came over me. I’m really not that kind of guy, not that kind of husband. I’d prefer not to even have an argument if I could avoid it. But just then, some kind of anger brought on by injustice started boiling in my veins. I felt forceful, I felt insistent.

Her forehead wrinkled and her eyebrows dropped in puzzlement at my unusual tone. As she hesitated, somewhat taken aback by it, I declared: ‘You’re my wife. You’ll do as I want.’

I never talked to my wife like that. We didn’t have that kind of relationship. I’d never have gotten away with trying to order her around, trying to assert some kind of paternalistic leadership over her just because I was the man in this marriage. But just then, I felt like I didn’t care.

I growled, 'Take it off.'

'Since when did you talk to me like that?' she said sharply, but her outrage didn't seem entirely sincere, and there was a strange hint of something like intrigue in her green eyes. She even bit her lip, as though this unusual situation we found ourselves in was turning her on.

Then she slipped the bathrobe off her shoulders anyway, exposing her beautiful breasts and those stiff, stiff nipples. She allowed the garment to fall to the floor, leaving herself completely naked in front of me.

'Kiss me,' I ordered her, and stepped up to her, backing her into the sink, giving her no room to escape.

'You don't get to tell me what to do,' she insisted, and yet she leaned back against the sink and placed her hands on the rim of the basin beside her, as though proclaiming that she was open for me. Her chest was rising and falling as her breathing deepened. I could sense adrenaline being pumped into her veins.

'Sure I do,' I retorted, and eased forward to press myself up against her, my hands moving around her to grab her lower back, her hips, and pull myself firmly against her as my lips crushed up against hers. I kissed her, sucking a little forcefully on her lips, tasting her sweetness, and perhaps a little something that wasn't her, that was a hint of her lover. She melted against me, kissing me back, reaching for my body—so much for her resistance.

I was in charge here. I squeezed her body, I groped her ass and her breasts, I grabbed her neck and sucked on her mouth. She moaned quietly, letting out little whimpers of surprise and delight as I grabbed her, as I put my hands all over her, as I proclaimed my ownership with every move. She liked this—it was as big a surprise to me as anything that had happened so far.

I wasn't thinking that there was any danger of Jake interrupting, discovering us, even if there was no lock on the bathroom door. Hanna was mine, and I would take her and make her my own again. If Jake tried to intervene, he could go to Hell.

She was so unbelievably sexy. With every breath I breathed her arousal, and the scent of her adulterous sex. With every kiss I tasted the saltiness of perspiration from her unfaithful night with Jake.

She was stroking me, and it seemed encouraging this all-new dominance in me. One of her hands dropped to between my legs as I kissed her, her fingers curling around my hard cock, marveling at how

hard I was for her, how I wanted her even though she was still filthy from her fucking someone else.

‘I need... I need... I need to shower...’ she insisted, out of breath when I finally released her from our kiss.

‘No,’ I said, and crushed her up against the sink once again, kissing her mouth, thinking about how wicked she was, how she’d taken another man’s cock between her lips not so long ago. She kissed me back, panting for breath, trying to reach for my cock. Apparently loving that I was ferociously claiming ownership of her like this.

I reached for one of her thighs and lifted her leg, lifting her whole body, in fact, so that she would sit up on the edge of the basin and the small counter, one leg raised, her pussy exposed. The smell of her arousal, the smell of sex, intensified significantly as she parted her thighs like that. I kissed her again, my hand cupping her hairless pussy, marveling at how wet she was, and how different her sex felt now that she’d removed all her fur to please someone else.

‘No...’ she said, quietly as I touched her there, but it wasn’t so much denying me consent as expressing astonishment that I wasn’t freaked out that another man had just fucked her, had just entered her there.

She added, ‘I could... rinse a little...’

I said firmly, ‘No. You’ll do exactly as I tell you.’

She looked at me, surprised and turned on, and continued to moan as I slid a couple of fingers inside her slippery folds, sinking them into her, playing her like she was a musical instrument. She knew it was no good to object as I dropped down to my knees, and now kissed her between her thighs, just above her clit, where the smell of her excitement and her infidelity was just intense, so intoxicating that I felt a touch light-headed.

She cried out as I enveloped her clit in my mouth, and then as I slid my tongue between her soaking pussy lips.

I’d never been so hungry for her.

I thought about Jake eating her out while she had sat on the window seat downstairs, but at that stage it didn’t feel as though I was trying to compete against him. I wasn’t so much trying to make her come—although she did come, and now for sure I was certain she wasn’t faking it—I devoured my wife’s unfaithful pussy because I craved it for myself.

It was only a quickie, it wasn’t long and tender like Jake had been, but it seemed to me that the very taboo nature of what she’d done so recently, and the fact I was doing something out of the ordinary by going down on her when I hadn’t for so long, pushed her into another orgasm

fairly quickly. As her hand clamped down on my head, pressing my mouth against her hot flesh, I felt her quivering, I felt her body pulsating. She cried out, and had to jam the hand towel into her mouth to stifle it.

Wow. And it was so weirdly sexy, making love to her wicked pussy with my mouth, that I think I nearly came without even touching my cock.

‘Fuck... fuck...’ Hanna panted as I finally pulled away from her, my face soaked in her juices.

I put a finger up to my lips to warn her to be quiet, to remind her that Jake was only in the next room, and Hayden was in the room opposite, even if he was still snoring loudly.

But now it was my turn.

I stood, and lifted her foot off the end of the sink so that she now stood in front of me. With one hand at her waist, I pulled her to me, firmly, still in control, and kissed her mouth forcefully. I was reminding her that I was in charge here, that she was my possession. I was also making her taste her own pussy on my lips, her tangy juices all over my face. She did not seem to object at all.

But then I was forcing her down, both hands pushing on her hips, shoving her down onto her knees in front of me. It was clear what I wanted. Hanna went with the flow and put a hand onto my cock as I directed the tip to her mouth.

She began to suck on it, dutifully but also eagerly. I guess it was strange and exciting for her to do this with two different guys in one night. Two different cocks.

I moaned and held her long, dark hair out of her face as she sucked on me, as she bobbed back and forth on my shaft. Her mouth felt sensational, her tongue against my tip. She might have been my wife ordinarily, but I felt an odd little shiver of excitement at stealing her away from Jake on the night she was supposed to be with him. Did he feel similarly about taking my wife away from me?

I held the back of her head as she sucked on me, showing her the rhythm I wanted. After a while, it seemed like I was fucking her head. She took it, and she seemed to enjoy it.

But we didn’t have time for everything. As much as I was controlling her—and could have forced her to stay with me in there, no doubt—I didn’t want her to be away from Jake for too long. I didn’t want him to suspect that I’d sneaked in with her for a few minutes that night.

I leaned down and coaxed her up from the floor, kissing her sweet mouth briefly again before turning her, making her face the mirror and

the sink, on which she placed her hands. She leaned forward and arched her back, tilting up her ass for me as I lined up behind her. I slid into her hot pussy so very easily, since she was seriously wet.

Holding onto her waist, I fucked her. Each thrust into her pussy made her whole body rock, her buttocks and breasts shiver. She bent down and clutched the faucet, panting loudly as I pounded into her, despite her attempts to keep quiet. I don't think I was too worried about the noise. If the shower didn't cover it, I thought Hanna would be able to tell Jake she had been unable to resist touching herself while soaping herself up.

Underlining my new dominance, I held her hair while I fucked her like that, and even got in a few light spanks, though it wasn't exactly something I'd done before. She seemed to respond to it.

She came again within a few minutes, and I released my own cream deep inside her. It felt glorious. It felt like some kind of victory.

When she finally turned back to face me, she was completely out of breath and looking at me as though I'd just made the Great Wall of China disappear or something.

'What?' I asked her, grinning.

'What was that?' she said, panting.

'What did it look like?'

She raised an eyebrow. 'You—we—never did it like that before.'

She reached down to grasp hold of my softening cock, looking at it as though wondering whether it was really the same one she'd been married to all these years.

'You've never... told me what to do before,' she said, looking up and directly into my eyes. 'You've never... ordered me around like that.'

I shrugged. 'I never had to deal with you sleeping with another guy before,' I said.

She smiled, a touch bashfully all of a sudden, and I noticed a faint pink flush in her cheeks. 'I kind of liked it,' she admitted.

'What, sleeping with another guy?'

'You... being like that.'

'You still want me, then?' I asked her, quite serious.

'Shouldn't it be me asking you that question?' she tossed it back my way.

I said, 'I would have thought that was obvious by what just happened. But... you know... I'm not the one giving myself to someone else.'

She gave a little nod, accepting the need for my question. ‘You know I love you,’ she said. ‘That’s never going to change.’

‘It better not,’ I growled, making her smile by channeling my inner caveman once again.

‘It *won’t*,’ she insisted, and looked genuine enough. I felt a big question burning a hole in my head: *but do you love Jake as well now?* Somehow I couldn’t bring myself to ask it, though. I wasn’t sure whether it was more that I didn’t want to give away my fears about that particular issue, or that I didn’t want to face any kind of answer she might give me.

‘You’d better get in the shower,’ I advised her.

‘Yes, I’d better.’ She smiled again. Enough to melt my insides yet again.

‘Get some sleep,’ I suggested, stepping back for her to access the shower. ‘Then in the morning after he fucks you again, you come back to me, right?’

In the shower, she covered herself as though we weren’t husband and wife—as though I wasn’t allowed to see her naked—and pouted.

‘You don’t get to tell me what to do, remember?’ she said.

But there was a twinkle in her eye as I left her to her shower.

Chapter Fourteen

She did wake me in the morning. I was still completely out of it, lying there on the bed on my back, without even having put any clothes on. She gently stroked my legs, and I felt her silky hair brushing lightly over my thighs. Her hands swept up over my chest, and down again to explore between my legs.

‘Hey,’ she said, barely more than a whisper.

I moaned, as though I wanted to be left alone, but as her grip tightened on my cock, so it began to stiffen.

She started slowly pumping it, and said: ‘I just fucked him again.’

My cock reached full hardness immediately.

I felt her hot mouth touch against its tip, and then there was no way I was going back to sleep. I craned my neck to look down at her, and reached down to brush her hair away from her face.

She gazed up at me and licked my manhood from base to tip, clutching my shaft in one hand. She was wearing her tank top from the previous night—and, as I peered down at her, it appeared that she was also wearing her skirt.

‘What happened?’ I said, my throat dry, scratchy.

‘I woke him up, just like this,’ she said, pausing to flick her hair back out of her face again before sinking down on my shaft.

‘Is that right?’ I smiled, and now urged her up so I could kiss her dirty mouth.

‘Mmm...’ she moaned as I sucked on her lips, and tasted the slightly odd flavor on her mouth and tongue. Dirty girl. She said, ‘I had to suck on him for a while before he woke up.’

‘Uh-huh?’

‘He tried to get me to stop so he could sleep.’

‘But you didn’t stop,’ I said, pulling her tank top up now, exposing her stomach, her breasts, her hard nipples. She wasn’t wearing a bra.

‘No,’ she said with a wicked grin, and then raised her arms so that I could pull her top up over her head and away. ‘I didn’t stop.’

I kissed her upper chest as I cupped her breasts in my hands, and tasted the salt of perspiration on her skin, breathed in the faint musk of another man. Her flesh was hot, clammy. A touch sticky, maybe. She sighed merrily as I took her nipples in my mouth, swirling my tongue around each one as I sampled it.

‘And then what happened?’ I asked her.

‘I fucked him,’ she said, pushing away from me again, moving down to take my hard cock back in her mouth, wrapping both hands around my hardness, apparently delighted she could get both hands on my full length.

‘Tell me,’ I said, groaning quietly as she pulled on my cock.

Sitting between my legs, her own legs parted and bending up over my thighs, she played with my cock, stroking it, squeezing it, massaging it as if I’d paid for a happy ending.

‘He got so hard,’ she said, ‘just like you are now.’

‘You like it?’ I asked her. ‘You like his cock?’

She looked at me and hesitated briefly before nodding her head. Perhaps figuring that I was demanding the truth, that it was easier in the long run to say exactly what happened, rather than making an attempt to inflate my own sense of self-worth. ‘It’s big, just like yours,’ she said, stroking my cock as though it was her pet.

‘You like them big?’ I smiled.

‘Oh, yes.’ She bit her lip.

‘You like his... better than mine?’

She smirked. ‘No.’

‘Is he bigger?’

She tilted her head. ‘I don’t know... actually,’ she said, thinking about it, playing with me with both her hands as though trying to make a judgment. ‘I think... maybe. Maybe not. It’s just... different.’

‘Two *different* men,’ I teased her. ‘You’re a lucky girl.’

‘Yes, I am.’

She leaned forward while continuing to play with my cock, and I was able to reach down and brush the backs of my fingers against her stiff nipples.

‘So what happened?’ I asked her. ‘How did you fuck him?’

She licked her lips. Squeezed my cock tightly in both hands. ‘When he was nice and hard, like this, I climbed onto him and put him inside me.’

She did climb onto me just then, a hungry expression in her eyes despite her night of passion, her recent love-making. She straddled me, and I felt her burning sex press down against my shaft.

‘You fucked him like that?’ I asked her.

‘Uh-huh, for a while,’ she said. ‘I like being on top with him.’

With him. The words needled my jealousy a little, but at the same time amused me. ‘You like being on top with me, too?’ I asked her.

She smiled, giggled girlishly, something she never did in bed with me. ‘I like it,’ she said, nodding gently. Then she added, ‘But I like it better when you’re on top.’

Her tone of voice hinted at the new tone of domination I’d tried on her in the bathroom some hours before, rather than recalling any actual occasions where I’d been physically on top of her when we made love.

‘Like this?’ I grabbed her, wrestled her over onto her back as though I was some ravenous lion claiming a fresh gazelle, and she was giggling and squealing in delight. I had half a thought about whether Jake might overhear, but it disappeared as quickly as it came to me.

‘Oh yes...’ she moaned as I pressed down on her, laying between her thighs.

But I didn’t give her the immediate satisfaction of penetration. I kissed my way down her soft neck, and over the clammy, warm flesh of her upper chest and her breasts. I breathed in the smells of her adulterous sex as I slid slowly down her body, kissing her stomach, her abdomen, inhaling her as the wicked scent strengthened the closer I came to her completely shaven sex.

‘Did you stay on top with him?’ I asked her.

‘No,’ she moaned as I nudged her clit with my nose, and then kissed her glistening pussy lips. ‘He rolled on top of me after a while.’

Her pussy was a little puffy, her lips dark and engorged with blood. Freshly fucked. I slid my tongue inside her, tasting that devilish tangy flavor of her arousal. Detecting no hint of contraception, none of that latex accent to her scent.

‘You don’t use condoms with him,’ I accused her, sucking on her pussy lips while her hand came down to gently stroke my head.

She didn’t seem troubled by the issue. ‘I trust him. And he hasn’t really dated anyone in a while.’

That I could confirm, since Jake had talked a lot about giving up dating after New Year because he said he needed to concentrate on his career for a while, since we were all heading toward our thirties at pace. At the time, I remember teasing him that he would never be able to cope without a blonde in his bed—I never imagined back then that months later, he’d have Hanna in his bed instead.

As I lapped at her soaking, shaven pussy, I found myself wondering what was going to happen when we all got home. Would Hanna’s infidelity remain a secret between the four of us? I had to suppose it would—unless one of our other friends managed to tease out the secret from one of us.

And what would happen to the dynamic of our friendship? Now that Jake had slept with Hanna, and I had allowed it—while Hayden had been excluded by the cards.

‘What happens next?’ I asked Hanna, but she looked down at me, vaguely confused. I realized my question had followed on from my thought process, to which she had not been party.

I said, ‘We have one day left, one night left in this chalet.’

‘Uh-huh,’ she said, quietly sighing in response to my tongue lashing against her slippery folds.

‘So are we playing poker again?’ I asked her, trying to sound fairly casual about it.

‘I... I don’t know...’ she said, seeming suddenly a little more troubled than I expected—though it could have been simply her response to my sliding my fingers inside her soaking pussy.

‘Maybe you’d get to experience a night with Hayden,’ I said, again doing my utmost to keep the tone light.

‘Or Jake...’ she moaned, and it was very much as though I’d prized a secret out of her by sexual manipulation. Her utterance tweaked my jealousy, although at the same time the fact she was thinking adulterous thoughts did give me that little buzz of arousal again.

Nevertheless, the thought that she might be falling for Jake was preying on my mind.

I said, ‘If you won the game—you’d choose another night with Jake?’ Then I dipped my head, enveloped her little swollen clit in my hot, wet mouth.

She moaned, long and low, and it sounded as though she was answering me in the affirmative. I tried to keep calm, enjoy the thrilling side of her infidelity while playing down my fears. I supposed that she really was only going to get to sleep with Jake while this weird vacation of ours continued—there was no assumption that it would continue after we got home. At least as far as I knew. I guessed that Hanna just wanted to enjoy as much time with Jake as she would be allowed, without having to start again with a new lover.

Still. My suppressed sense of jealousy was rearing its ugly head somewhat.

‘Don’t you think it would be nice to... you know... include Hayden in all of this?’ I said. ‘I just thought... you know... we were all doing this... to pass the time.’

Her eyes burned with mild annoyance. ‘The *game* is what’s helping everybody pass the time,’ she said. ‘Playing the game. Right? I’m not a

hooker.'

There was an edge in her voice. Anger. Lying between her legs, my lips wet with her juices, I really wasn't prepared for any kind of an argument. The way she was looking at me made it seem like she was suggesting all this was my fault. I'll admit, her attitude did surprise me. I guess she thought differently than I did, and perhaps that was because she was a woman, perhaps not. My assumption, perhaps male-oriented, was that given the chance to sleep with two new guys, she would sleep with two new guys, she wouldn't keep to just one of them. But it hadn't been part of the deal for her to fall for Jake.

'If I won the game, you'd just spend the night with me,' I said, not quite sure whether it was a question or a statement.

She said quietly, 'You might... let me... spend a little time with him.'

I sighed, and propped myself up on my elbows. 'The deal wasn't for you to fall in love with one of my best friends.'

She sighed sharply, angrily. 'I'm not 'in love' with him,' she insisted, although her sudden, fierce blush seemed to tell me otherwise. 'I *like* him... And since it turns you on that I... that I *fuck* him... I don't see how you can have a problem.'

I pulled myself away from her, and up to lie beside her. 'I don't have a problem,' I insisted. 'I just thought this was... you know... just about the sex.'

'It is just about the sex.'

'But you do have feelings for him.'

I saw her bristle at that. 'Of *course* I have *feelings* for him. I can't just sleep with a guy I don't have some kind of feelings for.' I felt irritation pinch my stomach because she was twisting my meanings. 'I'm not a porn star,' she said. 'I'm not a whore.'

I sighed. 'There's a difference between finding a guy attractive... wanting to sleep with him... and actually falling for him.'

She drew back from me. Grabbed the bedsheets to cover herself. I felt my stomach turn over in dread. I hated arguments.

'So what are you saying?' she demanded, now sitting up and pulling the bedclothes up to conceal herself. 'You just want me to be your good little slut, is that it? Fucking all your friends, fucking a bunch of men, so long as it doesn't mean anything to me. So long as I remain your own personal sex toy.'

I groaned inwardly. Sure, there was a little of that desire in me. I wouldn't have used the word 'slut', but to have her free to sleep with whoever she wanted, that put lead in my pencil.

‘Kind of objectifying me, aren’t you?’ she accused me.

Now it was my turn to bristle. I’m as feminist as the next liberal, I declared silently. But a man can’t truly say how a woman feels about a given situation. I had to concede that she might feel differently about this particular new fantasy of mine. That she would, in fact, have a completely different point of view on it. I had failed to take her perspective into consideration.

And yet, despite her protests about the differences between having feelings and falling in love with someone, I could detect the telltale stench of romance between my wife and her new lover. It was both completely terrifying and oddly exciting all at once.

She stood up, grabbed her clothes, said: ‘You can’t just pimp me out to your friends and decide how I should feel about it.’

It was a fair point, but I’d probably learned my lesson too late for this argument.

‘You either want me to sleep with him, or not,’ she added.

I sighed. ‘I just don’t want you falling in love with him...’

‘I told you, *I’m not in love with him*,’ she insisted again, angrily dressing herself in front of me as though to flaunt what I was now missing out on.

She stormed out, and I heard her in the bathroom turning on the shower. I threw on some clothes myself, so I could go downstairs to find something for breakfast. It didn’t quite feel as though I’d lost the argument, because deep-down I still felt I was right, she probably did have more feelings for Jake than she was admitting, even to herself. But my eyes were now open to the fact that I’d been treating her as more of a sex object than I’d realized or meant.

But what did this argument mean for the final night of our vacation?

Chapter Fifteen

Hayden came downstairs into the kitchen area as I was finishing up my breakfast. Clutching my bowl, I was in something of a daze of contemplation on the couch. He gave me a quick salute before digging out his own breakfast.

‘Hey, buddy. How’s it going?’

He seemed unusually bright and breezy. I guessed that he’d had a great night’s sleep, and now felt fully rested and at peace with the world—whereas Jake and I had been sleeping very little recently, owing to the sexual antics of my wife. But then Hayden asked me, ‘You see the weather?’

I turned to look out of the windows, and was surprised to see that I’d been so caught up in my thoughts that I’d totally overlooked the fact that the sky was blue and, apparently, completely cloudless.

‘Wow,’ I said.

‘Crazy, huh?’ he smiled broadly. ‘It’s not exactly going to get us skiing any time soon, but... hey, maybe we can get some hiking in today, right?’

I nodded. Hiking wasn’t exactly something I’d actively choose to do on a vacation, but after our claustrophobic few days, it seemed like the best thing ever. And perhaps, I thought, it would divert attention from the argument I’d just had with Hanna.

‘Sounds good,’ I smiled, and pulled myself up from the couch to wander over toward the windows and marvel at the blue, blue sky.

‘I need to stretch my legs, man,’ Hayden said, ‘I feel like I’ve been in prison for a month.’

‘There are some maps in the equipment room,’ I said, pointing over toward the hallway.

‘Oh, I don’t know if I need a map—I just want to get up to the top of the mountain, you know? At least then I can say I’ve been there, snow or not. Then it’s straight down again, right?’

‘Easiest way back,’ I nodded.

‘You guys planning something?’

I turned at the sound of Jake’s voice. Here he was, coming downstairs with a freshly showered and dressed Hanna, like the two of them were a couple. Hanna looked all smiley and chirpy as though she

hadn't had an argument since college. She avoided my gaze, and sauntered into the kitchen to find some food.

'We're gonna hike up the mountain,' Hayden said, waving a spoon at the windows and the cloudless sky. 'You guys coming too?'

'I don't think I'd make it,' Jake said, clutching his back and wincing like an old man. 'I think I must have slept in a bad position last night. My back is killing me.'

Hayden couldn't help but glance over at me, an eyebrow raised as though to say, *Is he kidding me or something? 'Slept in a bad position last night'? Jesus. 'Fucked' in a bad position, more like.* But then he said simply, 'You never know, a little nice, fresh air and exercise—you might walk it off.'

Jake attempted to stretch his lower back and groaned at the pain, 'Uh-huh, I don't think this is going to walk off.' From the kitchen, Hanna giggled.

'We were going to head slowly down to the store to see if they had something to dull the pain,' Hanna said, whisking up some eggs in a glass mixing bowl.

'It's that bad, huh?' Hayden said, though his pity seemed a mite less than genuine.

Hanna turned, and for the first time since coming downstairs this morning, actively glanced at me to gauge my reaction to her spending the day with Jake while Hayden and I went hiking. Was she taunting me? Or was there some concern about how I might take it, how I might interpret her desire to be with him after our argument? I couldn't quite tell.

I flashed her a smile that attempted to be vaguely apologetic and conciliatory. She looked down and poured her eggs into a sizzling frying pan on the hob, her emotions hidden.

'Well,' Hayden said brightly, 'we'll take a load of pictures I'm sure, so you guys can check out the view from the top.'

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Hayden didn't mention anything for a while. We engaged in cheerful small talk from the moment we stepped out of the chalet wearing short sleeves and no cold weather gear, and carrying backpacks containing food and water and some extra clothes in case the cloudless sky turned suddenly back to the way it had been all week.

The small talk seemed to peter out when we started out into the trees immediately above the little town, and the walk started to be a real effort. After a while, only our quiet panting broke the silence.

As the trail proceeded through a small clearing that opened up to a magnificent view down the mountainside, Hayden paused for a drink of water. He leaned up against a fallen spruce to gaze down on the little town and the rest of the upland valley, but then caught me by surprise, saying, 'You all right there, buddy?'

There was clearly more in his eyes than just asking after my well-being as a fellow hiker.

'Sure, fine,' I nodded, leaning up against the fallen tree trunk beside him in order to retrieve my own water bottle.

He paused for a while, then said, 'I heard you guys this morning... you know... voices getting a little raised...' It was as though he had waited to broach the subject of our argument until there was absolutely zero chance that Hanna, or Jake, or both of them, might change their minds and suddenly come on up the mountain after us.

I took a sip of water. 'I guess everyone heard, huh?'

'Everything okay between you guys?'

I shrugged. 'You know how it is.' He didn't, not at all, but then I wasn't sure I did completely, if I was being honest. He did have some idea that a strain might have been generated between Hanna and myself by the strange situation we were in, it seemed. He gave a sympathetic nod.

'You buy all that stuff about his back being sore?'

I shook my head. 'They're probably in bed right now.'

'Seems like it. You... are you sure you're okay, buddy?' he didn't seem to know what to say.

I shrugged, 'It's only sex.'

Actually, despite my misgivings about Hanna developing feelings for Jake, it still felt oddly exciting for her to be back at the chalet with him. Fucking him. They were probably doing it all over the place, and particularly in my bed. I supposed that since they'd given us a cover story about spending the day searching for painkillers for Jake's bad back, if they were actually fucking right now it was, technically, Hanna cheating on me. We hadn't agreed anything as husband and wife. I felt troubled by the suggestion that she might do something behind my back—even if that strange, perverted, dark part of me seemed to revel in the thought she would do something as interesting as cheating on me.

I told myself it wasn't a breach of trust. It wasn't really cheating. Hanna knew I'd assume she would start fucking Jake as soon as Hayden and I were out the door. Maybe that's what she had been doing when she'd looked into my eyes just before we left. She was claiming my approval for whatever was about to happen.

It was something to cling onto mentally.

Hayden said now, 'It's kind of weird to think that if I had won that poker game the other night—either night—maybe I would have... you know...'

'Slept with her?' I looked at him, smiling at his sudden awkwardness over what might have happened.

Suddenly defensive, he said, 'Hey, I'm not sure I would've been able to do that to you, anyway, Bud.'

I thought of how Hayden had been, particularly that first game of ours. How flirty he'd been with Hanna. Naked—or almost naked, if things had been different and he'd won that game—I wasn't sure he'd have been able to accompany an entirely naked Hanna upstairs to the bedrooms and resist her very clear intentions to fuck him.

But it was nice that he was sensitive to my possible insecurities.

I said, 'It's all right, man. It's only sex, as I said. When you've been married as long as we have... I don't know... it's like we've done everything together already, anyway. It doesn't matter so much that once in a while someone hops in and takes my place.'

Hayden swigged his drink. 'It's not every husband would say that sort of thing, even after five years married.'

'Seven,' I corrected him. 'But... you know... even for me, that first night... it wasn't exactly easy.'

'But you tell yourself it's only about the sex, and that makes it okay?' he asked. I wondered if Hayden had ever been in love with anyone before. I don't remember ever seeing him cut up about a relationship ending. And, he had never given the impression he was with someone who could go the distance.

I said, 'It felt like... you know... we just take a little breather, Hanna has a little fun while we're on this shitty vacation, and maybe you or Jake get a little fun, too, and then things wouldn't have been all bad this week. No big deal.'

'But you don't get to have fun?'

I shrugged, 'I'd get a wife who'd had fun.'

'And that's a big thing when you're married, right?' he chuckled.

'A happy wife is a happy life.'

‘Even so,’ he said. ‘I was kind of surprised... you know... Jake... going through with it and everything.’

‘I don’t know... the whole concept...’ I shrugged. ‘I think originally it was supposed to be more about the game, you know? We play poker, get through the night. Hanna throws a little spice into the mix, and it all seems exciting. I’m not sure I thought she’d actually go through with it.’

I was telling Hayden a little white lie. I couldn’t admit to him that I was turned on by the thought of Hanna being with someone else, that I had that fantasy. We were friends, but this was too much of a taboo. I couldn’t face his judgement.

‘But maybe... because you didn’t actively stop her...’ he said, trying to add another layer of explanation as though to help me out.

‘She assumed I was okay about it all,’ I nodded. A sigh. ‘Then... you know... after it happened... well, it was no big deal...’

‘Only sex, right?’

‘Right.’

‘But then came the second night... and maybe she’s enjoying being with him a little too much...’

I shrugged. ‘It’s okay if it’s just sex. If it’s more...’

‘And she doesn’t understand that?’ he asked me.

I nodded, and he gave a nod in return as though he understood it all now.

‘If she’d won that second game and she’d had the choice of who to sleep with,’ Hayden said. ‘She would have chosen Jake again, wouldn’t she?’

I nodded. ‘I think so.’

‘Figures.’ It almost sounded as if Hayden felt slightly embarrassed at attempting to flirt with her that second night—at showing signs that he wanted to win the game, that he had wanted to bed her. At the same time, I glanced at him, and there was a mild sense of relief about his features, as though he felt he’d dodged a bullet by not being put in a position to fuck my wife.

‘I hope you wouldn’t have been... offended by her choosing him,’ I said.

‘Oh, I might have been a little pissed at missing out,’ he smiled broadly. ‘I think even I realized she had a little candle for Jake, as soon as he won that second night.’

I recalled Hayden’s reaction—walking away from the poker table and upstairs to bed the moment Jake’s winning hand had been revealed. He’d been gutted.

‘But you know it wasn’t to do with you.’

‘I know, I know. If I’d have won that first game, she would have spent the night with me. I know that.’

‘She would.’

He chuckled, ‘And you know after a night with me she wouldn’t even have needed a second game of poker.’ Then he glanced my way and added, ‘Sorry, man.’

I laughed. ‘You’re probably right. But maybe she’d have fallen for you, and now I’d be sitting here with Jake worrying about the fact that she wanted to see you some more after we got home.’

He sighed. ‘So that’s where this is headed?’

I shrugged again. ‘I don’t know... She’s had a taste of this new relationship, and she doesn’t seem to want it all to suddenly end.’

‘And that was never the deal,’ Hayden said, and he was kind of correct, and yet not entirely there because of the information I failed to share with him.

I picked up my pack, and stood up. ‘I don’t know... I’m probably just paranoid about all of it. She told me she doesn’t love him... I just need to trust that she really does mean it.’

Hayden followed my lead, packing up his water bottle, readying himself for the climb to the top of the mountain. He said, ‘I can have a talk with Jake. You know, make sure he gets how it is.’

‘Oh, you don’t need to do that...’

‘He needs to know this was all about the vacation. Providing some distraction when we were all going nuts. You know... that it all ends when we fly home. We treat it as though none of it ever happened.’

‘I guess he does.’

I was grateful for Hayden’s support.

Chapter Sixteen

It took a while longer to reach the top of the mountain than either Hayden or I had anticipated. All day, in fact. Neither of us were complaining—the views as we got higher and higher were just stunning, real life experiences. We took hundreds, maybe thousands of pictures. The sun was going down as we finally returned to the little town, and eventually back to the chalet.

Hayden and I didn't talk about Hanna and Jake for the rest of the hike—not after that pause in the clearing halfway up the mountain. I think it was good for me to stop thinking about it for a while. Like some kind of therapy session, I'd gotten my thoughts and fears off my chest, and now I felt like I could move on. I had to trust Hanna, I had to trust my wife. If she said she didn't love Jake, that had to be good enough for me—the ring on my finger said as much.

And as we returned to the chalet, the incredibly welcome smell of roasting meat greeting us, I soon felt that my trust approach was the right one.

‘What the hell is going on?’

Hayden's question, as we came into a chalet filled with the smells and sounds of decent cooking, was the same as mine, he just beat me to the punch. Jake and Hanna were all smiles and part-way through fixing the most wonderful meal. In the kitchen there were pots and pans everywhere. On the table there was cutlery ready to host a feast.

‘We went down to the grocery store—and there was a whole farmers' market outside!’ Hanna revealed.

‘You're kidding me!’

‘So what's on the menu?’

‘Chicken—the biggest, fattest, juiciest chicken you ever laid eyes on. And bacon... and potatoes... carrots... parsnips...’

It was a wonderful meal. It was like a ragged, skin-and-bones sailor marooned on a desert island watching a luxury yacht coming steaming directly toward him. Jake and Hanna seemed like the picture of domestic bliss as they served up—which wasn't great for my paranoia, I can tell you, although I hung on tight to my new insistence on trust in my marriage.

Conversation was buoyant, however. I guess it was our last night, we were all relieved that we would all be soon heading home, despite

everything that had happened. We all looked over the photos Hayden and I had taken on our tour of the mountain. We appreciated the various foods Hanna and Jake had found at the farmers' market. We were in jubilant mood, and there was no mention of poker, or of what Jake and Hanna had done on two crazy nights in that chalet.

And even though there was no alcohol, keeping Hayden safe from his addiction for another night, the quantity and quality of food we ate, compared to everything that had come before, was intoxicating in itself. We all ended up in something of a food coma—and after a fairly physically active day, were all quite exhausted that night, too tired to even think about more strip poker.

Everyone ended up collapsing into bed relatively early that night, which was not a bad thing when we had a crucial rendezvous with the airport shuttle bus to meet early the next morning.

I didn't even really think too much about whether Hanna had spent all day fucking Jake before they'd gone out to find the farmers' market. With hindsight, I'm guessing that was why Hanna and Jake were as exhausted as Hayden and I had been after our climb to the top of the mountain. But that night I was too tired to think about such a thing, too tired to initiate anything with Hanna, and even relieved to find she was as eager as I was to just fall into bed and go to sleep.

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Afterwards, of course, I looked back on that night as a missed opportunity. Not only because we could all have played another evening of poker, and Hanna could have ended up sleeping with Hayden, or even Jake again. Also because I didn't get to appreciate how wicked she had probably been with Jake for the whole day Hayden and I had been gone.

There wasn't even, really, a right moment for me to ask her about it all.

Neither did I get to 'reclaim' her as my wife, to give any kind of closure to our vacation adventure.

In the morning we were all up and furiously packing and showering and cleaning up the chalet, so that we could power down the sloped streets to the main road, and the bus stop. It was all too feverish to pause and ask Hanna what she and Jake had got up to prior to their shopping excursion.

I'll tell you, though, that from her attitude and subsequent behavior, it seemed to me that whatever outstanding feelings she had for Jake had been resolved. Once we left the confines of the chalet, she didn't refer to Jake as anything more than one of our friends. She didn't speak about what had happened between them. I know, it was the deal: whatever happened in that chalet stayed in that chalet. It was surprising, though.

To some degree, it was a relief that our argument also seemed to have been left behind, forgotten completely. Hanna was the same bright and breezy brunette she'd always been, the same sharp and pretty girl I'd married. There wasn't even a hint that she had romantic attachments to Jake or anyone else.

Arriving back home in Brooklyn, however, it also seemed to me that the whole discovery of my strange affinity for Hanna to see other men was also forgotten. Hanna certainly didn't refer to it, didn't tease me about it, didn't use it to spur on our sex life. In fact, our sex life soon returned very much to the way it had been before we'd flown off to Eastern Europe. Regularly scheduled on Saturday nights. Short, efficient, skipping on the foreplay. It was strange how easily we just fell back into the same old rut.

I guess both being back at work, in fairly high-stress jobs, we were inevitably going to return to our exhausted lifestyle and find it difficult to find time for extended sexual appreciation of each other. But the way we looked at each other, the way we treated each other, it almost seemed as though we were faintly embarrassed at everything that had happened back in the chalet.

It was a shame.

And the four of us didn't even really speak about our time in the chalet, either. When we went out with our other friends, the ones with kids who couldn't justify ski vacations even if they were only once a year, the subject of our latest trip hardly even came up.

'What the hell happened over there in Europe?' Hardy, who'd been a surprising convert to the whole marriage thing some three years before, asked us at one point over a few beers in a bar downtown. 'Normally you guys are filling the whole of goddamn Facebook with your little jolly skiing snaps—but this year you haven't posted a thing.'

'We told you, didn't we? There was no snow,' Hayden said, as the four of us who did go on the trip gave each other awkward glances.

'So my question stands,' Hardy said with a whiff of smugness. 'What the hell happened over there? What do you do for a week in a ski resort nobody's ever heard of when there's no snow?'

‘We watched TV, we played card games, we went hiking,’ Hanna said, and that was about as close as anybody got to detailing what we’d all done on that week away.

‘Sounds incredibly tedious,’ Hardy declared, and so it seemed none of our friends were motivated to find out the details of what had gone on in that chalet, even if any of the four of us had been prepared to tell.

Life seemed to go back to normal, in pretty much every way. When Hanna and Jake were both present at drinks out after work, the two of them treated each other as friends, and made it seem that nothing untoward had ever gone on between them.

It was so much like nothing had ever actually happened in that chalet that more and more, it felt as though one—or all—of us had simply imagined it.

For me, though, once you’d discovered a taboo-busting sexual fantasy like the one I had about sharing my wife, you couldn’t just ignore it and return to the way you were before the idea had ever come to mind. When I found myself in bed with Hanna on a Saturday night, rushing through sex in an attempt to come as quickly as humanly possible, it was the memory of her time with Jake in that chalet that allowed me to finish as rapidly as Hanna seemed to want me to finish.

Had Hanna so easily forgotten about her two nights with Jake?

Chapter Seventeen

A few months after we got back from Europe, I woke to find myself unexpectedly alone in bed.

My first thoughts didn't immediately jump to paranoid fears about where my wife was, or what she might be doing. But as I waited for her to come back from the bathroom, I spread my arm out over the mattress and felt that the sheet where she would ordinarily sleep was cold. She'd been out of bed for a while.

My bedside clock said it was 4am. What time did she wake, three?

I actually wondered if Hanna was sick, or something like that might be hitting her sleep.

Then I heard a little giggle from out in the living room.

My first thought was that she was out there watching TV, either on the big television screen with the wireless headphones or on her tablet with headphones. It wasn't unusual when one of us was tired, and one was wired for some reason during an evening for us to go down this route: one of us would sleep while the other got on with their evening using headphones. But this was 4am, so she must have had some serious insomnia, the like of which I'd never known her to have.

I was about to get out of bed and wander out there to see what was up with her, but then I heard her giggle again and say: 'No!'

My heart skipped a beat.

You didn't watch television and interact with it like that. You didn't say 'No!' like that to a TV show. It wasn't a long, drawn out *Noooooo* that you might say when your cornerback misses a tackle and the opposition's wide receiver sprints 50 yards and straight into an unguarded end zone. It wasn't a shocked 'No!' that you might emit when finding out that Marlana Evans is the killer on *Days of Our Lives*. The sound I had heard from Hanna was light-hearted, flirty.

My paranoia—and, I guess since the events of the chalet, my libido—jumped instantly to the conclusion that Hanna had woken up at a time she felt certain I'd be sleeping soundly to secretly chat with Jake.

Since the adventure in the chalet, I had been pining for something unusual to happen in our sex life, to be sure—even if that meant Hanna cheating on me. For some reason I felt unable to talk to her about it—as though talking about it might return us to the argument over her feelings for him. Ever since our trip to Europe, when Hanna had gone out for the

night with her friends or co-workers without me, I would be hoping fervently that she would stay out late and get a little drunk and be tempted into something wicked. My hope was always that she might meet someone new, some guy at work, perhaps, or a stranger in a bar. That she might remember, even though I had concerns about her falling for Jake, that underneath it all, my fantasy was for her to sleep with other men.

I was always a little disappointed when she came home without any tales of debauchery. I guess over the weeks she could even have forgotten about my fantasy—or had she really left everything that had happened in that chalet back in that chalet?

Suddenly I was both excited and terrified that she had been seeing Jake behind my back. I felt sick to my stomach that she might have broken my trust by doing such a thing—and yet my manhood thickened up quickly at the thought that she might have been tempted into genuine adultery. It was a confusing mix of feelings. I'm not even sure what I thought I would do if I discovered that she really was cheating on me with Jake. Confront her? Try to get her to open up about her sexual experiences to pander to my perversion?

It would seem most unfair for me to reveal to her a desire for her to sleep with other men and share the details with me, if she then decided to sleep with other men in secret.

I slipped out of bed. I think my biggest hope was that, somehow, she was flirting with a new guy online. Perhaps she was going to set something up, and then present me with a wonderful surprise: she was going to go on a date with someone, to help rekindle our own sex life. But as I padded across the soft carpet toward our closed bedroom door, there was another giggle, and the tone was flirty and yet friendly. It made me feel that chances were that she really was talking to Jake.

Had they met up in real life to continue their adultery? Or had they simply started an online flirtation that might lead that way at some point?

I put my ear to the door. Another giggle. It confirmed to me that she was on our couch, which stretched along the wall separating our bedroom from the living room of our small apartment. She was sat at the closest end of our couch, and I was fairly sure that meant she would be facing away from the door, toward the windows.

I silently turned the handle on our bedroom door to open it. I thanked my lucky stars that the well-oiled door and its handle opened without a sound—although I was prepared, at any point, for her to notice

me and to sleepily inquire as to her well-being and reasons for being up and about. At any moment I would just spring into innocent mode, acting the innocent husband responding to the realization that his wife was no longer in bed even though it was 4am.

As the door opened, however, Hanna showed no signs of noticing. I saw her stretched out along the couch, facing away from me, lying on her back but with her head and shoulders propped up by a cushion and the armrest. Her laptop was on her thighs, and she was typing into it. I only had to crane my head slightly to see what was on her screen: a messenger app. And I could see Jake's face on screen, captured via a webcam.

I felt my stomach drop, my heart nearly seize up in horror—and yet my manhood thickened up dramatically.

How could she? How could she talk to him like this, behind my back?

I felt nauseous. I felt the anger rising inside me—and yet what tempered it was the very clear arousal I also felt. I waited a moment—still not wanting a real confrontation with her, despite the betrayal I felt. After a few beats, a few deep breaths, I started to calm down. I felt the faint whiff of irony, that I had been so supportive of my wife sleeping with my friend, but now she was here chatting with him on a computer. I was all riled up.

Maybe there was an innocent explanation.

Even though Hanna was facing away from me, I had to be careful that Jake didn't see in the background of his view of my wife that I was hiding in the doorway. It meant I couldn't lean out and attempt to read what the two of them were talking about while Hanna typed.

Hanna giggled again, in response to something she read on her screen.

My erection responded to her obvious cheerfulness. It made me think how down she'd been, on the whole, since we'd returned from Europe. I wouldn't exactly say depressed, but certainly not what you'd say was obviously happy. Come to think of it, she'd been much like that before the trip to Europe. Was that how she'd become through our marriage? It was nice to see her happy again, though, even if it was because she was talking to Jake. I hated to jump to the conclusion that she was lying to me, cheating behind my back. The nausea felt awful.

Maybe she was just chatting with Jake about the possibility of persuading me to allow them some time together again. That would be okay, wouldn't it? Maybe she would remind me of my fantasy, tell me

that she would be careful not to fall in love with him, but that she needed his big cock.

I waited, I watched her tap-tap-tapping away on that keyboard. She laughed occasionally, sighed. Sometimes even gasped, or at least caught her breath at something he said. She really was all bubbly and chirpy and light now that she was talking to Jake. It was wonderful to see, even if it irked me slightly that it wasn't me that made her feel that way. It made me think that at least a small part of my strange fantasy was the desire to make my wife happy, at any cost, even if that meant sex with someone else. I liked the idea that she could have the excitement of a new sexual relationship.

After a while, I could see her fumbling with something—there was a small click as she plugged something into the side of her laptop, and then she put a small headset on, the kind she occasionally used for Skype calls with her parents when the line quality was especially poor. In this case it seemed that it allowed her to talk to Jake quietly, supposedly to avoid waking me.

'Yeah... this is my actual voice,' she said softly, barely more than a whisper. 'But only for a minute, okay?'

I couldn't hear Jake's reply, which was fed through the headset.

Then she whispered, 'No, I told you. It'll wake him.'

It seemed amusing to me that she wasn't aware her giggling had been loud enough to wake me anyway.

I listened to her for a few minutes, and she wasn't saying much more than: 'Yeah... yeah... no, seriously?'

Then, she said: 'Okay, Buddy. I hope you can get some sleep. Yeah... okay...'

It wasn't exactly what you'd call sexual. The tone of her voice was more friendly, platonic. Like she'd been supporting him as purely a friend in a time of difficulty. I started thinking that perhaps Jake had some issue in his life that caused him stress or anxiety. Had a family member died? He had both parents, still, and I hadn't heard of any serious illnesses or anything. But perhaps he needed Hanna as a friend to help him through something like that.

I took a step back toward the open bedroom door, slightly regretting my intrusion upon her late-night conversation with him. Maybe whatever difficulty Jake was going through needed the kind of confidential relationship he might have with a therapist or a doctor. And I was in danger of breaching his doctor-patient trust. Now I was worried that

Hanna would discover me there, and get angry with me for invading their privacy.

But as I edged back into the bedroom, I heard Hanna say: ‘Okay, Dude. You have a good one, okay?’

Again, friendly rather than loving.

I saw Hanna quietly close the lid of her laptop, and I prepared to flee back to bed. She didn’t rise from the couch, however. She placed the laptop down on the floor beside her, then gave a long sigh, and drew her hands down over her body to nestle between her legs.

She lay still for a moment or two, and I wondered if she was about to fall asleep right there where she lay on the couch. But then as I grew bold enough to edge back out of the bedroom, to get a better view of her, I saw that between her thighs her hand was moving a little. She was stroking herself there. I felt a jolt of surprise shoot through my chest, and my manhood thickened back up to full hardness.

I saw her thighs fall open, and her hips were tilting to offer herself easier access. Her fingers were dancing over her underwear, as one hand pulled up her nightshirt.

I caught my breath.

I heard her breathing deepen as she pulled the narrow band of white cotton covering her sex aside, so that she could steer her fingers over her exposed sex. She sighed quietly, and there was a slight tremor in her breathing as her other hand glided up and under her nightshirt to cup one of her breasts.

Oh God.

I could see over her shoulders, down her body as one of her fingers dipped inside her pussy. I was so hard, watching her. Not only was it simply beautiful to watch—the way her body moved, rising and falling in gentle undulations as she coaxed the little moans from her body—but it was such a buzz that she’d just been secretly chatting with Jake. It had to be connected, even if her vocal sign-off with him had seemed anything but romantic.

I watched as she built up quite a head of steam. Her fingers were working hard, turning circles around her clit, pressing against her increasingly slippery folds, delving deep inside her.

She had been worried about waking me, but now she was lying back and moaning to the point where it seemed she was trying to actively wake me, or had forgotten about me entirely. Should I step forward? Act like she had woken me up, and maybe join in?

I was so hard, and it was so tempting—but the suggestion that she had been talking with Jake behind my back, the implication that it might mean she was actively cheating on me troubled me too much. I didn't want to get involved, and have all my concerns about what she was doing with Jake blurted out accidentally. For one, I wasn't entirely sure how I felt about it. There was the breach of trust, sure. I was more than disappointed at that. But it was still enticing to have her committing adultery, it seemed to me. Somehow. And wasn't adultery purest when it was behind the husband's back?

I stepped back, allowed her to reach orgasm alone, but as hot as it was, I slipped back into bed and tried to calm down. It wasn't easy. I wanted to storm out there and demand to know why, when I'd taken the bold step of actively allowing her to sleep with a guy—guys, if she wanted—other than myself, could she feel the need to keep anything she had with Jake to herself?

Wasn't that a key issue? It wasn't just that she was falling for him: it was that she was circumventing me, she wasn't involving me. And to get around our marriage vows, it seemed to me that I had to be involved.

I waited. I heard her return to bed.

Somehow, I slept.

Chapter Eighteen

The next morning, Hanna seemed noticeably upbeat. She was very chatty as we had breakfast, talking about the new creative brief she'd been given to lead at her agency, making me wonder why she hadn't mentioned anything about it the evening before. She was wearing a skirt with her suit for the first time in I don't know how long, and though it came down to her knees it did show plenty of leg. Her heels were a bit higher too than what she normally wore. She seemed to have a touch more perfume on than usual, and unless I was imagining things, she'd been a little heavier with the lipstick and eyeliner than usual that morning. And I swear, her bust was pushed up more than usual—and it wasn't just the cut of her suit.

She looked gorgeous—and very flirty.

I tried not to appear as though I'd noticed anything. No doubt she might say she was making more of an effort because she was now leading a team at her advertising agency, and wanted to make a good first impression that morning. Part of me—the part between my legs, no doubt—hoped that perhaps there was some new guy she had her eye on in her office. Would she tell me if something like that happened? We'd never actually talked about her having sexual freedom beyond what had happened in the chalet, but she knew what my big sexual fantasy was. Perhaps she felt free to act on it.

My conscious mind, however, felt the flicker of anxiety overwhelming everything. I felt nervous as I ate my own breakfast cereal on one of our couches while Hanna fixed her own grapefruit extravaganza in the kitchen. Was she meeting Jake for lunch? Were they already beyond casual lunch meetings, moving on to full-on mid-day sex at a motel somewhere?

It was so confusing. I was so turned on by the idea, and yet the anguish about her doing things behind my back was truly awful.

I played along, chatted as cheerfully as she did, responded to her career news proudly and with real interest. I kissed her goodbye before getting ready for my own work day, which involved much less smart clothing and no early starts, but actually paid me on a level with Hanna.

I went onto Facebook. It seemed like a fairly stupid place to start—if I'd been thinking rationally, I'd have said there would be no way Hanna would admit to meeting Jake for lunch on Facebook if she wasn't

going to openly tell me about it to my face. And of course, I found nothing suspicious on her timeline. I scouted around her posts, her list of friends, finding nothing but distraction. Then I glanced at Jake's timeline. Jake was in Japan, according to his latest few posts. I was mildly impressed. Apparently he was there on business—but what was a lowly accountant doing in the Far East on business?

His posts from Japan were actually kind of interesting, and had far too many comments on them from friends and especially family to be in any way fake. I was kind of relieved, he couldn't possibly have been meeting Hanna for lunches and more. Not recently, at least. Perhaps before the trip, of course, but my gut feeling was that Hanna's late-night chats with Jake had not been going on for long. I would have noticed the upturn in her mood much earlier, I was sure.

I signed out of Facebook, my IT executive's brain trying to think whether I'd left any kind of trail that would make Hanna suspect I'd been trawling through her Facebook timeline—but Hanna wasn't the kind of person who would know how to find any kind of incriminating signs of my suspicion, I was fairly sure.

Now I was late for work, but feeling better about things.

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That night, I watched my wife some more.

This time, I didn't go to sleep. It was crazy, but I was so obsessed with seeing what my wife and my best friend were doing at night, that I stayed up. I couldn't afford to set any kind of alarm to wake me up at 3am—and yet I couldn't rely on my body clock to simply wake me at the right time, either. So I just stayed up later than usual, telling my wife when she was ready for bed that I wasn't feeling sleepy yet. I did go to bed around midnight, however, as I didn't want Hanna to get suspicious. But, I didn't go to sleep.

Staying awake wasn't so difficult once Hanna was asleep beside me, thanks to my smartphone. Netflix, podcasts, YouTube, the New York Times—it was all there to keep me occupied for a few hours, while lying motionless beside my wife.

About 3am the alarm on Hanna's phone went off. It wasn't quite as loud as it could have been, but I was still a little taken aback at how bold she was waking herself up that way. She had to be confident that I was a

heavy enough sleeper. Confidence, as it happened, that was perhaps misplaced—although I suppose I hadn't really been woken by her phone alarm the last time.

She immediately shut off the alarm on waking, then paused for quite a while to make sure I was still asleep. I was pretty good at faking it. After a while, she seemed satisfied enough that I was fast asleep, and crept out of bed. She paid a brief visit to the bathroom—and left the light on, I noticed, after she left—then checked on me one more time before venturing out into the living room.

I did well at portraying a man in deep, deep sleep. At least, it seemed to me.

I waited for her to get comfortable on the couch, and then crept out of bed myself, the cool air raising goose bumps on my skin as I went. This time, I peered through the crack in the bedroom door to see that Hanna had camped out on the far end of the couch, closest to the windows. She was facing me, so there was no way I could creep out of the bedroom to make any kind of attempt to see what she was typing to Jake.

'He's asleep.'

Her voice surprised me. She spoke quietly, and the noise of the extractor fan in the bathroom didn't help me to hear, but skulking that close to the bedroom door I could just about make out what she was saying.

'The fan is on in the bathroom, so he won't hear us,' she said.

I didn't hear Jake's side of the conversation. Was he on headphones? I couldn't quite see Hanna well enough through the crack in the door to tell.

'No, he'd get all suspicious,' she said, and I was naturally suspicious about her theorizing about my getting suspicious. 'It's not worth it—he's asleep, that's fine. So how're you doing?'

It was friendly, it was bright and breezy. She found out all about what he was up to in Japan, how his day went out there, investigating the accounts of some Japanese corporation that was due to merge with an American company. I had no idea that was the kind of thing Jake did for a living. I guess my assumptions about accountants were that they simply did everybody's taxes once a year.

'Don't you think you should learn some phrases, you know, if you're going to be there a whole month?'

She sounded like his best buddy. I felt strangely jealous that she was infringing on my territory as Jake's friend. I could tell quickly from the

conversation that he had been feeling pretty lonely and isolated, adrift in the middle of the colossal city of Tokyo. Why hadn't he persuaded me to chat with him in the early hours of the morning instead of Hanna?

My guess was, he needed some female company—even if, as I listened, this seemed to be strangely platonic, despite their recent sexual encounters. Jake could talk to Hanna in a way he couldn't with Hayden or myself or one of the other guys. He could open up a little more, reveal more of his vulnerabilities.

'You should definitely visit the Imperial Palace, it's supposed to be *amazing*...'

I wouldn't have said it was 100% platonic, though. The two of them were flirting, even if they weren't actively having phone sex together. I guess that was another reason why Jake was confiding in Hanna, and not me.

'How could it *possibly* be depressing going to Tokyo Disneyland? Even on your own.'

But there was no lovey-dovey stuff. None of the sorts of *I-really-miss-you* or *I-wish-you-weren't-so-far-away* or *I-can't-stand-that-you'll-be-gone-for-a-whole-month* kind of heartfelt, bittersweet expressions of long-distance longing. I listened to her, and I felt entirely unthreatened by my wife's secret conversation with my friend. My guess was that when Hanna had told him I'd get suspicious, it had been after Jake had suggested they come clean and tell me she was chatting with him to help him cope with the solitude of his daily life in Japan.

Then after Hanna said goodbye to Jake, closed her laptop and put it down on the floor beside her, I could just about see through the gap to know that, once again, she was lying back on the couch and tending to her own sexual frustrations.

I took full advantage of her distraction to quietly turn the handle on the door and ease it open a little more so that I could see properly.

There she was, lying flat on her back, head up against the cushions in the corner of the couch, one knee up against the back of the couch, one leg draped over the edge toward the floor. Since she was facing toward me this time, I had an even better view of what she was doing—her thighs parted, her pea-green nightshirt pushed up, one hand cupping a breast through the shirt, the other sunk beneath her silky gray panties, stroking her pussy.

After a while she lifted her hips briefly, and removed her panties completely, and I could see everything as her fingers strummed her soaking sex. So beautiful to watch her, and startling because before the

previous night, I'd never gotten to watch my wife touching herself—masturbation was a private thing in our relationship, even after seven years married.

Once again I was tempted to intervene. Once again I stepped back, leaving her to it. It seemed like such a personal time, I didn't feel I had the right to intrude.

I closed the door again and returned to bed, and, despite the continuing hum of the bathroom fan, I did hear her moan as her orgasm finally hit. Was she thinking about Jake when she touched herself? It couldn't be a coincidence that she was moved to masturbate immediately after their little international chat came to a close. And yet... maybe this was one of the only times in the day or night when Hanna felt she had genuine privacy. She knew I was asleep, so she just went ahead and dealt with her sexual needs.

I mean—it wasn't as though I didn't masturbate from time to time. I tended to do it in the shower, but I still needed my own private time to do it.

I did feel uneasy as Hanna came to bed, however. Our sex life had gone back to a regular unfulfilling quickie each Saturday night. I'd tried to spin things out a little, here and there, but it felt wrong, and Hanna had seemed impatient somehow. It had felt as though I was trying to resurrect how we felt each other while in Europe, in the chalet, and yet our argument had closed the door on that.

It made me wonder what other doors between us might have also closed.

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Hanna and I were at a dinner party with some of our married-with-kids friends out in the suburbs. Once again, the topic of our trip to Europe came up—how could it not? Our friends were jealous that we got to travel, that we got to go skiing, that we got to sleep at night. Hanna and I told them that there had been no skiing, that there had been no snow, but we didn't mention anything else about the trip. Thankfully, there was no 'what did you do, then?' kind of follow-up question from anybody. Conversation moved briskly on to something else about some of the kids.

I think normally, Hanna and I would have suffered through a dinner like that. We'd tried so hard to have kids ourselves, but even when my equipment was working fully, that pregnancy had just never come along. I guess it was to the point where we needed to get properly tested, to see if there was an infertility issue somewhere. But it was so humiliating, as far as I was concerned, and I suspected Hanna felt similarly. We'd wait a year or two, the biological clock would tick loudly enough that we'd overcome that sense of humiliation, I figured.

This time, though, we were just happy that our friends weren't talking about what had happened to us on our trip to Europe, we were relieved they weren't trying to grill us for the truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth.

I looked across the table at Hanna, and we smiled at each other to share our relief that our friends were so totally absorbed in their own family life these days to really pay much attention to other people. It wasn't often you'd be relieved about that, but there you go. As she smiled at me, it really struck me just how pretty she was, how beautiful she was when she smiled. She looked amazing too, wearing what seemed to be a new strapless red dress. And it struck me that she really had to love me, properly love me, to smile at me like that. Even if she did actually love Jake as well, she did love me.

Then as my attention finally returned to dinner, and the conversation before us, Patricia Wallace was talking about having her new baby, and about how it had been for her first child to get used to having a baby brother all of a sudden.

She said, 'It's a big change mentally, of course. Because when it's just Brady... you know, mommy and daddy love him more than anything in the world. And then along comes this other little person, and mommy and daddy love him more than anything in the world, too.'

Jenny Goldsmith, who had four kids by now, said, 'It's always like that with the first one. It's like they think love is like a pie: the bigger the piece you give to the new baby, the less there is for them.'

Something inside my head clicked, listening to them.

'If you start loving somebody new, it doesn't mean you have to stop loving your existing kids any less. And it's the same when the third one comes along...'

'Maybe not the fourth one, though,' Donnie Goldsmith joked, attracting an eye-roll from his wife.

Gayle Morgan said, 'We told our kids that love is more like TV—it's always there when you need it, and it's available to an unlimited

number of people, and the signal doesn't reduce the more people are watching it.'

'I guess it's just really frightening,' Jenny said, 'to feel maybe you're not loved as much anymore.'

Was that how I felt about Hanna falling for Jake?

It seemed like it to me. So, I was just a big kid, worried about losing my portion of the love pie. But it really made sense to me. Love is unlimited, so why should I feel threatened if Hanna slept with Jake, and ended up loving him, too? As long as she continued to love me. That was the important thing.

The most important issue, I decided, was my own bond with Hanna.

We were married, and yet more and more it felt as though we were siblings, rather than lovers. I couldn't be sure whether she thought about Jake when she touched herself, but watching her touch herself after those nightly conversations with my friend had made me feel excluded. Simply because she was doing it in secret. Now I could concede that feeling that way was unfair to Hanna, since I probably masturbated as often, if not more so, than she did, and I didn't always think about her when I masturbated.

But how could I turn things around? How could we turn things around? Did Hanna have any interest in turning things around with me?

A few evenings later, I had drinks out with Hayden after work. After everything that had happened at the chalet, and my mountainside conversation with him, I felt able to open up to Hayden about what was going on.

'It was a pretty strange time,' he said, 'back in that chalet. I'm not surprised she can't stop thinking about it.'

'Thinking about 'it', or about him?' I asked.

He sighed. 'Well, you got to go with your gut, haven't you? You think she has feelings for him.'

'I do.'

'So you have to expect she's been thinking about him, not just the basic cheating thing.'

'Oh, it wasn't cheating,' I smiled. And I guess when I said it, I was kind of reminding myself that nothing Hanna had done had been without consent from myself.

Hayden looked suddenly a touch surprised. Well, I suppose I hadn't told him the whole truth before. I guess I hadn't explicitly told him I enjoyed many aspects of Hanna's extramarital liaisons. 'Not cheating?'

‘Well, you know I allowed it all to happen.’

He nodded. ‘I suppose you did. But you regretted that, right?’

I shook my head. ‘Only the part about her falling for him. And even that—I guess I’ve been thinking that if it makes her happy...’

Now he was a trifle shocked. ‘You’d really... let her... fall for him?’ I got the sense that he couldn’t get his head around the thought that I would allow another guy to sleep with my wife. I wasn’t ready to completely spell it out to him, not when I was still in two minds about everything. But I gave him a kind of picture in which I was obviously open to the possibility of something unconventional happening.

I said, ‘I guess if she still loves me... and she doesn’t want to leave me... what would be the harm in her loving someone else as well?’

‘Okay...’ he said, not quite knowing what to say to that.

‘I mean... we spend a lot of time with each other... there’d plenty of time for her to see him as well... the only issue is... whether she’d still want to be with me if she had him.’

‘I suppose a lot of guys... if they wanted some guy’s wife, they wouldn’t want her to keep on seeing her husband,’ Hayden nodded.

‘Most wouldn’t,’ I agreed.

‘But this is Jake. He’s your buddy, right? He’d never take her from you.’

‘Yeah, I know. But they are talking behind my back. And she... well, she clearly still wants him.’

Hayden pointed a finger at me, ‘But what do you want? I mean, in a perfect world?’

What did I want? That was a question.

‘I just want to know that she’s not going to leave me,’ I said. Sounded kind of pathetic, I suppose. ‘I don’t mind if she wants to see him... if she wants an affair... I just want...’ It was difficult to open up completely. To admit that I wanted Hanna to sleep with whoever she wanted, that the thought of her being unfaithful was sexy to me.

‘What? What do you want?’ he prompted me.

I took a deep breath. ‘I kind of want her to have an affair,’ I admitted. I felt an odd surge of sexual arousal as I admitted it. ‘I think maybe she *needs* to do it... but I don’t want her to feel she has to leave me to do it.’

I looked warily into Hayden’s eyes, thinking he’d be disgusted with me for saying such a thing about my own wife, for giving up my marital rights just like that.

But he seemed only understanding. Maybe even mildly impressed, for some reason.

‘Maybe you need to talk to Jake,’ he said.

‘Jake?’

He nodded. ‘He’s a good guy—we both know that. He doesn’t want to hurt you.’

‘No.’

‘So maybe you just need to sound him out about... you know... having an affair with her... without breaking up your marriage.’

Chapter Nineteen

I emailed Jake. It seemed like the easiest way to start up some conversation with him, considering the time difference between us. And because writing to him, rather than talking initially face-to-face, seemed like the least humiliating way to get into the possibility of him having an affair with my wife.

I kept things light in my message, or as light as possible, but dropped in a little hint of things that needed to be resolved after Slovakia, before asking if he might be able to talk sometime, perhaps via Skype or FaceTime. I mentioned that I'd seen on Facebook that he was in Japan, and expressed mild surprise that he hadn't said anything about his upcoming trip. I suggested that maybe what had happened back in the chalet had taken a toll on our friendship—even though, as far as I was concerned, neither of us had done anything wrong.

Then, I asked whether he might be able to help me with something. I suggested that Hanna had seemed a little down recently, and that as far as I could tell it had started not long after we'd returned from Europe. I told Jake I thought that, perhaps, she had had such an adventure with everything that had happened, that now she was going through a withdrawal of some sort, whether she realized it or not.

It was mostly honest and on the level. I didn't talk about my concerns about her falling for him—but then he had to be aware of what Hanna and I had argued about back at the chalet. I didn't talk about my strange sexual fixation on Hanna's infidelity, either. I wasn't entirely sure how to talk about that with a friend. And anyway, I was trying to keep the message short and not too heavy.

I wasn't sure how he'd take it. I wasn't sure how strong he felt about Hanna, and whether he still saw me as a friend or a rival. But even if I felt nervous to press that 'send' button, it did also feel cathartic. I was getting something off my chest that needed to get gone. I was taking a pre-emptive strike that would allow me to gauge how Jake really felt about Hanna, and whether I needed to do something about it.

It seemed to take ages to get any kind of reply. I suppose by the time I'd written and rewritten that short message over and over and over, and finally sent it, it was getting on for noon in Brooklyn. With 14 hours' time difference to Tokyo, that meant Jake would receive the email at

2am. Such an awkward gap—no wonder Hanna had to get up at 3 in the morning to chat with him.

I couldn't get it off my mind all afternoon. I was working on a website for a company that made vacuum cleaners, and couldn't do much to keep my focus on the coding.

All afternoon my paranoia twisted things in my head, I started worrying about what I'd said to Jake, and about how he'd interpret what I'd said. When I'd told him Hanna was going through some kind of withdrawal, was I suggesting that the solution was for her to start seeing him again? In which case, would a fairly normal monogamous type of guy like Jake assume that I was suggesting that Hanna should start seeing him instead of me?

I started foreseeing a video call with Jake in which he agreed that Hanna should leave me to hook up with him—and that when I refused to give her up, anger ensued.

What if he started messaging Hanna about my email? My wife might be surprised at hearing that I thought she'd been down in the dumps since we got back from Europe. She might be suspicious that, after she'd started secret chats with Jake at night, I was now getting in touch with Jake trying to get involved with their relationship. Would she think me manipulative? Devious?

What if my interference actively pushed Hanna into Jake's arms, and away from our marriage?

If she did want to end our marriage, we had no kids to worry about.

I stayed unusually late at work, hoping for a reply. If only I'd requested an alert to tell me if Jake had read my message—but I was naturally cautious about doing such a thing, it was all too easy to find out if someone had requested such an alert, and I didn't want to come across to Jake as desperate or suspicious—or, come to think of it, threatened.

About six in the evening, I was thinking Hanna might be home already and wondering where I was. I didn't really want to reveal my full hand to her, either. What if Jake didn't even read my email? There was the chance it would go into his junk mail folder, or even that it would simply be overlooked among the flood of marketing materials that, these days, even managed to get past junk mail filters. He might wait days just to pluck up the courage to open my message.

I waited. I didn't want to go home and have all of this playing on my mind. I texted Hanna to let her know that one of our website projects had a problem that required me to stay late.

Then, finally, at around six-thirty, Jake sent a reply.

Hey Buddy, how's things? Yeah, it's been crazy for me at work recently—and the Japan thing hit me without warning, so I never got the chance to really tell anybody about it. Hanna actually messaged me about it because she noticed it on Facebook before you did.

Sorry to hear what's going on—I guess things got a little insane back in the chalet. To be honest I wasn't sure what to say to you guys about it afterward. I figured we had said that what happened in the chalet would stay in the chalet, so it seemed to me that no one wanted to talk about it once we left. I don't know what I can do to help—maybe we can talk about it, though?

Japan's been interesting, and the work's okay, but it's kind of intimidating if I'm honest. I feel a long way away from anybody I know, and not knowing anything about the language, I feel kinda lost most of the time.

Anyway, I've had a lot of time to think, and to be honest, I'm kind of regretting what happened back at the chalet—you and Hanna seemed to want it to happen at the time, but it should never have gone that far. I guess we were all feeling crazy stuck in that chalet with nothing to do all week, huh? Maybe it would be best to just forget about it, but I'm not sure what we could do to help Hanna to move on.

I'm just off to work, and I usually get back to my hotel by about 4pm, but with the time difference I guess maybe we could talk just before you go off to work in the morning? Let me know, Buddy.

- Jake.

I read and re-read the message a few times as I sat on the B, heading from my office in Midtown Manhattan back to Brooklyn. On the whole, I'd say I felt relieved by the tone of his reply. It did feel as though he wasn't telling me the whole truth—for one, he'd reduced his nightly chat sessions with Hanna to her having messaged him. I guess you could say he was truthful, just not quite laying it all out there. The truth, but not the 'whole truth', so to speak.

But then, wasn't it also true to say that I hadn't laid out my whole side of the deal to him either? We were both as bad as each other.

From his message, I could just about accept that he'd been talking to Hanna out of loneliness. It also seemed, if he was being straight, that maybe he had moved on from what had happened back at the chalet. His tone suggested that he wasn't trying to get things re-started with Hanna, that he even thought she needed help 'to move on'.

Why would he lie about that, if he intended to have a secret affair with her, or worse, planned to take her from me permanently?

He was in Japan. It seemed to me there was no point in lying about anything—he could tell me straight that he'd been talking with Hanna and the two of them wanted to start seeing each other, and she was thinking perhaps it might be best if she left me. He could shield himself from my anger by totally ignoring me online.

The truth, I felt certain, was that Jake had decided we needed to push past what happened in the chalet and remain as friends.

The only odd thing seemed to be the way he'd played down his chatting with Hanna at night. I could only suppose that it was a difficult thing to open up about—*oh yeah, Buddy, I've been talking with your wife every night trying to get through this horrible loneliness*. I suppose it wasn't easy to admit the extent of loneliness, and maybe it was easier to admit to a female friend than a male one.

Would he be having another secret chat with Hanna that night? He hadn't mentioned anything about it, of course, hadn't invited me to join. But then we were intending to talk about Hanna, so needed our own private time.

When I returned home, Hanna was on the couch watching the TV show *The Good Place* on Netflix, curled up with a takeout pizza.

'Hey, how did it go?' she asked as I came in. 'You guys get everything sorted?'

'I think so,' I lied, though without really saying anything.

'Want some pizza? It just came.'

I dropped down on the couch beside her, trying my best to act normally, though I was being cautious, attempting to work out whether Jake had said anything to her about my emailing him. As the evening wore on, I had to believe he hadn't said anything to her—and that seemed to me to underline his credentials as a friend looking to get past a brief fling with his friend's wife, rather than attempting to conspire to steal her.

What would he think about me wanting him to have an affair with her?

Chapter Twenty

That night, Hanna did, indeed, wake up at 3am once again to talk with Jake. I had a better strategy this time round: earlier than usual in the evening I told Hanna I wasn't feeling so hot and needed an early night. I managed five hours of solid sleep, then woke myself up with a vibration-only alarm on my phone at not long after 2.30am. I set additional vibration-only alarms in case the first did not wake me, but it did.

Once again, Hanna woke at 3am. She crept out of bed, and set up on the couch. I went to the doorway and silently opened the door to watch her. As with the previous night, she seemed confident enough in the soundness of my sleep to talk with Jake instead of just typing messages. If anything, she was even slightly louder than the previous night—I guess I'd proven myself to be a reliable sleeper.

'Hey, man, how you doing?' she greeted him cheerfully. It was still a risk, talking out loud like this, but from the way she spoke with him I guessed that he had said something about it being good to hear her voice. It had to be better, if you were lonely and remote from everyone you knew, to talk with someone directly and not via a keyboard.

'You are kidding me!' she said, and for a moment my heart seemed to stop beating, and I felt certain Jake had just told her that I'd gotten in touch and had said some weird things about wanting to talk with him about her.

But then after a moment or two, she said: 'You went there? Was it as good as everybody says?' And, proudly, 'I told you it would be something good to do.'

They chatted, innocently. It seemed that Jake didn't tell Hanna at all that I'd been in touch, or that I was apparently worried about her. Surely if he was being all best-buddies with Hanna, he would have mentioned something? *Hey you know what? Thad emailed me yesterday, said he wanted to talk. Said he was worried you've been feeling down lately.* Maybe she would dismiss my concerns, tell Jake she was perfectly fine. Maybe she would wonder if I had discovered she was talking to him at night, maybe she would ask if Jake thought I was getting suspicious about them. But none of that came to pass.

I listened, and they chatted. I quickly zoned out—mostly it seemed to be Hanna getting Jake talking about Japan, but since I couldn't hear his replies, it was hardly enlightening. Hanna chipped in with a few

tidbits about her life, her work and so on, but she'd already told most of it, and the rest was just small-talk. There was really no mention of any romantic stuff, no sexual stuff. Even the flirty nature of their conversation seemed to have toned down somewhat.

But now came something different: when Hanna said goodbye to him, and closed down her messenger app, she didn't shut down the laptop, she didn't put it down on the floor beside her. This time, I saw her open up the photos app on her machine, and now she was scrolling through pictures taken during our week in the chalet.

These were not pictures I had seen. These were not the pictures taken by Hayden or myself on our hike to the top of the mountain—and I hadn't realized any other pictures had been taken during that week, because our mostly-tedious time in the chalet itself hadn't warranted recording our experiences photographically.

My heart started pumping forcefully as I saw her open some of the pictures—they were all of Jake, some of herself, some of her with Jake. She started looking at pictures the two of them must have taken during their day at the farmer's market, and preparing food for our final feast. But then she was looking at more risqué pictures, taken from within the chalet, during the nights she'd spent with Jake.

I was so hard as I saw what she was looking at. Shots of Hanna and Jake with no clothes on. There were selfies the two of them had taken while kissing—and apparently, the act of taking selfies while also making out had been challenging and highly amusing. Then it got more explicit. I caught my breath at the sight of Hanna straddling Jake, his erect cock held firmly in one hand. Then there was a picture of her face, close up but with the end of his cock touching her lips. Next: she was kneeling in front of him, his cock filling her mouth. After a few more similar shots, where she was licking him, stroking him, they moved to the bed and she was lying between his thighs, taking his hardness inside her mouth.

As the pictures started appearing where Hanna was riding him, and Jake's cock was clearly buried inside her pussy, my heart was pounding so hard I thought I might keel over if I wasn't careful. I had to be careful that she didn't hear my breathing as I peered over her shoulders at the screen of her laptop.

There was a closeup of his shaft protruding from her pussy—he was deep inside her, there could be no mistake. Despite the fact that I'd actually watched them fucking in the chalet of that kitchen, this seemed so much more dramatic—this was the close-up view.

So many extreme pictures, it was quite a shock. Then after a while I realized I'd been focusing so hard on what was on Hanna's screen that I'd failed to notice that while she had her laptop balanced on her stomach, one hand accessing its touch pad to flick through the pictures, her other hand was stuffed between her thighs again, taking care of business.

Jesus. To me it confirmed what she'd been thinking about every time she'd ended her calls with Jake to start masturbating.

And yet their late-night conversations really had been so entirely platonic.

It felt to me that the two of them had made a conscious decision to leave everything that had happened in that chalet back in that chalet. They were actively trying to be friends and not lovers now that they were back home. Yet there was no mistake that Hanna had not stopped having sexual thoughts about Jake.

Hanna flicked through so many pictures. Did Jake have copies of these pictures? It gave me a real idea of what had gone on. From the furiously hot sexual intercourse to the leisurely periods they'd spent together in between fucking, when they seemed affectionate together, chatting, joking, cuddling, kissing. There hadn't been much sleep those nights, it seemed. Even when one or other of them had slept, it seemed the other had taken pictures of them, amazed that they were together when Hanna was married to someone else. The bond between them was clear, and clearly romantic. It was beyond mere sex. Seeing it was both thrilling and deeply worrying to me.

And yet, seeing them like that, and then taking in the fact that they had apparently decided not to continue an affair afterward, did make me feel that Hanna saw our marriage as important, and Jake was attempting to respect it, too. She loved me. She'd left everything she'd felt for Jake back at the chalet, precisely as agreed, even if she'd apparently smuggled some illicit photos of their union out of the chalet and back home.

Would she stop loving me if I allowed her to start seeing Jake again? If I allowed her to love him? I couldn't believe she would.

*

Hanna came, hard. I slipped back to bed, feeling somewhat feverish. I was so tempted to jump her when she eventually returned to bed herself,

the desire I felt for her seemed to have doubled. But I didn't give in to temptation.

Then, in the morning, everything seemed wonderful. Hanna was in a terrific mood, and despite being up in the middle of the night, my early night had allowed me to sleep sufficiently that I felt pretty good, too.

Hanna went off to work, apparently none the wiser that I was about to give Jake a call. None the wiser about me knowing she was chatting to my best friend each night. None the wiser that I'd seen her touching herself while she perused indecent images of her with another man.

Then I was nervously opening up my laptop, hugging a hot mug of coffee as though it might shield me from any embarrassment as I called Jake on FaceTime.

'Hey, Buddy, how's it going?' came his chirpy greeting as we were connected.

'Not bad, not bad,' I said. 'So what time is it for you right now?'

'Uh... it's just about ten at night. You okay to talk now? You're not heading off to work?'

'Flexible hours,' I smiled. 'I can pretty much get in any time before 10am.'

'So... I guess I should say sorry about what happened...' Jake said, breaking through the ice in our conversation. It was very Jake to get straight to the point like that, I thought. Made me realize that we really hadn't talked very much at all in the past few months. Ever since Europe, of course.

I said, 'Man, you really don't have anything to apologize for.'

'Things went too far,' he said. 'As I said in my email. Buddies don't do that to buddies...'

'Hey—' I attempted to interject.

But he continued, as though he'd rehearsed this speech a thousand times and wasn't going to be put off his stride. '...We should have laughed it off, right? I could have been happy with an eyeful of Hanna... you know... naked... and left it at that.'

'I told you to do it,' I pointed out to him. 'You offered to stop. You suggested we all call things to a halt.'

He hadn't been expecting that, hadn't been expecting me to defend his behavior. I could see in his eyes, even through FaceTime, that he had been waiting for me to rage at him for fucking my wife during a week in which we'd all been in a vulnerable state—but now he was rather surprised that I was so calm, and not just forgiving him, but fighting his corner.

‘I—’ he said, then stopped, his eyebrows dropping in mild confusion, unable to quite think what to say next.

‘Look,’ I sighed. I couldn’t see any way of getting him on board without telling him the truth. If he thought I was a disgusting pervert and never wanted to talk to me again... well, at least I wouldn’t be holding back the truth anymore. Perhaps if I told him everything, it would shock him out of falling for Hanna. ‘Look... I wanted you to sleep with Hanna. Or for Hayden to...’

‘I thought—’

‘Why do you think Hanna suggested she be the prize in a poker game in the first place?’ I asked him. ‘She wasn’t trying to hurt me.’

‘I don’t understand,’ he said after a moment’s pause.

I sighed again. ‘It’s hard to explain. When you’ve been married as long as we have... I don’t know... I guess usually the sex kind of... you know... gets kind of familiar. I won’t exactly say ‘stale’...’

‘Yeah, I heard that can happen.’

‘And sure, not every couple is the same... but you need to make a little more effort than you used to... to... you know... keep things interesting. Unpredictable.’

‘So you thought maybe if Hanna slept with one of us, it would make things interesting?’ Jake raised an eyebrow, still not fully understanding where I was coming from. Then he said, ‘I mean, I can see why it would be interesting for Hanna... she gets to sleep with someone new... but what would you get out of it?’

‘It’s weird,’ I conceded. ‘But just seeing how she looked when she came back from being with you... the glow about her... that came from doing something naughty like that... she was so hot...’

‘But that was after she did it,’ he pointed out. ‘How could you have known you’d feel that way after she’d slept with me? What was the attraction for you before she spent a night with me?’

‘It’s hard to say. It just seemed hot to me—you know, shaking things up. Taking the Hanna I knew, and was so familiar with, and then letting her do something so naughty... I guess I thought it would get her juices flowing, get her incredibly horny, and maybe when she came back to me things would be different, less routine...’

He nodded gently. ‘I guess I can almost understand that. I mean... never having been married, I don’t have the whole reference point...’

‘When you have someone like that,’ I said, trying another tack, ‘when she’s yours... you know... your wife. And you trust her, and you know she wouldn’t leave you... if she’s then with someone else, because

you allow it... it's weird, but it's kind of exciting, like walking on the edge of a cliff or something...'

Jake chuckled. 'I can't say I like the idea of walking on a cliff edge. So you really don't... you know... mind the thought that some other guy has... you know... fucked her?'

'No,' I said, 'not at all.'

'He's been... you know... inside her...'

I felt my manhood thickening at the thought, and silently accepted that maybe I was just wired differently than Jake or other men. Or maybe marriage affected my wiring.

'It's just sex,' I said, playing down a little how turned on it made me to think of her having 'just sex' with somebody else. I felt Jake would never truly understand why I enjoyed the thought of my wife being dirty with somebody else, just as I myself couldn't understand the desire for a guy to kiss and cuddle with another guy. 'I mean, she showers afterward, right?' I laughed, not worrying him with the fact that I'd reclaimed Hanna before she'd showered, and I'd loved it. The visible, tangible evidence of her sleeping with another man only made it hotter, because it confirmed everything.

'I guess,' he gave another half-smile as he nodded comprehension. Then, after a beat, he said quietly: 'You're a real pervert, you know that, Buddy?'

I looked at him with surprise, but then his smile turned full-on, and he was laughing—not at me, but with me. And he said, 'Most everybody's a pervert one way or another, you know that?'

'I suppose...' I said.

'You should see how much porn I have on my computer at home,' he laughed. 'You know... threesomes... anal... gangbangs...'

We laughed, and it seemed cleansing for the soul. He was accepting my perversion, such as it was, and making it clear he didn't think less of me.

'I guess this is like some really hot porn,' I said, 'except that the star of the show is someone you know and love. Someone you've always wanted, you've always thought hotter than anybody...'

Jake said, 'But you're not watching her, are you?'

I felt myself blush, but I wasn't about to admit to peeking when he'd fucked Hanna in the chalet living room that second night. Some things would stay with me until the grave.

'Maybe not,' I nodded.

'I guess you would if you could, right?'

I nodded again. 'But you know... even if I don't get to watch... knowing it's happening... seeing her afterward, knowing it's happened... it's still pretty incredible.'

Jake smiled. 'Makes me want to get married.'

Then he seemed to think of something, remember something he should have remembered. His expression changed, to a more serious look. He said, 'But you guys were arguing... after that second night...'

I sighed. 'I guess the one thing I didn't really account for in all this was her feelings.'

'Okay...'

On screen, Jake glanced away, as though he was feeling a little too awkward to quite look me in the eye.

I swallowed. Difficult things needed to be said. 'She had such an amazing time with you... and you guys are so good together... I was kind of freaked out that she'd fallen in love with you.'

'Hey, look—' he attempted to protest, but I could see in his eyes that he at the very least suspected such a thing might be true. And, from his sudden look of fear—which he quickly tried to conceal—I was fairly sure he was suddenly guilty about his feelings for Hanna.

'No, it's okay,' I insisted patiently. 'I'm not angry about it. Not now. It was kind of a shock at the time...'

'I'll bet it was,' he said, trying to play things down, but I could hear a strange lightness in his voice, see it in his eyes, that perhaps meant he was suddenly feeling quietly delighted at my confirmation that Hanna had felt something for him, possibly even love.

They'd never said it to each other, then, even if they'd both felt it.

'I just... I don't know... lately I've come to think maybe it wasn't so bad, you know? So what if she's fallen for you... if she still loves me... she still wants to be my wife...'

'Of course she does,' Jake insisted, as though he had inside information on the matter.

'So...' I was scratching a little for what to say next. I couldn't quite find the words. After a few moments, my mouth just seemed to take over, and I was talking without exactly thinking about what I was saying. I said, 'So I've been thinking... she's seemed so down ever since we got back from Europe... what would be the harm if she got to see you again, occasionally?'

Surprise and delight seemed to explode all over Jake's face for a brief moment, before he thought better of it and hid his emotions. He was trying to seem calm, it was quite obvious, as he took on board what I was

trying to say. As though he didn't want to seem too excited, too enthusiastic at the possibility of seeing Hanna again.

'It wouldn't affect how much she loves you,' he said, acting almost as though he was arguing my side, he was representing my wishes. It interested me that Jake hadn't denied the possibility that Hanna had fallen for him—or, as I saw it, that it might be mutual. He was cautious, but he wasn't denying anything the way she had.

And now that I was actually offering her to him, he wasn't torpedoing the idea.

I know: he could have been masking his true feelings, saying whatever he felt I needed to hear just so that he could have her again—but this was Jake. My friend. Jake, who hadn't told Hanna we were having this little chat about her. Jake, who had voluntarily stopped seeing Hanna as a lover because of how he felt it might affect my marriage.

'You know, the issue might not be about me,' I pointed out. 'The issue might be about whether you can... you know... deal with the fact that she would continue to be with me, even while she was dating you at the same time.'

'Right,' he said, nodding as though he knew that was the key issue, even though it seemed a little obvious he hadn't fully considered this. 'I suppose so.'

And therein lies the rub.

We paused. There was a pause. A real pause of a pause. Oh pause, how awkward art thou.

I felt suddenly immensely threatened by Jake. It's hard to describe, but it was as though I'd just opened a locked door that neither of us really knew was there, and the door opened straight out over a 300-foot cliff.

'Well, Buddy, I hate to break it to you, but you have to go to work,' Jake said after what seemed like forever.

'I do,' I said. 'We can... you know... talk about things later.'

'Hey, of course. I'm around... well, I guess I'm in Japan... but you know... around on FaceTime. As long as we get the time zone's right and book well in advance...' Jake gave me a wry grin, which if I wasn't such a paranoid person might have made me feel much better, and might have persuaded me there was nothing wrong here, he was still my best friend.

'Sure,' I said. 'And if you need... you know... someone to talk to... well, I'm always around. Even when I'm at work.'

'Thanks, Buddy.' He actually seemed grateful for my offer, genuinely. For a moment, I saw through his normal jovial exterior and

could tell just how isolated he really felt, how bad the loneliness could be in being in such a foreign place on your own even for just a few weeks.

‘And all this... well, it can wait until you get back, I’m sure,’ I said.

We signed off. I felt a sudden wave of panic.

In all this, the strangeness of my fantasy, the taboo of raising the issue with Hanna and Jake himself, the danger in allowing Hanna to go off and see other guys. The fear that she would—that she had—fallen in love with Jake. In all the times I’d reassured myself that it wasn’t a problem, that it was just sex, that I was fine with her fucking other guys, as long as she came right back to me and wanted me first and foremost—but I hadn’t really considered the fact that if Jake or other men knew she was still with her husband, would they object to the idea that she was fucking a man other than them?

It was one thing for Hanna to be in love with two guys. It was a completely different thing if her second guy didn’t like the idea of her being with more than one guy.

What if Jake really did want to take her away from me?

Chapter Twenty-One

Another night. Another wake-up in the early hours of the morning. I know, I know, I shouldn't have been sneaking around, spying on my wife. But something was going on. I'd talked with Jake about the possibility of her once again being able to see him, occasionally, once he returned from Japan.

So why hadn't she said anything when she got home from work that evening?

I would have expected jubilation from her, excitement that she was going to be able to resume the brief love affair that had made her so very happy at the time—and somewhat miserable after it had ended. I thought she might have been jumping up and down when she got home, and maybe even horny as fuck at the thought that her husband was going to allow her to sleep with Jake again, and probably as often as she really wanted.

But she'd been the same. Everything had been the same. Perfectly civil, perfectly fine, but nothing new, no improvement in her mood.

Had Jake even talked to her about what he and I had discussed? He had to have done. Surely, if you were that into a woman, and had the green light to see her again, you'd want to tell her as soon as possible. Had he not emailed her? Messaged her? Called her?

Maybe he was saving it until their regular nightly conversation on FaceTime. I could just about accept that. He wanted to make sure he made the right impression—he didn't want her to imagine he'd been trading with her husband for her, treating her like cattle at an auction, a piece of meat in a butcher's shop.

I would give him the benefit of the doubt, despite the pestering paranoia that kept making me imagine something was up, that the two of them were conspiring against me, plotting to end my marriage and leave me in the courts bearing full responsibility—since I was a husband trying to offer my wife to another man.

So, yes, I woke up early again in order to monitor my wife's nocturnal activities.

Actually, I was a little late to the party this time—I didn't wake up quite as planned. I felt that stab of blind panic in my chest as I pulled out of my slumber and realized that Hanna was already out of bed, already in the living room, already quietly chatting with Jake.

I tumbled out of bed, my head spinning as it often did if I woke suddenly, breaking my natural sleep cycle. My phone continued to vibrate after I left the bed—and to my horror, you could hear the buzzing sound of that vibration, even if it was supposed to be ‘silent’ mode. Such was the stillness of the night.

I managed to shut it down before too much damage was done, but I had to wait a moment to see if Hanna had heard it.

Her conversation with Jake went on regardless. Chatting, interspersed with some light giggles. I sighed with relief and padded quietly to the bedroom door. The door was open a crack, which was different than previous nights. Hanna had forgotten to fully close it. Was she getting careless after so many nights without any apparent risk of me waking?

I glanced at my watch. Was it slightly later than usual, too? Hadn’t she normally signed off with Jake by now, and started her post-conversation masturbation?

I was suspicious.

In my mind, the longer she talked with Jake each night, the stronger their romantic bond would be—and the stronger their romantic bond was, the longer they would want to talk to each other each night. I edged closer to the door, silently clutching the doorframe so that I could safely peer through the gap.

She was lying on the couch, this time in the far corner nearest the windows, facing back toward me and the bedroom door. I would have been instantly discovered, I think, except that the way she was sitting—lying, virtually—her view was entirely blocked by her laptop, which sat on her stomach.

‘No, you have got to be kidding,’ she said. ‘Seriously? Why do they do that?’

The tone of her voice set me at ease. It also, truth be told, took some of the excitement out of my sneaking about. They were chatting, as usual, like they were simply friends.

‘God. If it were me, I would run for the hills.’

I couldn’t hear what Jake was saying, of course, but it was obviously nothing significant.

Had he not told her about our little talk? About the fact that I was interested in him seeing her again? That I would risk their romantic bond if it meant relighting the fire at the heart of our marriage?

As I listened to half a conversation that was about as riveting as most reality TV shows, I had to conclude that Jake needed time to think

about everything. He had some pretty heavy issues to get through if he was to start seeing Hanna, start properly dating her. Maybe it was too much to get over, and he was already thinking it would be best to keep things platonic with her.

I watched as Hanna closed up her laptop, the call with Jake over. Then, instead of putting it down on the floor so she could indulge in a little personal pressure release, she picked the laptop up and pulled herself up to her feet.

I had to flee, as silently as I could, as it became clear she was simply coming straight back to bed.

I lay awake, pretending to sleep, while she got comfortable and slipped off to real sleep herself. For a while, I couldn't sleep myself, my thoughts whirling round and round my head. Hanna seemed to sleep perfectly peacefully, and then in the morning as we both readied ourselves for work, she didn't seem in any way downhearted. Perhaps she had accepted that things were not going to get sexual again with Jake, and had stopped fantasizing about it.

I was disappointed.

A few days passed. Almost a week.

I had stopped waking myself up to monitor her little chats with Jake. Oh, they were still talking regularly, but the remaining few times I caught it, it was purely platonic—and afterward, no masturbation from Hanna.

After a while, I left them to it. Oh, I still woke up occasionally, because my body had become accustomed to waking up at that time, but if I didn't go straight back to sleep then I would merely listen for the quiet sound of Hanna chatting with Jake, and then drift off back to sleep, entirely unthreatened. The tone of their conversation never reached beyond friendly banter.

Life went back to normal, at least on the surface. Under the surface, I felt a little embarrassed. That I'd admitted everything to Jake, that I'd bared all my secrets. He would think me a pervert, now. A freak. He could no longer be my friend, I was sure of it, and that made me feel awful. And how could I possibly socialize with our other friends if he was around?

*

Then, a few days before Jake was due to return from Japan, Hanna woke me up in the middle of the night.

I would tell you it was my body clock again—when I adjust sleep patterns, like I had done trying to monitor Hanna and Jake, it takes me a while to get back to normal—but this time I was jolted out of sleep, and when I got over the initial disorientation it was Hanna, out there in the living room, who I heard quite clearly.

In the still of the night, I could hear her heavy breathing, I could hear her sighing, I could hear her letting out quiet little moans. I could also hear an odd little buzzing sound, as though some guy was getting a military haircut in the next apartment.

It didn't take more than a moment or two for my kinky brain to work out what Hanna's heavy breathing meant, coupled with those silky sighs and soft moans. I was almost instantly hard. *My wife was touching herself again.*

I looked at the bedside alarm clock—3am. Had she been talking with Jake? It was on the early side for one of their conversations, or at least for the end of a conversation so she could masturbate afterward. Perhaps he'd gotten home early. For a while I just lay there in bed and listened to her, trying to figure out why, after so many days where Hanna had apparently given up touching herself after her chats with Jake, was she now back in full flow? And this time, apparently throwing caution to the wind in terms of how loud she was being while touching herself. I guessed that as far as Hanna was concerned, she'd tested the solidity of my sleeping over enough nights to be confident I wasn't going to wake up, however loud she was being.

So what had driven her back to touching herself like this? Had the two of them talked about the possibility of her seeing him again? Had Jake mentioned that I'd gotten in touch with him? Had it dawned on her that her sexual desires for him were not all for nothing?

Hope bloomed inside me along with pure, searing arousal—and, I'll admit, a sliver of fear, fed by my paranoia over where things could lead.

Of course, there were still other possibilities to explain what was going on. Hanna could have just had her period, and for the past however long, she simply hadn't been in the mood for any self-loving like this. Perhaps nothing unusual had happened with Jake, and tonight Hanna was simply returning to her 'normal' pattern of responding to her conversations with Jake.

I was about to hop out of bed, to take a little peek through the doorway for my own little kicks—and then I heard her voice.

‘Yeah... it feels really good...’

My blood ran cold. She was *talking* to somebody? She was *talking to Jake while she touched herself*?

I stifled a gasp.

Jesus. My heart was pounding. I had to be careful to keep my breathing quiet, even though it was suddenly heavy, my chest rising and falling as I drew in enough air to cope with the shock I was feeling.

‘Oh man... I wish... you could be here... right now...’

My heart seemed to stop for a few moments, seizing up with a painful jerk as the horror took hold of me. She wasn’t just flirting with Jake, she was having cybersex with him. Did people call it ‘cybersex’ anymore? God, it seemed like ages since I’d even heard the term. People in newspapers used to debate endlessly whether cybersex was killing society, whether it was ruining relationships—even whether it was actually cheating or not, if you weren’t doing it with your partner.

This definitely felt like cheating to me. Hanna knew I was turned on by the thought of her sleeping with another guy, and yet she was doing this in the middle of the night, while I was oblivious. She was keeping the mutual pleasure of such an encounter to herself, despite knowing I would have loved to watch her doing this with Jake—even simply knowing that it was happening would have been a turn-on for me.

Did she feel that, after our argument in Slovakia, I was against her continuing to see Jake? That I was never going to allow anything like this because of her feelings for him? Is that why she hadn’t alerted me to her resumption of sexual activities with Jake? In which case it really was cheating.

And Jake... after our conversation, he knew how I felt about the potential for him to date my wife. As far as he was concerned, I was not only supportive of him seeing her, but I had also made it clear I didn’t mind that she had feelings for him. So how come he hadn’t told me about their nightly conversations? How come he hadn’t said anything in the past few days about considering cybersex with her.

I hated the implications all this had on the trust I had in my wife. And yet... it was so hot, even just hearing her.

‘You’re so hard... God... I love your cock...’

I took a deep breath. Told myself that perhaps something spontaneous and unexpected had happened when Jake had finally told Hanna that he and I had spoken. Perhaps the sexual arousal between them had simply exploded out as soon as Jake had mentioned the fact that I was ready to let her see him again as a lover.

But as I climbed out of bed, and tiptoed over toward the doorway, the fact was that even if the two of them were actually cheating, it was a colossal turn-on for me. The thrill even overwhelmed my concerns about trust issues, at least for this moment.

The door was open. Not just a crack this time, it was open by a good couple of feet. She was really getting careless—or else she was really trusting that I would sleep through anything. The bathroom fan wasn't even on to cover her noise.

Hanna was lying on her back along the couch in a startling state of undress. Her head was propped up against the cushions at the arm of the couch, her nightshirt was pushed up so far that most of her breasts were also visible, and she didn't seem to be wearing any panties at all. Oh God, she'd shaved her pussy again, completely bare. *All for him.*

Her laptop lay between her parted legs, just inches away from her completely hairless pussy, which she was rubbing with a rounded white plastic object that suddenly explained that buzzing sound. A vibrator. I could see the white wire of her headphones trailing down from her ears, over her chest, her stomach, then down over one thigh to her computer.

'Oh... oh... Jake... yeah...'

She really was talking with Jake while she did this.

I was careful as I peeked around the door jamb to see her, although in the darkness of our apartment it was quite clear that her attention was on the bright laptop screen between her knees, when she wasn't laying back and pressing her head into the cushions, her eyes tight shut as the sensations from the vibrator surged through her.

It was certainly the hottest thing I'd seen since we'd returned from Europe. She was so wet, I could see her pussy glistening in the light from her screen. I could smell her arousal. It drove me wild—I couldn't help but squeeze my throbbing erection through my PJ pants.

As I watched her, it was quite clear she was totally absorbed by whatever was on her screen—Jake, I imagined, in some similar state of undress no doubt. It made me relax, a little more comfortable in peeking out to watch her.

At one point, she slowed the stroking with her vibrator, then leaned down to retrieve something from the floor beside her, saying to Jake: 'Hey, check this out...'

It was another toy—bigger than her vibrator.

'Yeah,' she said softly, 'I bought it online... it's the same size as you, honey...'

She held it up, briefly, in front of the laptop. A realistic-looking dildo, quite large. I felt the jealousy burn inside me. Was he really that large? From what I remembered, watching the two of them in the chalet living room, I had to concede that he probably was.

Now she lay back again and slipped the tip of the thing inside her open pussy, uttering little groans as she slid it in, then withdrew it, and slid it in again.

She kept the vibrator pressed against her clit while she penetrated herself with the huge fake cock, and now her moans became louder still—gasping cries. I could hear the wetness of her pussy as she fucked herself with that thing.

Then for a moment, she paused, looking down at her computer, smiling at something Jake had said.

‘No, it’s okay. Seriously. He’d sleep through a fire alarm.’

So she really was unconcerned about the possibility of being caught.

Now she switched off her vibrator and abandoned it to concentrate on her dildo, and the penetration she clearly imagined to be by Jake. She panted, she cried out, and I was starting to wonder how she couldn’t be concerned about waking the neighbors, far less her sleeping husband in the next room.

She was rocking the whole couch as she fucked herself, stretching her legs as far apart as possible, lifting her hips as she jammed that thing into her. Jake had to be getting a pretty amazing view.

Then, as her cries reached fever pitch, she pulled that big cock out of her pussy and just clamped her hand over her mound, her body shaking and convulsing as she cried out one more, ear-splitting time, her orgasm crashing through her.

Wow.

I ducked my head back into the bedroom, fearful that she would look up from her computer, to double-check I hadn’t woken up. The sudden silence that came from the living room seemed to confirm that she was listening for signs that I was no longer asleep.

Then, at last, there was a giggle. ‘I told you he wouldn’t wake up.’

Then, after a pause, ‘You could use a towel there, huh, buddy?’

It made me think that Jake had come too, and messily so.

I didn’t come, however. There was no way for me to do so and continue to avoid detection. I had to try to calm myself down, to keep myself from the brink. I returned to bed, though I kept listening.

She said, ‘Stay a little longer,’ she said quietly, pleading. ‘I really miss you.’

My heart burned with a mixture of jealousy and—oddly, given how terrified I was getting about this real infidelity—excitement.

Then she said, ‘I know... you’ll be home very soon. And I get to see you, right? As soon as you’re home.’

I felt a jolt of pain shoot through my chest. Jealousy, only a grade more than I’d felt before. The two of them were planning to meet up?

She said, ‘As far as I’m concerned, he’s said he doesn’t have a problem with me seeing other guys... so what’s the big deal?’

My heart was freezing up. I felt nausea—and, worse than that, I felt genuinely upset.

She would really do this? She would really cheat on me, and not tell me it was happening?

I couldn’t believe the woman I married could be so cruel. What had I ever done to her to warrant it?

Chapter Twenty-Two

I think I was in denial by the time Jake returned to the States. I started telling myself that if Hanna wanted Jake, and did not want me, then she would have left me already.

On successive nights, I woke up at the same time to catch Hanna chatting with Jake, Hanna taking her clothes off for Jake. Hanna exposing herself, touching herself, playing with toys for Jake. Hanna telling him how much she wanted him.

It turned me on, watching her preparing to cheat on me. As much as it sickened me, the loss of trust, the wickedness of it, the sexiness of her as she did it, even the risk that I would lose her to him in the long run seemed deliciously thrilling. It pleased me how happy she always seemed in the mornings following a long session with Jake overnight. It was like the best possible Hanna, after she'd spent time with him. She was happy and satisfied and optimistic.

I thought a lot about all the implications. About whether my marriage would survive this. My mental process was pulled this way and that—one moment, by my depressing paranoia, the next moment by my sexual fantasy. In the end, though, my kinky side always came out on top. I let them do it. I watched them do it—or at least, I watched her do it. And when I got up in the morning and showered, I pictured them in my head doing it while I tugged on my hard cock.

On the Thursday night/Friday morning, I was woken at midnight—three hours earlier than usual—by Hanna bringing herself to orgasm in front of her laptop. She really had no cares about waking me. Did she have some speech all prepared in case she did wake me? Did she even care anymore?

And yet her secrecy remained. As the two of them talked, after the sex stuff died down, it was clear that Jake was about to head to the airport. It took me a while to get my head around the time zones and flight times—was he really returning to the States already? Early Friday morning in Brooklyn would be Friday afternoon in Tokyo, and a flight on Friday evening from Tokyo would get into New York on Saturday evening.

'I'll come pick you up at the airport,' Hanna was saying, her affectionate offer making my jealousy well up so that it felt like my heart was being squeezed in a vice.

It shocked me, how casual she seemed to be about blowing me off so she could go pick up Jake at the airport and, no doubt, go back to his place to take their recent online chats into full physical passion. Did she not think I'd miss her that evening? Then I remembered that she was due to go out that night with some of her old work buddies. She'd been dropping hints to me about it for ages.

'Okay, but after you've showered, I can see you then?' she suggested, and I guessed that Jake had torpedoed her idea about picking him up from the airport.

'Nelson's... I know it. That would be perfect.'

My blood froze as I recognized the name of an English-style pub about five blocks away—a place Hanna and I often hung out with our college friends, including Jake and Hayden. It seemed so shameless that she'd go there for a date with Jake. Wasn't she worried about some of our friends being there?

'Okay, hot stuff. You have a good flight, right? I can't wait to see you...'

That day we did what we often did on a Saturday—we had a wander around a farmers' market, did a little light shopping. Hanna found some new perfume after testing a few on me. Kind of sexy, actually—not her usual kind of thing.

I didn't put two and two together until later that evening, when she started to get ready for her night out with the girls from her old job. She'd bought that perfume to impress Jake!

She left the bedroom door open as she was changing after her shower.

"You going to get pizza?" She asked me, as though she needed further confirmation that I would be staying home that evening.

'Yeah, probably.'

'Okay, remember we have that coupon.'

I guess she was feeling confident that I was just collapsed on the sofa watching TV, my back to the bedroom. But I could see her reflected on the TV screen—especially if I put a really dark movie on. She wasn't just getting ready for a night out with old work friends. She was trying on different sets of lingerie to see what worked best with her dress. I saw her choose the kind of high-cut thong panties that weren't comfortable and definitely weren't designed for a casual night out catching up with friends.

'You should watch the new Blade Runner movie. The sequel with Ryan Gosling? It's supposed to be good.'

‘I’ll take a look.’

Her dress was black and ridiculously short and sexy. She put a big coat on over the top to hide it.

Then she was out the door without so much as a goodbye kiss. Just a quick shout out to warn me not to wait up, that she’d probably be late. Was that where our relationship had gotten? And it was Saturday, when we were supposed to have sex under our usual pathetic schedule. Hanna was out on a date with my best friend, and she’d hardly done very much to conceal it.

For God’s sake, I could pick up my iPad and go to Facebook to check out her old work friends—they were the prolific social media types, so they were naturally posting away about what they were up to every moment of the day. Visiting the theater. Romantic dinner with hubby. Not going out for drinks with Hanna.

I sat and waited. Even called out for pizza. I wasn’t able to concentrate on a movie, though, even the long-awaited sequel to *Blade Runner*. My mind was all over the place—were they even going to stay long at Nelson’s? Why wouldn’t they just go straight back to his place and fuck like rabbits? They’d been desperate for it for so long. Were they going to rekindle feelings that would lead to her deciding to leave me? Or did her veil of secrecy mean she did want to maintain her marriage, even while she had an affair on the side?

It didn’t take me long to go a little nuts. I’d almost say it was similar to the kind of cabin fever we all experienced back in that chalet in Slovakia.

Nelson’s.

I knew where they were, so why didn’t I go down there and see if I could check on how they were getting on?

For a while, I couldn’t decide on what to do. Then my libido won out—even if nothing major happened, it would be hot to see her with him. It would probably fuel my masturbatory fantasies for months. And if I wasn’t going to get to sleep with Hanna that night anyway...

Once I’d made the decision, I raced down to the bar. Hardly dressed up much, either. Jeans, sweatshirt, jacket. I didn’t need to impress anybody, I needed to blend in to the background. I knew Nelson’s well enough to know how to do that. The place was two steps up from a dive bar, dark, full of pokey corners. It was an odd sort of place for Hanna to choose for a date with Jake—but I supposed that she imagined there might be a shady corner there where the two of them could hide away

while they caught up and prepared to make the next step toward actual adultery.

When I got there, it was getting dark. But I had to be instantly on my guard—as soon as I went in, I saw Hanna sitting at the bar, and only by sheer luck did I seem to avoid her spotting me as I entered. I edged toward the back of the place, my eyes on her constantly. She didn't seem to have noticed me, I was certain of it.

Although at that time in the evening the place was beginning to fill up, I found a table from which I could watch her. Hanna was perched on a barstool, and there was no sign of her bulky coat. She was showing a lot of leg in that short dress—quite breathtaking. She was easily the most glamorous person in the place. What if somebody mistook her for some kind of high-class escort?

There was no sign of Jake. What had happened to him? I saw Hanna glance at the clock on her mobile phone, which lay out there on the bar beside her and a large cosmopolitan.

A guy came up to her—a stranger. Thirtyish, tall, dark-haired, he wore a smart suit, which like Hanna herself, didn't quite fit in with the low-key surroundings. She looked up at him, smiled. Nodded. Said something. Smiled again. Ran her fingers through her hair. Jesus—was she flirting with him?

She was.

I hadn't really seen it before. Or at least, I hadn't seen it before discovering my little penchant for an adulterous wife. The butterflies fluttered inside my stomach, my heart rate started skipping daintily. My manhood thickened up somewhat in my pants.

Hanna smiled and covered her drink, as though to indicate that she didn't want or need another. The guy gave a little mock semi-bow as though to formally accede to her wishes, and then stepped away. Hanna glanced around again, and I have to say that for a moment I was probably a little too exposed, craning my head to get a good view of her.

Another guy came up to her—there wasn't much time for her to catch her breath. I saw her glance at her phone again, and smiled wryly at the thought that Jake was letting her down. Perhaps his flight was delayed, although it should have landed hours before.

This time the interested newcomer was dressed a little more casually, but seemed nevertheless as confident as the first man I'd seen trying to hit on my wife. Blonde, he looked like an off-duty military man or a cop or something like that. Wide shoulders, athletic bearing. He was

a little bolder than the last guy, pulling up a bar stool of his own next to Hanna, and ordering another drink for her before she could refuse it.

She was smiling, even if she wasn't interested in him. Talking to him easily enough.

Where was Jake?

I wondered what I would do if Jake failed to turn up, and Hanna needed someone to stick up for her if a guy like this military man went a little too far for her liking. I could tell her I'd gotten sick of being on my own in the apartment, that I needed a beer. Nelson's wasn't exactly the most local bar for our apartment, though. Not the place I'd go to if I was on my own and just needed a stiff drink.

But Hanna was okay. Seemed to be having fun with the guy trying to hit on her. She giggled, she flashed her eyes at him, she toyed with the ends of her hair.

It was such a turn-on. I was surprised. I sat there silently hoping that the guy would have success with her. That she would go with him to a table, or perhaps even to another bar where they could find more privacy. I swear, she was pushing out her chest as she spoke to him, and he needed no encouragement to stare down at her cleavage.

I watched Hanna excuse herself to go to the bathroom, and glanced at my watch—Jake was really late by now. Stupidly late. I waited. Blond guy at the bar gave a shifty look around, and then quietly finished his drink and left. Perhaps Hanna had sneaked away from him, and had also left the bar. What if she was on her way home, and when she got there she found I wasn't there?

'Hey! And what are *you* doing here?'

I nearly jumped out of my skin as Hanna's voice cut through the low rumble of conversations around me. And there she was, standing right there in front of my table. I was well and truly busted.

Chapter Twenty-Three

‘I... needed a drink,’ I stammered weakly.

‘You followed me.’

She had one hand on a hip, which was never a good sign. I felt a little light-headed. What now? Had my blundering around in the background further shredded my marriage into some irreconcilable mess?

‘I just... wondered... where you were going,’ I said, wincing a touch as though the roof was about to fall in.

‘You were spying on me,’ she said, folding her arms.

A few people around us were turning to watch. I guess the men might not have been as interested in the conversation as in the fact that Hanna looked so easy on the eye.

‘I...’ I was flustered. Okay, so I shouldn’t have been spying on her—but I couldn’t quite get why I was suddenly the bad guy in this. I felt annoyed. ‘You were coming here to meet Jake,’ I hissed, uncomfortable at airing our dirty laundry in public like this.

She sighed, and her tough body language seemed to soften a little. ‘I was never here to meet Jake,’ she said. It didn’t sound like a straight denial—it sounded as though she’d taken me for a ride, and now she was owning up to it.

‘You told him last night—’ I said.

She shook her head. ‘I made it sound as though I did,’ she revealed. Then: ‘I never talked to Jake last night. He was on the way to the airport, I never got the chance.’

‘I... but...’

I scratched my head. She’d fooled me. It had all been a tease because she’d discovered me watching her with Jake the night before, or the night before that, or whatever.

‘You’ve been spying on me every night since... God knows when,’ she said, sharply.

I laughed. ‘You were having secret... I don’t know... online sex sessions with another guy, behind my back.’

She shook her head again. ‘We just chatted occasionally,’ she said. She didn’t seem to be lying, didn’t seem to be embarrassed or anything. ‘He was lonely out there. Weeks in some foreign place where he couldn’t talk to anyone.’

‘You still hid it from me,’ I pointed out. ‘You could have just told me—oh, I talked to Jake. He’s lonely, he needs a little company from time to time.’

‘You would never have believed it was just innocent chatting.’

‘It wasn’t just innocent chatting,’ I said.

Hanna glanced around, and felt it wiser to sit at the table opposite me, to lower her profile.

‘It was always innocent chatting,’ she declared. ‘Ever since that argument you and I had back at the chalet, we decided not to pursue anymore... you know... romance stuff.’

‘But—’ I couldn’t quite get my head around what she was saying.

‘I was annoyed at you, when I saw you checking up on us,’ she explained. ‘The next time... I thought I’d tease you a bit. You know... making it look as though talking to him made me all... horny...’

I remembered how it had begun, with Hanna chatting with Jake before closing her laptop, abandoning it so that she could lie back and touch herself.

‘You knew I was watching?’

‘I knew you were watching.’

My swollen manhood twitched in my pants. She knew I was watching her, night after night, and she continued to give me a show. Kind of a hot thought.

‘Why didn’t you just say something?’ I asked her. ‘You could have just told me you knew I was watching you, that I didn’t need to be suspicious of you.’

She shrugged. ‘You didn’t say anything,’ she said. ‘I wanted to see how far I could go before you would react.’

‘You were doing it... in front of your laptop... the last week or so,’ I said, though I could see the pattern by now, I could almost tell how she would respond.

‘He wasn’t there,’ she said. ‘It was always after I ended the call with him.’

‘You faked it.’

She nodded, but then smiled. ‘You didn’t say anything. Even when I made it seem like I was meeting him for some... I don’t know... secret date.’

Now it was my turn to shrug. ‘No, I didn’t.’

‘You wanted me to see him. To meet him. To... what, cheat on you?’

‘I guess I did.’

She just stared at me for a moment. I didn't really know what to say to her—the enormity of what I was feeling seemed too much for the words I had to describe it. I was disappointed that she wasn't meeting Jake tonight, that she wasn't planning on some liaison with him. I wanted her to have an affair—even if I was troubled by having things done behind my back, deeply troubled.

I felt our marriage, our love, had become tired, and that I could not reinvigorate it, re-energize it, on my own.

'So... what are you thinking?' she said. 'You want me to sleep with him so you can... what, see other women? Divorce me? So you get to keep the apartment...'

A quick frown at that. 'You think I want a divorce?' I asked her.

'I don't know...'

'Do *you* want a divorce?'

So, divorce had come up.

I felt the ground begin to shake under me. I felt as though some gaping hole was opening up under our table, threatening to suck me and my whole established life into some great black void. Had we really gotten to the point where we were considering the possibility of divorce?

'Of course not,' she said quickly. The relief I felt was like how I imagine an addict might feel getting another shot of heroine. 'I love you.'

I hesitated, and really it was because I didn't know what to say. But she took it as some kind of doubt, and insisted, 'I do love you, Thad. I swear.'

'All this... deception...' I said, the words just tumbling out of my mouth—I was just letting my thoughts come out, unfiltered. I was too messed up, too tired to filter anything anymore.

She sighed. 'Look, I don't know what happened over in Europe. It was just... crazy. When you and Hayden went off hiking up the mountain... Jake and I figured we had to hit the reset button, you know? Like, we were going to ruin our friendship if we didn't. So everything... you know... sexual... stopped.'

'But you were talking with him at night... behind my back.'

She tilted her head. 'He was in Japan. He was so... lonely. And I guess I was the one he was comfortable turning to.'

'You didn't say anything about it.'

'He was embarrassed,' she said. 'It's not the kind of thing you tell your guy friends, is it? I'm lonely. I'm scared. I'm thousands of miles

away from anybody I know, and if my employers don't take me out to dinner I might not know how to even feed myself in this town.'

'I guess...' I began to understand Jake's POV, Hanna's POV.

'If he wasn't working, he was marooned at his hotel, and it was nice enough, but not exactly a five-star place. Not like the one in *Lost In Translation*.'

'Okay.'

'And you know what? He was feeling like we all did back in that chalet in Slovakia. You remember how bad that was? Only, this time, he didn't have any friends around him to help keep him sane.'

Okay, I could understand how that might feel. I could understand why he might want to talk to somebody like Hanna, rather than one of his male friends or even a member of his family—Jake's family were tough nuts, from what I remembered.

Okay, so now I felt like a bit of an idiot.

Hanna said, 'I saw you watching me talking with him, and I guess I was a little annoyed—because I knew you'd jump to the conclusion that I was cheating or something.'

'I'm sorry,' I said. 'I should have just asked what you were doing.'

'You should have trusted me.'

I nodded. Boy did I feel stupid. Where had I gone wrong? I had been certain her secret chatting with Jake had been more than just friendly. And the fact that she'd started masturbating after her calls had ended.

'And I shouldn't have... done what I did...' Hanna said now that it was the season for apologies. 'I guess I just wanted to... provoke you, or something. I was so annoyed at you for... you know, invading my privacy...'

'You kind of persuaded me that something sexual was going on between you and Jake.'

'I see that now. At the time... I don't know, I thought you'd step in, say something. I was going to yell at you for spying on me, and you know... you didn't say anything... you just watched...'

'Can you blame me?' I said, and actually raised a half-smile from her. 'The hottest woman I've ever met was lying on a couch... touching herself.'

Now, a full smile. My God, it was worth a million dollars.

'And then every night, you talked with Jake... and afterward, you did that again,' I pointed out.

She said quietly, 'I wanted to see if you'd do anything. If you said anything. If you got jealous at all. You never did.'

'No.'

'And you stopped... watching me. After a while. You just left me to talk with Jake... and you didn't even get up.'

'I needed my sleep after a while,' I said. 'I don't know how you managed.'

She shrugged. 'It made me feel good, you know... helping Jake to cope.'

I nodded. And was that why she'd always been in a good mood after her nocturnal conversations with Jake? Purely because she'd been doing a good deed?

I said, 'But then later... I woke up and you were talking with Jake *and* playing with... you know... sex toys.'

She nodded, blushed. 'Jake got a bit funny... I don't know... he was suddenly, like... he didn't want to talk so much. He said it might not be a good idea... did you talk with him? Did you tell him you knew I was talking with him at night?'

Suddenly, her tone sounded sharp, accusatory. So, she had figured out that I'd talked with Jake. But he hadn't told her what we'd talked about.

'I was annoyed again... I was kind of trying to wake you up, trying to ruffle your feathers. I thought you might get angry at me, and then I'd turn my laptop around and show you that, actually, I wasn't talking with Jake at all.'

'But I didn't.'

'No,' she gave me an eye-roll. 'You just watched.'

'I've told you... it was hot.'

'Hot. And you thought I was doing it with Jake?'

I laughed. 'Don't you remember anything about what we talked about in Slovakia?'

'I... I kind of... put all that behind me.'

'You don't remember how we got into that whole strip poker thing in the first place?' I asked her. Was it really that long ago?

'We were bored. I thought of some desperate way to kill the boredom for a while... and since you didn't seem to object...'

I shook my head. I couldn't believe she'd forgotten about my fantasy. In fact, I didn't believe she had: I think, honestly, she had mentally come to terms with the strangeness of a man wanting his wife to sleep with other men by wrongly attributing it all to my need to end

our serious boredom in that chalet. In her mind, I had simply come up with a strange reason for supporting the idea that Hanna should sleep with my friends in order to keep everybody from going crazy that week so far from home.

‘It wasn’t like that,’ I said. I had her full attention. I can’t remember the last time she hung on my every word like this, but here it was.

‘What are you talking about?’ she was genuinely confused.

I said, ‘Hayden said that you and I had an easy way out of our boredom, right? That we could just go away and fuck all week.’

‘Yeah, he did.’

‘And even if they could hear us, you decided we should go off and do exactly that.’

‘I was *bored*,’ she insisted.

I smiled. ‘I think you kind of liked the idea that they would hear us. Maybe it even turned you on.’ She blushed, so deep I could see it even in the low light levels of Nelson’s. ‘Only... I don’t know... when I start to feel any kind of pressure, I can’t really... perform. So you got all offended...’

‘I don’t get why it happens,’ she said. ‘It’s like when we were trying to get pregnant...’

‘When you’re a guy... half of it, maybe more than that, is mental,’ I tried to explain. ‘If you’re not thinking the right things when it’s happening... then it’s not happening...’

‘I thought you just see a naked girl and you get hard. Simple as that, isn’t it?’

I shook my head. ‘Seeing a naked girl helps... but when a guy is having sex, any nagging concerns... they can threaten everything. All it takes is to think... maybe I’m not going to be able to do this... and it becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy. If you’re not completely in the mood for sex, or if there’s pressure, like you start thinking *my wife will get offended because I can’t get her pregnant right now... or the guys will laugh because I’m not able to have sex with her while they can hear...*’

‘I never thought it was so complicated for guys,’ Hanna said.

I shrugged. ‘When you’re younger... you know, you don’t think negative thoughts while you’re having sex. It’s all new, and you’re so amazed it’s happening, there’s no stopping you. When you’re older, and you’ve been married a while...’

‘You’ve seen it all before,’ Hanna said flatly.

‘It still turns you on... it’s still amazing... but it’s harder work keeping those negative thoughts out.’

She nodded. I had to remind myself what I'd been trying to tell her.

'Anyway,' I said. 'So then you *did* get offended, of course...'

'I wasn't *offended*,' she tried to deny it, I guess to be kind.

'...And you suggested maybe you needed Jake or Hayden to come finish you off,' I reminded her.

'And God, you were suddenly so *hard*,' she laughed, so loudly that a few people around us turned their heads to check nothing weird was going on. Then, 'You were turned on by the thought of me being with the other guys,' she said, as though she really had forgotten. 'Then... when I was with Jake after the poker game... you *did* like it...'

'I did.'

'But then suddenly you were all annoyed at me...'

'I didn't want you to fall in love with him.'

'So there you go: we stopped.'

'But when I saw you talking with him at night, you made it look as though you hadn't stopped,' I said, feeling like a winner in this argument for the first time.

'I was *trying* to make you jealous,' she said, laughing, but serious.

'Every night? You must have figured out after a while that I wasn't going to get jealous...'

She blushed again. 'I kind of... liked it.'

'You *liked* it?'

'I liked it when you were watching me,' she admitted. 'And you were... well... clearly turned on...'

'I was.'

'I just didn't know how to... you know... get you to come fuck me... but at least I enjoyed it when you were watching me.'

'You could have told me,' I said.

'I didn't want to scare you away,' she said, and she had a point.

She was turned on. I could see it in her eyes. Her pupils weren't enlarged just because it was a little dark in here. The constant blush across her cheeks didn't come from the alcohol she'd had. And I was sitting here with a hard-on. I guessed we did still have it in us to get each other going, sexually.

After a long pause, in which I thought we might be able to get out of here, and go home to have a little wild, passionate sex and make everything better again, Hanna presented the remaining question she had about things between me, her and Jake.

'What did you say to Jake after you'd discovered me talking with him at night?'

I breathed deeply a few times. It occurred to me how she might take it, that I had told Jake he could have Hanna as well, if he wanted her. She could easily have taken it to be like trading her to him, selling her to him, making her an object that could be given by one man to another.

‘I said I hadn’t realized he was in Japan until I’d looked at his Facebook page,’ I said, truthfully enough, although not the whole truth.

‘That’s not the kind of thing that would have made him stop chatting with me,’ Hanna said, spotting the glitch in my story immediately.

I sighed, and took a deep breath, and had no other option but to try to say how it had been.

I said, ‘I told him I didn’t mind if he actually did want to start dating you.’

Hanna caught her breath. ‘You said... what?’

‘I told him if he wanted to, he could start seeing you again... I’m guessing that was probably a lot for him to get his head around... so maybe he couldn’t just talk to you as a friend anymore...’

Hanna glowered a little. I guess I had spoiled a nice thing the two of them had going. She said, ‘You told him he could date me... because you get turned on at the thought of me sleeping with other guys?’

‘Because you like him,’ I said. ‘Because you really like him. Because you probably do love him, even if you say otherwise. Even if you tell yourself you don’t.’

‘I...’ she was speechless at that.

I said, ‘You were miserable when we came home from Europe. You’ve been miserable most of the time since. And then when Jake went to Japan, and you started talking to him every night... you’ve been so much happier.’

‘So why would you want him to start dating me if you’re so certain that I’m in love with him?’ Hanna said, jabbing a pointed finger at me as though she suddenly suspected I had some secret plan to emotionally destroy her. ‘I thought back in Europe you made it clear enough that if I was in love with him, it wasn’t a good idea for me to go anywhere near him.’

‘I’ve changed my mind,’ I said, simply.

She gasped.

Part Two: **Dealer's Choice**

Chapter Twenty-Four

My wife was shaving her pussy. And she wasn't doing it for me.

'I told you, he likes it this way.'

'You never did it for me.'

'Would you like me to?' she offered.

'Kind of unnecessary now.'

I was teasing her. It was hot enough watching her perch on the side of the bathtub running a new razor over her mound—hotter still for me knowing she was doing it to impress another man. I guess it tweaked that jealous part of me that reacted to the thought of a rival suitor mating with my partner—it made my body prepare itself to reclaim her, to make sure my sperm was inside her and fertilizing her at the end of the day instead of his. And when my body prepared itself to mate with her, my unsophisticated brain mistook that as being simply ultra turned-on by watching her shave her pussy for another guy.

'So which way do you prefer, if you had a choice?' she asked while continuing to diligently scrape away at the white foam spread over her private parts.

'I like it... all ways,' I said.

'Well, that's hardly an answer.'

'I like it with... and without. If it's yours.'

She giggled at that. 'So if I just let it grow everywhere...'

'Oh no,' I winced. 'I like it tidy, at least. You know... so you can go to the beach in a really tiny swimsuit.'

'So that means you're going to take me to the beach soon?' she grinned.

'Uh-huh. If Jake's okay with it.'

She caught her breath again. She just couldn't quite get used to the idea that I was letting her date another guy. And that the other guy was Jake.

'He might not... want a say in the matter...' she said, warily.

Tonight, Hanna was going on a date with Jake. Only, despite what had happened to them before, this was very much a first date. Since I had given my wife the go-ahead, she had gotten in touch with him to find out what he was thinking, considering he had halted their nightly online chats after I'd talked to him and offered him the chance to see her again so long as she could share the details with me.

‘He will,’ I said, with confidence. Feeling that no man could turn down the beautiful brunette sitting before me right now. ‘After tonight... he’s going to want to be with you as much as humanly possible.’

She grinned. ‘He’ll have to share me with you, though, my love.’

The other thing that had happened since our evening in Nelson’s had opened the communication channels between us, was that Hanna and I had been fucking like rabbits every chance we could get. It wasn’t just the fact that she now knew I was okay about her seeing Jake, or even that she could fall in love with him and be clear that it wouldn’t affect our relationship. It was also the revelation that she had enjoyed me watching her touching herself so much, and that she rather liked the idea that by having sex with another man she would be turning me on.

It’s hard to lose track of this particular sexual fantasy sometimes. It’s so complex, there are so many different facets to it. Sometimes you miss some of the reasons why you’re into it, until they then jump out at you.

And Hanna seemed more and more into this fantasy. She was still wary about how Jake might feel about it, and whether there was potential for any of us to be emotionally hurt by whatever might happen—but after a little Internet research of her own, she was ready to accept that at the end of the day, I was just turned on by the concept of her sleeping with other men, and so she might as well just enjoy her side of it.

But we were unsure of how Jake thought about the fantasy, now that he’d had some time to think about it. He had agreed to go out on a date with Hanna, to see how it felt, but no one was fully sure how he would feel, what he would ultimately want. We were almost more nervous about whether he would want to date Hanna any further, than the fact that Hanna would, ideally, be going outside our marriage for sex tonight.

‘If he doesn’t want to date me, what would you want?’ Hanna said now, handing me her razor.

I was unsure what she wanted me to do with the razor, but she parted her legs a little more, and with her eyes managed to silently invite me to help with her shaving. Wow. It was a surprising thrill to shave her pussy ahead of her date.

‘What would I want... from you?’ I asked her.

‘In an ideal world. If you got to choose, without any need to please me.’

I didn’t hesitate long. ‘I guess I’d want you to try dating someone else,’ I said, and laid a finger very gently along the line between her pussy lips.

‘Pervert,’ she joked, and giggled at her own joke.

‘Don’t you think it would be fun?’ I asked her, stretching her sensitive flesh this way and that to get a close shave. ‘It would be like you were single again.’

‘I guess it would,’ she said, smiling as she took the razor from me to wash off the cream under the faucet before handing it back to me. ‘But you know I’m probably forgetting a lot of the annoying parts about dating.’

‘Annoying parts?’

‘You know... the guys that don’t show... the guys that turn out to be a-holes...’

‘True, there are a lot of a-holes out there.’

‘And I’m no longer exactly a college girl... what if single guys don’t want me anymore?’

I laughed at that. ‘You’re kidding, right? Any guy you choose would drop everything to be with someone as gorgeous as you.’

She smiled, and now leaned forward, her eyes signaling her intentions plainly. She kissed me, gently sweetly, and I found myself wondering if she would be doing this with Jake later that evening.

‘I feel bad that you don’t get to see someone else,’ Hanna said, then tempered her point: ‘Well... I mean... I don’t feel *bad*... I just feel...’

‘Guilty,’ I said, interpreting her expression. Hanna didn’t feel bad about me not seeing another woman, because Hanna didn’t want me seeing another woman. ‘But you don’t need to feel guilty.’

‘It’s kind of... unfair, isn’t it?’

I shook my head. ‘It’s not your sexual fantasy to have your partner sleep with someone else, it’s mine.’

Her hands sank beneath the waistband of my gym shorts and sought out the hardness beneath. ‘Mmm...’ she almost purred as her fingers curled around my stiff shaft. ‘It certainly is yours, isn’t it?’

We kissed again, and she slowly fondled and squeezed my hard cock.

‘What if Jake wants to date me, but doesn’t want me to... you know... open up to you about it all...’

I’d thought about this question, of course. It was one of the options, when you thought about how Jake might feel about sharing Hanna. Online, I’d read all kinds of accounts of guys, like me, who wanted to share their wives. Many of them would flat refuse to do it unless they were right there in the room, watching their wives fucking the other guy in the arrangement. I wasn’t quite like that.

To me, it was sexy as hell just to know that my wife was dating another guy.

‘I’d still want you to date him, if you both wanted to,’ I told her now.

She looked at me now as though she thought me crazy.

‘I’d still know you were dating him, wouldn’t I?’ I tried to explain. ‘I’d still know you were sleeping with him.’

‘Uh-huh,’ she agreed, and now ducked down to slip the end of my cock into her mouth.

‘And... you’d... still be... happier... if you were dating him...’ I added, in between moans as she repeatedly sank down on my shaft, one hand squeezing and pumping it at the base.

I’d thought about the prospect of Hanna respecting Jake’s privacy if she dated him, and even if she kept quiet, to me the hottest point of the whole process was getting her back just after she’d been with him. Reclaiming her. Taking her when I knew she’d just been with another man. I wasn’t in this purely for the voyeuristic value, as I know some men are. I was turned on by the fact that she was cheating, she was breaking the taboo, shattering the norms that society prescribed for marriage.

And the simple fact was that the prospect of being shared made Hanna get in touch with her sexuality in a major way. She’d been horny as hell ever since our little conversation in Nelson’s. I wanted that to continue regardless.

What I didn’t want to continue, for now, was Hanna sucking on my cock. I stopped her, urged her up, and as she looked puzzled at me, I explained: ‘I don’t want to come just before you go out—I wouldn’t enjoy your date as much.’

She sat up and laughed at that. ‘You’re not supposed to enjoy my date, are you? It doesn’t work like that.’

‘I’ll enjoy it,’ I said, ducking down between her thighs so that I could inspect her freshly shaven pussy with my tongue.

‘Oh God....’ she moaned as I appreciated the work of the razor around her pussy lips, and just how wet she was between them.

And I did enjoy her date, even if I was nervous about how well it would go with Jake. I enjoyed showering with her, I enjoyed watching her pick out saucy black lace underwear and a strapless black cocktail dress for her date. I enjoyed watching her brushing her long, dark hair, and apply makeup to her pretty face.

I enjoyed breathing in her scent after she'd applied her new-for-this-date perfume, I enjoyed seeing her nervous excitement at the prospect of going out on her first date for more than seven years.

And when she was finally gone, I enjoyed the straight sense of quiet stillness in the apartment, and the odd feeling that this was really happening. My wife was out on a date with another man. My wife was in the process of trying to seduce someone else. My wife, unless her date was completely insane, was going to have sex with someone who was not me later that night.

Chapter Twenty-Five

I was nervous. I didn't think I'd be quite as nervous as that, because Hanna had already slept with Jake before, of course. But I found I was incredibly nervous. I paced our apartment, and there wasn't much apartment in which to pace—this was Brooklyn we're talking about, money doesn't go so far in property there.

I tried watching TV. I tried listening to music. I even surfed the net to see what other guys do while their wives are out dating other people. I tried a couple of their ideas—cleaning the kitchen, getting the laundry done. It was all designed to take my mind off what was happening—and yet at no point could I stop thinking about what Hanna might be doing at that very moment, how their conversation was going, and whether or not Jake might be on board with the idea of sharing her.

I glanced at the clock every other moment, and it just didn't move on at all. Minutes took hours to pass, I swear. Was Hanna drinking? Was she getting high off the joy of finally being able to be with Jake to the fullest extent, so high that she was forgetting about me, forgetting about who was letting her be with Jake?

Was I being naive to think that after a whirlwind love affair with Jake, she would want to come back to me and our very conventional marriage?

I guess it wasn't so conventional.

I went out. I found a bar, I bought a very, very stiff drink.

Hayden came out to meet me. I told him everything, pretty much. Once upon a time, it had been just as easy to talk to Jake—but now, I wasn't certain about anything as far as Jake was concerned. He hadn't spoken to me since our online chat while he'd been in Japan.

'My guess is, you've gone too far, now, for things to ever go back the way they were,' Hayden told me after hearing my full side of things.

'I think you're right.'

'Jake can't ever just be your buddy anymore. Or Hanna's. There's been too much put out there.'

'So it's all or nothing, huh?' I asked him. Thinking: way to raise the stakes even further.

'If he doesn't want to see how it might be dating Hanna... I would say it might be a while until you all can get back to having friendly drinks every other Friday night,' he agreed.

I kept glancing at my phone to see if there was any news from whichever bar or restaurant Hanna and Jake were at.

‘I guess it’s too late to call anything off... but are you really sure this is all the right move for you guys?’ Hayden stressed his question. Then he said, ‘You know... I probably shouldn’t tell you this... but before you went and asked Hanna out in our last year of college... well, let’s just say Jake had his eye on her.’

Well, that was news. I kind of felt bad, now, if I’d gone and swiped a girl from my best friend—and had ended up marrying her.

‘He never said anything to me,’ I complained.

‘Of course not. He was talking about asking her out for ages... really got hung up on it. You remember he was dating that blonde...’

‘Sheila Dumfries.’

‘Sheila. And they’d been together since sophomore year. She had the ring, the dress, the damn kids’ names all picked out already. But Hanna showed Jake that he couldn’t be with Sheila the rest of his life and be happy. Only... you know... he had to find a way to let Sheila down gently... and then you went and asked Hanna out instead.’

‘Jesus,’ I groaned.

‘You know he’s been comparing his dates to her ever since?’

God. Every other sentence Hayden was saying to me was like a punch in the chest. Poor Jake. I felt like I’d taken his life. Maybe Hanna should have been his all along. Maybe if the two of them had been together, they’d have moved out to the suburbs already, and had a batch of kids like most of our other friends.

I thought about the women Jake had dated since college. I tried to remember their faces. I couldn’t recall a single one since Sheila who wasn’t a brunette in the same mold as my wife.

‘Most of his dates have... kinda looked like Hanna, huh?’ I said.

Hayden smiled, but with a touch of pity. ‘It’s been like watching every Star Wars movie ever made: the romantic interest is always a pretty, sparky brunette.’

I sighed. ‘Did... Hanna ever know?’

He shook his head. ‘He’s pretty much kept it to himself the whole time—I mean, I knew, obviously. He talked to me enough times about wanting to ask her out, about whether she was worth the risk of ending what he had with Sheila... but ever since you asked her out... and, you know, things went well for you guys... it hasn’t gone further than that.’

‘So when Hanna suggested that game of strip poker...’ I felt my heart being squeezed mercilessly by the realization that all this must have

shredded Jake's emotional wellbeing.

'I thought at the time it probably wasn't a great idea... but you know... I thought it would all be a little fun... never expected Hanna to actually go through with it all when Jake won the game...'

Another sigh from yours truly. 'So right now... we might just be reopening old wounds for Jake?'

'Something like that,' Hayden nodded.

I took a big swig of drink. I was onto neat Bourbon by that point, it burned the back of my throat as it went down.

'Well... I guess the ball's in his court right now,' I said. 'If he thinks he can handle being in a relationship with her... when she's still with me... then maybe it'll all be okay.'

'And if not... you guys might need to give him space for a while,' Hayden advised.

I took a deep breath. I'd been stupid not to consider Jake's point of view in any significant way. I'd been hung up on the whole fact that Hanna had feelings for him, I'd overlooked how serious it was if Jake had a major emotional stake in Hanna.

'You just need to see things from his perspective, I think,' Hayden said. 'You can't feel bad if he turns you guys down. Or if, after he does, he needs some distance for a while.'

I nodded. 'I can see he would. God, I feel like an idiot.'

Hayden smiled, 'Maybe when you realized you... you know... liked the idea of Hanna going with other guys... you shouldn't have chosen a good friend for her to go with, right?'

I shrugged. 'I'm not sure it was completely my choice to begin with.'

'Well, the cards did have some say in it, didn't they?' Hayden pointed out.

I was a little less nervous as I parted ways with Hayden and headed home again. Probably something to do with all the alcohol inside me, but I think I also felt prepared for eventualities other than the perfect one. In the taxi on the way back to our apartment, I tried to imagine how it might have been if Jake had asked Hanna out first. How I'd feel having a secret crush on her while my best friend got to date her, and move in with her, and get engaged, married.

I hadn't been in love with her when I'd asked her out originally. I'd just thought she was attractive, she was fun, she seemed to like me and my friends. I'm not sure when I did ask her out whether I was even properly asking her out. There had been a night when I felt like going out

clubbing, and none of my friends were in the mood to do anything other than play video games. I'd asked Hanna if she wanted to go with me, and she had readily agreed. We'd had an amazing time, just the two of us, drinking and partying, and ultimately we'd ended up in bed.

I guess that could have been Jake who took her out like that.

How would I feel, loving her as I did, and not being able to be with her?

Poor Jake.

As I got to my apartment, a text message came through from Hanna. My heart froze inside my chest.

(Hanna): You still awake, sweetie?

(Thad): Yeah. Just went out for a quick drink with Hayden. So you guys having a good time?

Typing those words into my phone, my cock thickened between my legs, and my pants and underwear started to feel restrictive. It was hard to believe I was really texting my wife to see if she was enjoying her date with my best friend. But here we were.

(Hanna): We've had such a wonderful time.

My heart swelled, and started pounding heavily. I was glad the date had done well—but what now? Was she going back to his place? Was she going to sleep with him? Had she changed her mind, at all, about me and our marriage in the light of what she felt for Jake?

(Hanna): Jake said he'd escort me home... I just didn't want things to be awkward between you guys... if I invited him in for a little while.

I stared at her message, trying to read between the lines, trying to interpret every little nuance in the limited number of words she'd sent to me. 'Awkward'. What did that mean was going on between Hanna and Jake if she thought there was a danger that things between Jake and I might be 'awkward'?

Actually, I took it to be a hopeful message. Was Jake intending to pursue, her, then? To date her, to sleep with her, and therefore worried that I wouldn't actually be entirely comfortable with another guy seeing my wife romantically?

I guess it was a difficult concept to cope with, understanding someone like me, who wanted to be married to a woman who is free to see other people.

I texted her back:

(Thad): I don't see why anything should be awkward. I'm totally okay if Jake wants to bring you home, or if you want to invite him in. Or even if you want him to stay the night.

My heart was jumping up and down by now, it seemed. My erection was just about straining to burst out of my pants. I felt a little light-headed—if I wasn't already collapsed on the couch, I might have needed a good sit down. Was this really happening? Or was I pre-empting things.

I added another text message before she had time to reply:

(Thad): Would you rather I get out of here? I could go check into a motel or something.

A few moments later, she replied:

(Hanna): No, it's okay. You shouldn't have to leave home on our account.

My hard cock throbbed at that—and more than that, I was left breathless by what she'd texted. It was her use of the word 'our', as in 'our account'. In my eyes it made it really seem like Jake and Hanna were a couple. Jesus.

So she was bringing Jake over. She wanted me to say here, and to be here when she invited Jake up. What was her plan? From the way she'd said Jake had wanted to 'escort her home', it seemed to me that perhaps they intended to take things slowly. If this was a first date, regardless of what had happened in Slovakia, then maybe there would be no sex on the first date.

And yet why would the two of them pursue some slow courtship like a couple of people uncertain how they felt each other? It was clear as day that Hanna wanted Jake, and Jake certainly wanted Hanna.

I waited on tenterhooks for the happy couple to return.

Chapter Twenty-Six

And here they were, coming through the door looking like a glamorous couple walking the red carpet to some lavish awards ceremony or something.

And goodness, they did look like a couple. It was breathtaking, it was frightening, it was seriously, seriously exciting.

‘Hey, sweetie!’

‘Hey, how’s it going?’

‘Hey, buddy. Good, good. You okay?’

It almost felt as though I was throwing a small house party, and I’d invited Jake and his girlfriend along. I was dressed casually, in jeans and a fairly informal blue shirt, camped out on the couch as though I’d been in all evening. Jake was smart in a dark blue suit and crisp white shirt, Hanna in her tiny little black cocktail dress. And his arm was around her waist as they came through the door—my heart leapt at the sight.

‘You have a good time?’

‘Oh, really nice. You know Bannerman’s? It’s, like, four blocks down from—’

‘I know it, we took some clients there once. Really nice.’

‘The food was just great...’

Small talk, like I was just part of the party crowd, and Jake and Hanna were the couple doing the tour, making sure they mingled enough to do the party justice.

‘Hey, can I get you guys a drink?’ I even said. Playing host, even if the girl on Jake’s arm lived here.

‘Uh... yeah...’ Jake said, nodding. I could see that he was a little nervous himself. I had to remember Hayden’s advice, to try to see things from his perspective. He wasn’t sure how I would take it if he wanted to actually be with Hanna, if he wanted to actually take us up on our offer of dating my wife. As far as he was concerned, what if I changed my mind at any point?

I smiled warmly as I handed Jake a tumbler full of his favorite tippie, Johnnie Walker. As I handed it to him, I silently admonished myself for not even asking him what he wanted to drink. Was he driving? Would he have preferred something a little lighter like beer, wine?

But he accepted the drink gladly enough, as did Hanna her glass of chilled Sauvignon Blanc.

‘You know, I could easily just slip away...’ I said, as we all relocated to the sofas, and there was a brief moment where Hanna didn’t quite know where to sit... with her husband, or with her date. As I made my offer, Hanna turned to look at me, and I flicked my eyes toward the front door to show her that I had a small overnight bag already packed.

My wife chose to sit with her date. I felt like fireworks were going off inside my chest.

‘There’s a Best Western not too far from here...’ I said, taking a slurp of my water-disguised-as-vodka, which I was drinking on the rocks, as it were, so they might imagine me to be relaxed and nicely inebriated, even though by this point I didn’t want anymore alcohol. I was intoxicated enough by the way Hanna was locked to Jake’s side.

‘You don’t have to go anywhere,’ Hanna told me. She glanced at Jake, as though to check she was on message. I saw a tiny little nod he gave her in reply.

God, they really were acting like a couple. Suddenly I felt a touch fearful. Were they about to announce something? *I’m sorry, honey, but we’ve decided to get married. I’m going to move out and live with Jake instead.*

‘You really would just move on out of here?’ Jake said, breaking the ice with a somewhat perplexed smile.

I shrugged. ‘If you guys needed your space... your... privacy...’

Jake’s smile turned into one of amusement. ‘It wasn’t so private at the chalet, huh?’ he said. I flushed slightly thinking he was calling me out for eavesdropping on them—or worse, for outright spying on them while they were making love in the living room of that anything but soundproof chalet.

But he said, ‘At least, as far as I was concerned... when you and Hanna were together... we could hear pretty much everything. I guess it was the same for you when she was with me...’

‘Those walls were pretty thin,’ I nodded, and gave a nervous smile.

What was he saying? That after what had happened back at the chalet, I might as well stay here in our apartment while he slept with my wife? My heart skipped a beat or two. Or... was he somehow leading me to his decision that he was not going to pursue Hanna anymore, whether or not I vacated this apartment to give them privacy?

I stole a peek at Hanna, and it surprised me how she was looking at Jake. She seemed nervous, waiting, in suspense. It struck me that she did not know what Jake had decided, whether or not there would be a second date, or indeed how this first date would end.

Jake turned his head and saw for himself just how anxious his date seemed.

I guessed that Jake was keeping his cards close to his chest as far as what he was thinking about all this. He was maintaining, throughout, a perfect poker face to hide his emotions. As we had seen in Europe, Jake was pretty good when it came to poker. But now he seemed to grasp just how Hanna felt not knowing whether he wanted her, or whether he did not.

He smiled.

‘Okay,’ he said, taking another swig of his Scotch. ‘Look, if we’re going to do this...’

I caught my breath—and then Hanna’s eye. I could see how thrilled she was, just from the positive tone of Jake’s voice, just from the hint that he really might go for it. I guess I looked just the same—we smiled at each other as we recognized that we were both reacting the same way.

Jake continued: ‘...there’s a few issues I figure we need to get... you know... out there.’

I took a swig of my water-on-the-rocks. Well, it didn’t help with my resolve so much, but at least gave me a moment to get my shit together and regain some kind of poise.

Then I said, ‘What’s on your mind?’

Jake sat back, so that he could see both Hanna and I without too much twisting and turning. He said, ‘I’ve been doing a lot of thinking about all this. Ever since... well, mainly ever since you told me your whole deal with Hanna, Thad.’

‘Uh-huh,’ I said.

‘Before that... well, Hanna and I had decided it would be better for all concerned if she and I just tried to be friends, instead of anything more.’

I nodded, and the look I received from Hanna was the kind that said, silently, that she was now entirely proven right in what she’d said to me about those nightly chats with Jake, while he was in Japan, being platonic in nature.

‘I did a lot of thinking... and a little research,’ Jake added.

‘Okay...’ I said, uncertain what was coming next. ‘Research is good.’

‘The thing is,’ he continued, ‘This is not what you’d call... a normal polyamorous situation.’

I nodded. ‘No, I guess that’s not the word I’d use to describe it.’

He said, 'You read stories in the press about polyamorous people and... well... it's always this woman needs more than just her husband. Or that guy fell for two girls at the same time...'

I'd read some of the same articles. 'Usually it's the woman who needs more than one guy, right?' I smiled. 'Because in the media, that's your story to shock the readers. Guys are expected to need more than one woman.'

'You're right,' he said, taking another swig of Scotch. 'But here's what you never see: the guy wants his wife to see other people. The guy... gets off... on his wife seeing other people.'

'A little too shocking for our poor media,' Hanna laughed. She sat back a little in the sofa.

'I never thought I'd be a pioneer,' Jake said, but as the mood seemed to be lightening, his face reset in serious mode. 'But here's the thing... I think it would be probably easier for me to understand if it was just Hanna... you know... dating me while she's married to you... keeping things separate...'

'Compartmentalized,' I nodded.

Now Hanna was looking at me with a kind of pleading expression. Could it work like that? Keeping everything she had with Jake separate, private from me? That wasn't the terms of my particular fantasy, I had to admit, but I'd already considered the possibility.

Before I could say anything, Jake went on: 'So here we are... and you want Hanna to date other guys... and you're buzzed by that whole thing. So you kind of want to know everything that goes on between her and me.'

'If you're not comfortable...' I started.

But he cut me off. 'I get the sense that this isn't going to work if you try to be like those guys in the press articles who accept that their partners also have boyfriends, and just quietly ignore what goes on when they're with them.'

'Maybe,' I agreed. I could imagine it if Hanna came back from a date with Jake, I could picture myself trying to subtly find ways around her relationship firewall, to garner little snippets of detail about how it might be for her to really fuck another guy while she was married to me.

'Okay,' he nodded, 'so I've got to get used to the idea that what I do with Hanna... it's between the three of us, not the two of us.'

I saw his arm slip around Hanna's shoulders as they sat there on the couch. It was subtle, like a teenager trying to make a cautious next step on a first date in a movie theater. But it seriously fired me up.

‘There’s no judgment here,’ I said, figuring where he was going with this. ‘You don’t have to... you know... win points or anything. Just... enjoy being with her...’

‘And you’ll just... enjoy that I’m with her?’ he nodded.

‘We’re friends,’ I said. ‘Never competitors.’

‘Never competitors.’

‘I’m not here to win her from you, and you’re not here to... well... try to prove yourself by judging me.’

‘No, of course not. Never competitors.’

I know, some guys online are into the whole competitive thing. Their wives come back from the boyfriends, they feel like they have something to prove, they have to be better than the boyfriend. Plenty are even the reverse: they want their wife to humiliate them with tales of how amazing their other man was, how big his cock was compared to her husband’s, how pathetic her husband is to give up his sole right to her sex.

‘Okay,’ he said, and now pulled Hanna into an embrace on the couch— and a full kiss.

I heard Hanna catch her breath as he went in for her, but then she was quietly moaning.

I just about stifled a gasp, not really wanting them to think I was shocked by all this. I was a little taken aback. The feelings it provoked in me were so strong, even after everything that had happened over in Europe. I was happy for her, I was turned on by their contact; and to dampen down the fear factor, I clung to that brand new pledge of ours: *never competitors*.

There was fire in both their eyes as they came up for air. Hanna looked over at me to check I was still okay, and I gave her this stupid Labrador smile.

‘Was that weird?’ Jake asked.

‘Not at all,’ I said, trying to be calm.

Hanna said, ‘It’s just the three of us in here, right? We all accept each other, and we all respect each other.’

‘And it’s nobody else’s business but our own,’ I added.

Jake nodded. ‘What happens among us stays among us. That worked out okay for Slovakia.’

We’ll always have Slovakia, I thought to myself.

Hanna leaned into Jake for another kiss, and I was just starting to wonder if the two of them actually wanted me to stick around while they began the whole seduction thing, or if it would be easier for me to depart,

even if we had an intention to be open about what happened among us between us—by which I meant that Hanna would be free to tell me about her time with Jake.

But Jake stopped her just prior to that kiss.

Wait, what?

Holding up an apologetic digit finger as though to press a ‘pause’ button on that kiss, he said, ‘There’s another thing.’ We were all eyes. He said to me, ‘I think we know for a fact that you’re A-okay with me doing... whatever... with your beautiful wife.’

‘Of course,’ I said, wondering where he was going with this. Was he going to suddenly turn into Christian freaking Grey?

Jake said, ‘And I... I want to be with her... I want to spend time with her, I want to go out with her. But you know... I kind of have to figure out if I can deal with... you know... you being with her, too.’

I remembered Hayden’s advice from earlier in the evening. That I had to remember to see things from Jake’s perspective sometimes. And right here, he was reminding us that while I might be turned on by another guy sleeping with my woman, he wasn’t certain how he would feel about such a thing. And I did intend to sleep with his woman if he slept with mine.

‘You’re right,’ I nodded.

Hanna said, ‘It’s only sex, right?’

She wasn’t entirely thinking from his perspective. I looked into Jake’s eyes and I could just about see what he was thinking. Could he deal with me putting my hands all over her, kissing her, penetrating her? Even after a full shower, maybe he’d be squeamish about it. Plenty of men would run for the hills if they knew another guy had even laid a finger on their woman. Plenty of men around the world needed wives to be virgins on their wedding days, and there were horror stories in the press from time to time about that whole deal being taken to the extreme.

‘It’s only sex,’ Jake seemed to mull the words, letting them tumble over his tongue like a connoisseur letting a fine wine reach all of his taste buds.

‘But how—?’ came my question.

Jake told Hanna, ‘Go sit with him.’ His voice was quiet, his manner entirely tempered and without hint of force.

Hanna stood, and tottered over to me in her high heels before sitting down next to me. I was greeted with a waft of her sweet perfume—the

scent she'd picked out specifically to impress Jake—and the warmth of her thigh pressed against mine.

'Kiss him,' Jake said lightly. A suggestion, rather than an order.

I was more than a little surprised, as was Hanna, it was clear enough to see. But we were going to do as he wanted. We sat up, nervously leaned into each other. Hanna's breathing was shallow, anxious. We gazed into each other's eyes, our expressions more of concern than real desire. We kissed, and it felt nice, her sweet lips against mine. A little awkward, though. Nervy like our first date. We didn't know what Jake wanted.

We didn't kiss for too long, but after a little early tension between us, Hanna opened her eyes, and we both cracked up into light guffaws at how strange this was—for us to be nervous about kissing each other after several years of marriage. It seemed to break the ice to some degree. We melted into our kiss, sucking on each other's lips, giving it a little tongue here and there. I breathed her in and just delighted in the sense that perhaps, soon, these sweet lips of hers would be pressed against Jake instead of me, and I think Hanna delighted in the possibility that she was driving Jake crazy by doing this with me.

We were both somehow reminded at the intimacy, the sweet pleasure that could be had from a simple kiss.

Then Jake was telling us, 'Okay, okay. So that went well...'

We came up for air, and Jake was standing over us, nodding sagely like some film critic appreciating a lost Orson Welles movie.

He leaned down and tilted Hanna's face to his with a finger under her chin. He kissed her, and as far as I was concerned the sweetness of our kiss was thrown in the shade by the pure eroticism of their kiss.

Wow. He had Hanna moaning as though she was tasting the finest dessert in Christendom.

'I think I can do this,' Jake said, a note of surprise in his voice as he moved to Hanna's other side, and knelt down on the couch behind her, slipping his head over her shoulder to kiss her cheek as his hands cupped her breasts through her dress.

Hanna moaned again and smiled blissfully as he fondled her breasts and his kisses drifted down to her neck.

'You think you can handle both of us?' he whispered into her ear, and she grinned.

'Of course,' she said, her eyes telling me in no uncertain terms just how wild she thought this was.

Jake grinned at me, and held her breasts as though offering me a sample. I stroked her leg feeling a little giddy, not quite believing any of this myself, and as Jake continued placing little kisses on her neck, I leaned in to kiss Hanna's exposed flesh, just above the neckline of her dress.

She moaned as I pulled her dress down, and then slipped her breasts free of the delicate black lace bra, before sucking her stiff nipples into my mouth one by one. I kissed her mouth, and then Jake was peeling down her dress, and unfastening her bra, fondling her bare breasts. She turned her head to kiss him, and my mouth moved to her nipples again. It all seemed perfectly amicable, perfectly relaxed, with no hint of rivalry or jealousy between Jake and myself, no fears of embarrassment or judgement.

Jake whispered something in her ear—a direction, it seemed to me, and then Hanna's kissing turned more forceful, and she was urging me to lay back against the couch so that she had to kneel up and lie over me in order to continue kissing me. Her hands were all over the bulge in my crotch, and soon enough she broke off from our kiss in order to unfasten my pants and free up my throbbing erection.

I think I was expecting it to be a little more difficult than this, performing with another guy present. But it all seemed easy, I was so turned on by watching my topless wife duck down to take my hard cock in her hands, and slip the tip into her mouth, while another man stroked her behind, and worked to peel her dress down to expose her little black lace panties.

Hanna was moaning even more than I was as she stretched her lips around my shaft and bobbed down on it in full view of her date. Jake had her dress pulled down mid-thigh and was calmly stroking her through her underwear while watching her sucking on me.

What was he thinking? He'd wanted her for so very long, it seemed, and now that he had her, he was sharing her with me.

Was he feeling the same as I was? The way he was acting, I didn't get the sense that he was seeing this the same way I was. The way he looked at me, the way he directed Hanna to be with me, it seemed as though he almost saw me as a simple extension of himself. I was no threat to him—I was her husband, I wasn't the shiny new thing that would potentially tempt her away from her normal existence, he was. Although he'd wanted her so badly for so long, it seemed that he was fully reconciled with me being her other half, and was now just happy to be with her as well.

And yet I could not feel quite so laid back. As he eventually extricated himself from the mesmerizing view of Hanna sinking down again and again on my shaft, he was on his feet and approaching her to offer his own hardness. I watched her pull herself up from my lap, and flick open his fly before helping him to shove his pants down, his own hard-on bouncing free. She kissed him just below the navel and took his hardness in one hand. And then she was sucking on him. I didn't feel laid back at all. I felt a surge of adrenaline as I watched her, close up, taking Jake's sizable beast in her mouth.

In my eyes, he wasn't just an extension of myself. He was a guy I wasn't used to seeing with my wife like this. It was both strange and fascinating to watch, beguiling and a little unnerving. She held onto my cock with tight fingers squeezing hard around my girth, but her moans of excitement were for her new toy.

The fear was unconscious, however, and after a moment or two I could get a handle on it, tame it, allowing my arousal to dominate my feelings. Jake wasn't a real threat, I accepted that consciously. It was just my subconscious that reacted to his presence, the scent of his cologne, the low moans as he gently held my Hanna's head and slid his cock in her mouth time and again.

'Come on,' he said now, urging Hanna up, leading us to the bedroom.

By the bed we helped each other remove any remaining clothes, Hanna claiming kisses from Jake and I along the way.

Then Jake hung back as Hanna and I lay on the bed, Hanna guiding me onto my back while she straddled my hips. He was still getting accustomed to us being together physically, although we were all fairly sure by now that none of it would prove a problem. Hanna was facing away from me, but as Jake stood at the foot of the bed, I could tell by his facial expressions that she was teasing him a little while getting into position to take my cock inside her.

She did a little wiggle as she slid down on my shaft, raising a smile from Jake even if he was getting his head around the sight of my manhood sinking into her pussy right in front of him. She loved to show off for him. And for me, of course. With my legs hanging off the end of the bed, Hanna was able to lean forward and take Jake's cock in her mouth again. She giggled with her mouth full at just how scandalous it was to have two men inside her at the same time, but her giggles soon melted into long, sensual moans.

After a while it was time for Jake to take his turn. Hanna turned around and, on all fours, presented her rear to him. I leaned forward to kiss her mouth as he planted his hands on her hips and eased his hardness into her. I felt her moan in her mouth as he entered her, and it was such a thrill.

I'd seen it before, of course, but never so close up. And here, Hanna was looking into my eyes as another man fucked her from behind.

Wow. Every cell in my body seemed to be jangling, buzzing, roaring.

It was just so damn sexy. My Hanna, my beloved, my wife, naked and on her hands and knees, rocking back and forth as another man shoved his huge, hard cock into her most personal place, right there in front of me. Looking at me with those big, green eyes in both gratitude and astonishment as he thrust into her again and again. I was jealous, for sure, but it only made me want her more, and as I embraced that desire and kissed her deeply, that jealousy only seemed to become part of the ferocious thrill of the occasion.

I knelt up on the bed to feed her my cock once again, although such was the experience of Jake stretching his big cock into her pussy, she wasn't able to dedicate much attention toward sucking on mine. She held onto the base of my shaft for dear life, and left me to basically fuck her mouth.

Jake's grunts were increasingly desperate, and when at last he urged her to kneel up between us, and withdrew his cock, I had every expectation to see that he had come inside her. He hadn't. His shaft was glistening with her juices, but free of his own cream—and still hard. He stroked it between her legs for a few moments while Hanna stole another kiss of my mouth, but then she was lying down on her back, her head turning toward Jake at the end of the bed, taking his stiff cock into her mouth. Her thighs parted to present her pussy to me.

I caught my breath at the sight of it—red, puffy, dripping wet, gaping from their sex. I ducked down, drew in a deep chestful of that earthy, dangerous scent. I kissed her at the apex of her open sex, and she moaned at the contact, at the heat of my mouth. It was just intoxicating, my Hanna's adulterous pussy, close-up.

I made her moan with my mouth, I made her lose focus on her sucking of Jake's cock.

I made her come first.

Then Jake urged me up with a quick hand signal, and told me in no uncertain terms: 'Fuck her. Now.'

She went on all fours again. Jake, perhaps unexpectedly, retreated to the armchair to watch as I slid into her from behind, grabbing her hips and thrusting my full length into her as hard as I could. Sitting there, stroking his impressive manhood, Jake obviously had no problem with being naked in front of another guy, but he was clearly still testing himself out, making sure he could handle this. He passed with flying colors, apparently finding it arousing enough to watch Hanna being taken right in front of him.

Hanna seemed in heaven, and I'm not just saying that because I was fucking her. She liked watching him watching her. Seeing how hard he was to see her like this. She watched him as closely as he watched her, and their eyes were on each other.

After a while he stood, and brought his hardness to her again, stroking it against her cheeks, touching its tip to her lips. She stretched her lips around it, and I was gone, warning them that I was going to come, there was no way back for me.

'Go ahead,' Jake said, and there wasn't really time to question what he wanted. I held Hanna's hips and just exploded into her.

He didn't seem to mind. I don't think it actively got him going, watching me coming inside her. Not the way it got me going to watch him coming inside her. When I was sitting in that chair, and she was straddling him, bouncing hard, so hard her body made a slapping sound each time she came down on him, watching him bring her to orgasm, and then loose off inside her—well, that just about made me hard all over again.

We ended up in the shower, Hanna washing us both, both of us washing Hanna, then once we were clean Jake left the two of us there so that she could finish me off.

'How are you doing?' she asked me, quietly, as I held her close and slid inside her.

'Never better,' I said.

'Even if I do have feelings for him?' she asked.

'He's a nice guy,' I said, and I had to admit to myself I still had some mild hints of anxiety about that one factor.

How long would she feel this way about Jake? Forever? Was this 'til death do all of us part? What if one of us three did get tired of the arrangement?

I wonder if Hanna could tell how I felt. She looked me in the eye and said, 'You'll always be my husband. He'll only ever be my boyfriend.'

I smiled. ‘We’re going to need a bigger bed.’

About the Author

Max Sebastian is a thirty-something writer, author and occasional journalist who lives in London with his wife and two children. He has been writing erotica for more than 15 years, starting out at the website Literotica.com before joining the indie publishing revolution in late 2011.

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目录

Author's Note	5
Part One: High Stakes	6
Chapter One	7
Chapter Two	13
Chapter Three	21
Chapter Four	27
Chapter Five	33
Chapter Six	41
Chapter Seven	48
Chapter Eight	53
Part Two: Dealer's Choice	58
Chapter Nine	59
Chapter Ten	67
Chapter Eleven	76
Chapter Twelve	82
Chapter Thirteen	89
Chapter Fourteen	96
Chapter Fifteen	102
Chapter Sixteen	108
Chapter Seventeen	112
Chapter Eighteen	118
Chapter Nineteen	127
Chapter Twenty	131
Chapter Twenty-One	140
Chapter Twenty-Two	148
Chapter Twenty-Three	153

Part Three: All In	161
Chapter Twenty-Four	162
Chapter Twenty-Five	167
Chapter Twenty-Six	172
About the Author	184
Get your free Max Sebastian ebook...	185
Also by Max Sebastian	186